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The University of Alabama

Department of Anthropology

ANTHROPOLOGICAL THEORIES

A GUIDE PREPARED BY STUDENTS FOR STUDENTS

The guides to anthropological theories and approaches listed below have been prepared by graduate students of the University of Alabama under the direction of Dr. Michael D. Murphy. As always, *!Caveat Retis Viator!* (Let the Net Traveller Beware!)

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Postmodernism and Its Critics

Daniel Salberg and Robert Stewart and Karla Wesley and Shannon Weiss

(Note: authorship is arranged stratigraphically with the most recent author listed first)

Basic Premises:

As an intellectual movement postmodernism was born as a challenge to several modernist themes that were first articulated during the Enlightenment. These include scientific positivism, the inevitability of human progress, and the potential of human reason to address any essential truth of physical and social conditions and thereby make them amenable to rational control (Boyne and Rattansi 1990). The **primary tenets** of the postmodern movement include: (1) an elevation of text and language as the fundamental phenomena of existence, (2) the application of literary analysis to all phenomena, (3) a questioning of reality and representation, (4) a critique of metanarratives, (5) an argument against method and evaluation, (6) a focus upon power relations and hegemony, (7) and a general critique of Western institutions and knowledge (Kuznar 2008:78). For his part, Lawrence Kuznar labels postmodern anyone whose thinking includes most or all of these elements. Importantly, the term postmodernism refers to a broad range of artists, academic critics, philosophers, and social scientists that Christopher Butler (2003:2) has only half-jokingly alluded to as like "a loosely constituted and quarrelsome political party." The anthropologist Melford Spiro defines postmodernism thusly:

The postmodernist critique of science consists of two interrelated arguments, epistemological and ideological. Both are based on subjectivity. First, because of the subjectivity of the human object, anthropology, according to the epistemological argument cannot be a science; and in any event the subjectivity of the human subject precludes the possibility of science discovering objective truth. Second, since objectivity is an illusion, science according to the ideological argument, subverts oppressed groups, females, ethnics, third-world peoples. [Spiro 1996: 759]

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Nietzsche's assertions regarding truth, language, and society, which opened the door for all later postmodern and late modern critiques about the foundations of knowledge (Kuznar 2008: 78). Nietzsche asserted that truth was simply:

a mobile army of metaphors, metonyms, and anthropomorphisms – in short, a sum of human relations, which have been enhanced, transposed, and embellished poetically and rhetorically, and which after long use seem firm, canonical, and obligatory to a people: truths are illusions about which one has forgotten that this is what they are. [Nietzsche 1954: 46-47]

According to Kuznar, postmodernists trace this skepticism about truth and the resulting relativism it engenders from Nietzsche to Max Weber and Sigmund Freud, and finally to Jacques Derrida, Michel Foucault and other contemporary postmodernists (2008:78).

Postmodernism and anthropology **-** Postmodern attacks on ethnography are generally based on the belief that there is no true objectivity and that therefore the authentic implementation of the scientific method is impossible. For instance, Isaac Reed (2010) conceptualizes the postmodern challenge to the objectivity of social research as skepticism over the anthropologist's ability to integrate the context of investigation and the context of explanation. Reed defines the context of investigation as the social and intellectual context of the investigator – essentially her social identity, beliefs and memories. The context of explanation, on the other hand, refers to the reality that she wishes to investigate, and in particular the social actions she wishes to explain and the surrounding social environment, or context, that she explains them with. In the late 1970s and 1980s some anthropologists, such as Crapanzano and Rabinow, began to express elaborate self-doubt concerning the validity of fieldwork. By the mid-1980s the critique about how anthropologists interpreted and explained the Other, essentially how they engaged in "writing culture," had become a full-blown epistemic crisis that Reed refers to as the "postmodern" turn. The driving force behind the postmodern turn was a deep skepticism about whether the investigator could adequately, effectively, or honestly integrate the context of investigation into the context of explanation and, as a result, write true social knowledge. This concern was most prevalent in cultural and linguistic anthropology, less so in archaeology, and had the least effect on physical anthropology, which is generally the most scientific of the four subfields.

Modernity first came into being with the Renaissance. Modernity implies "the progressive economic and administrative rationalization and differentiation of the social world" (Sarup 1993). In essence this term emerged in the context of the development of the capitalist state. The fundamental act of modernity is to question the foundations of past knowledge, and Boyne and Rattansi characterize modernity as consisting of two sides: "the progressive union of scientific objectivity and politico-economic rationality . . . mirrored in disturbed visions of unalleviated existential despair" (1990: 5).

Postmodernity is the state or condition of being postmodern. Logically *post*modernism literally means "after modernity. It refers to the incipient or actual dissolution of those social forms associated with modernity" (Sarup 1993). The archaeologist Mathew Johnson has characterized postmodernity, or the postmodern condition, as disillusionment with Enlightenment ideals (Johnson 2010). Jean-Francois Lyotard, in his seminal work *The Postmodern Condition* (1984) defines it as an "incredulity toward metanarratives," which is, somewhat ironically, a product of scientific progress (1984: xxiv). Postmodernity concentrates on the tensions of difference and similarity erupting from processes of globalization and capitalism: the accelerating circulation of people, the increasingly dense and frequent cross-cultural interactions, and the unavoidable intersections of local and global knowledge.

Some social critics have attempted to explain the postmodern condition in terms of the historical and social milieu which spawned it. David Ashley (1990) suggests that "modern, overloaded individuals, desperately trying to maintain rootedness and integrity . . . ultimately are pushed to the point where there is little reason not to believe that all value-orientations are equally well-founded. Therefore, increasingly, choice becomes meaningless." Jean Baudrillard, one of the most radical postmodernists, writes that we must come to terms with the second revolution: "that of the Twentieth Century, of postmodernity, which is the immense process of the destruction of meaning equal to the earlier destruction of appearances. Whoever lives by meaning dies by meaning" ([Baudrillard 1984:38-39] in Ashley 1990).

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Modernism should be considered distinct from the concept of "modernity." . Although in its broadest definition modernism refers to modern thought, character or practice, the term is usually restricted to a set of artistic, musical, literary, and more generally aesthetic movements that emerged in Europe in the late nineteenth century and would become institutionalized in the academic institutions and art galleries of post-World War I Europe and America (Boyne and Rattansi 1990). Important figures include Matisse, Picasso, and Kandinsky in painting, Joyce and Kafka in literature, and Eliot and Pound in poetry. It can be characterized by self-consciousness, the alienation of the integrated subject, and reflexiveness, as well as by a general critique of modernity's claims regarding the progressive capacity of science and the efficacy of metanarratives. These themes are very closely related to Postmodernism (Boyne and Rattansi 1990: 6-8; Sarup 1993).

Postmodernism - Sarup maintains that "There is a sense in which if one sees modernism as the culture of modernity, postmodernism is the culture of postmodernity" (1993). The term "postmodernism" is somewhat controversial since many doubt whether it can ever be dignified by conceptual coherence. For instance, it is difficult to reconcile postmodernist approaches in fields like art and music to certain postmodern trends in philosophy, sociology, and anthropology. However, it is in some sense unified by a commitment to a set of cultural projects privileging heterogeneity, fragmentation, and difference, as well as a relatively widespread mood in literary theory, philosophy, and the social sciences that question the possibility of impartiality, objectivity, or authoritative knowledge (Boyne and Rattansi 1990: 9-11).

The following are some proposed differences between modern and postmodern thought: Contrast of Modern and Postmodern Thinking

	Modern	Postmodern
Reasoning	From foundation upwards	Multiple factors of multiple levels of reasoning. Web-oriented.
Science	Universal Optimism	Realism of Limitations
Part/Whole	Parts comprise the whole	The whole is more than the parts
God	Acts by violating "natural" laws" or by "immanence" in everything that is	Top-Down causation
Language	Referential	Meaning in social context through usage

Source: http://private.fuller.edu/~clameter/phd/postmodern.html (note: this link is no longer working as of 4/30/2012)

Points of Reaction:

"Modernity" takes its Latin origin from "modo," which means "just now." The Postmodern, then, literally means "after just now" (Appignanesi and Garratt 1995). Points of reaction from within postmodernism are associated with other "posts": postcolonialism, poststructuralism, and postprocessualism.

Postcolonialism

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3. A description of discourses informed by psychological and epistemological orientations.

Edward Said's *Culture and Imperialism* (1993) uses discourse analysis and postcolonial theory as tools for rethinking forms of knowledge and the social identities of postcolonial systems. An important feature of postcolonialist thought is its assertion that modernism and modernity are part of the colonial project of domination.

Debates about postcolonialism are unresolved, yet issues raised in Said's *Orientalism* (1978), a critique of Western descriptions of Non-Euro-American Others, suggest that colonialism as a discourse is based on the ability of Westerners to examine other societies in order to produce knowledge and use it as a form of power deployed against the very subjects of inquiry. As should be readily apparent, the issues of postcolonialism are uncomfortably relevant to contemporary anthropological investigations.

Poststructuralism

In reaction to the abstraction of cultural data characteristic of model building, cultural relativists argue that model building hindered understanding of thought and action. From this claim arose poststructuralist concepts such as developed in the work of Pierre Bourdieu (1972). He asserts that structural models should not be replaced but enriched. Poststructuralists like Bourdieu are concerned with reflexivity and the search for logical practice. By doing so, accounts of the participants' behavior and meanings are not objectified by the observer. (For definition of reflexivity, see key concepts). In general postructuralism expresses disenchantment with static, mechanistic, and controlling models of culture, instead privileging social process and agency.

Postprocessualism

Unlike postcolonialism and poststructuralism, which are trends among cultural anthropologists, postprocessualism is a trend among archaeologists. Postprocessualists "use deconstructionist skeptical arguments to conclude that there is no objective past and that our representations of the past are only texts that we produce on the basis of our socio-political standpoints(Harris 1999).

Leading Figures:

Michael Agar Agar is critical of traditional scholarly studies related to the social world for two reasons. Firstly, he feels that it is far too difficult to reconstruct human interactions based on notes in a meaningful way. Secondly, he feels that American anthropology tends to draw a barrier between "applied" and "practiced" work (Agar 1997). This effectively means that those who are currently paid to teach anthropology in an academic setting have become out of touch with the current state of scholarship being done by "practitioners" whose positions within academia are far less secure, having not yet attained status in a university setting. To define this distinction he uses the terms "slave labor academic instructors" and "practitioner civil servants."

Jean Baudrillard (1929 - 2007) Baudrillard was a sociologist who began his career exploring the Marxist critique of capitalism (Sarup 1993: 161). During this phase of his work he argued that, "consumer objects constitute a system of signs that differentiate the population" (Sarup 1993: 162). Eventually, however, Baudrillard felt that Marxist tenets did not effectively evaluate commodities, so he turned to postmodernism. Rosenau labels Baudrillard as a skeptical postmodernist because of statements like, "everything has already happened....nothing new can occur," and "there is no real world" (Rosenau 1992: 64, 110). Baudrillard breaks down modernity and postmodernity in an effort to explain the world as a set of models. He identifies early modernity as the period between the Renaissance and the Industrial Revolution, modernity as the period at the start of the Industrial Revolution, and postmodernity as the period of mass media (cinema and photography). Baudrillard states that we live in a world of images but images that are only simulations. Baudrillard implies that many people fail to understand this concept that, "we have now moved into an epoch...where truth is entirely a product of consensus values, and where 'science' itself is just the name we attach to certain modes of explanation," (Norris 1990: 169).

Jacques Derrida (1930 - 2004) Derrida is identified as a poststructuralist and a skeptical postmodernist. Much of his writing is concerned with the deconstruction of texts and probing the relationship of meaning between texts (Bishop 1996: 1270). He observes that "a text employs its own stratagems against it, producing a force of

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Norris, "He tries to problematize the grounds of reason, truth, and knowledge...he questions the highest point by demanding reasoning for reasoning itself," (1990: 199).

Michel Foucault (1926 - 1984) - Foucault was a French philosopher who attempted to show that what most people think of as the permanent truths of human nature and society actually change throughout the course of history. While challenging the influences of Marx and Freud, Foucault postulated that everyday practices enabled people to define their identities and systemize knowledge. Foucault is considered a postmodern theorist precisely because his work upset the conventional understanding of history as a chronology of inevitable facts. Alternatively, he depicted history as existing under layers of suppressed and unconscious knowledge in and throughout history. These under layers are the codes and assumptions of order, the structures of exclusion that legitimate the epistemes by which societies achieve identities (Appignanesi 1995: 83, http://www.connect.net/ron).In addition to these insights, Foucault's study of power and its shifting patterns is one of the foundations of postmodernism. Foucault believed that power was inscribed in everyday life to the extent that many social roles and institutions bore the stamp of power, specifically as it could be used to regulate social hierarchies and structures. These could be regulated though control of the conditions in which "knowledge," "truth," and socially accepted "reality" were produced (Erikson and Murphy 2010: 272).

Clifford Geertz (1926 - 2006) Geertz was a prominent anthropologist best known for his work with religion. He was somewhat ambivalent about Postmodernism. He divided it into two movements that both came to fruition in the 1980s. Geertz describes these as follows:

The first led off into essentially literary matters: authorship, genre, style, narrative, metaphor, representation, discourse, fiction, figuration, persuasion; the second, into essentially political matters: the social foundations of anthropological authority, the modes of power inscribed in its practices, its ideological assumptions, its complicity with colonialism, racism, exploitation, and exoticism, its dependency on the master narratives of Westerns self-understanding. These interlinked critiques of anthropology, the one inward-looking and brooding, the other outward-looking and recriminatory, may not have produced the 'fully dialectical ethnography acting powerfully in the postmodern world system,' to quote that Writing Culture blast again, nor did they exactly go unresisted. But they did induce a certain self-awareness and a certain candor also, into a discipline not without need of them.. [Geertz 2002: 11]

Ian Hodder (1948 -) Hodder is one of the founders of postprocessualism and is generally considered one of the most influential archaeologists of the last thirty years. The postprocessual movement arose out of an attempt to apply insights gained from French Marxist anthropology to the study of material culture and was highly influenced by a postmodern epistemology. Working in sub-Sahara Africa, Hodder and his students documented how material culture was not merely a reflection of sociopolitical organization, but was also an active element that could be used to disguise, invert, and distort social relations. Bruce Trigger (2006:481) has argued that perhaps the most successful "law" developed in recent archaeology was this demonstration that material culture plays an active role in social strategies and hence can alter as well as reflect social reality.

Nancy Scheper-Hughes (1944-) Scheper-Hughes is a professor of Anthropology at the University of California, Berkeley. In her work "Primacy of the Ethical" Scheper-Hughes argues that, "If we cannot begin to think about social institutions and practices in moral or ethical terms, then anthropology strikes me as quite weak and useless." (1995: 410). She advocates that ethnographies be used as tools for critical reflection and human liberation because she feels that "ethics" make culture possible. Since culture is preceded by ethics, therefore ethics cannot be culturally bound as argued by anthropologists in the past. These philosophies are evident in her other works such as, "Death Without Weeping." The crux of her postmodern perspective is that, "Anthropologists, no less than any other professionals, should be held accountable for how we have used and how we have failed to use anthropology as a critical tool at crucial historical moments. It is the act of "witnessing" that lends our word its moral, at times almost theological, character." (1995: 419)

Jean-Francois Lyotard (1924 – 1998) Lyotard was the author of a highly influential work on postmodern society called, *The Postmodern Condition* (1984). The work was a critique on the current state of knowledge among modern postindustrial nations such as those found in the United States and much of Western Europe. In it Lyotard made a number of notable arguments, one of which was that the postmodern world suffered from a crisis of

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refuses the consolation of correct forms, refuses the consensus of taste permitting a common experience of nostalgia for the impossible, and inquires into new presentations--not to take pleasure in them, but to better produce the feeling that there is something unpresentable.[Lyotard 1984]

Lyotard also attacked modernist thought as epitomized by "Grand" Narratives or what he termed the Meta(master) narrative (Lyotard 1984). In contrast to the ethnographies written by anthropologists in the first half of the 20th Century, Lyotard states that an all-encompassing account of a culture cannot be accomplished.

Key Works:

- Baudrillard, Jean (1995) *Simulacra and Simulation*. Translated by Sheila Faria Glaser. Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press.
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- Marcus, George E. and Michael M. J. Fischer (1986) *Anthropology as Cultural Critique. An Experimental Moment in the Human Sciences*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
- Norris, Christopher (1979) *Deconstruction: Theory and Practice*. New York: Routledge.
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- Vattimo, Gianni (1988) *The End of Modernity: Nihilism and Hermeneutics*. In Post-Modern Critique. London: Polity.

- Modernity: Nihilism and Hermeneutics. In Post-Modern Critique. London: Polity.

Principal Concepts:

"Culture" in Peril - Aside from Foucault, other postmodernists felt that "Culture is becoming a dangerously unfocused term, increasingly lacking in scientific credentials" (Pasquinelli 1996). The concept of Culture as a whole was tied not only to modernity, but to evolutionary theory (and, implicitly, to euro centrism). In the postmodernist view, if "culture" existed it had to be totally relativistic without any suggestion of "progress." While postmodernists did have a greater respect for later revisions of cultural theory by Franz Boas and his followers, who attempted to shift from a single path of human "culture" to many varied "cultures," they found even this unsatisfactory because it still required the use of a Western concept to define non-Western people.

Lament - Lament is a practice of ritualized weeping (Wilce 2005). In the view of Wilce, the traditional means of laments in many cultures were being forced out by modernity due to many claiming that ritualized displays of discontent, particularly discontent with the lost of traditional culture, was a "backwards" custom that needed to be stopped.

Metanarrative Lawrence Kuznar describes metanarratives as grand narratives such as the Enlightenment, Marxism or the American dream. Postmodernists see metanarratives as unfairly totalizing or naturalizing in their generalizations about the state of humanity and historical process (2008:83).

Polyvocality **-** Paralleling the generally relatativst and skeptical attitudes towards scientific authority, many postmodernists advocate polyvocality, which maintains that there exists multiple, legitimate versions of reality or truths as seen from different perspectives. Postmodernists construe Enlightenment rationalism and scientific positivism as an effort to impose hegemonic values and political control on the world. By challenging the

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"power" as the major focus of anthropological research (Barrett 2001). Foucault felt that it was through the dynamics of power that "a human being turns himself into a subject" (Foucault 1982). This is not only true of political power, but also includes people recognizing things such as sexuality as forces to which they are subject. "The exercise of power is not simply a relationship between partners, individual or collective; it is a way in which certain actions modify others. Which is to say, of course, that something called Power, with or without a capital letter, which is assumed to exist universally in a concentrated or diffused form, does not exist" (Foucault 1982: 788).

Radical skepticism - The systematic skepticism of grounded theoretical perspectives and objective truths espoused by many postmodernists had a profound effect on anthropology. This skepticism has shifted focus from the observation of a particular society to a reflexive consideration of the (anthropological) observer (Bishop 1996). According to Rosenau (1992), postmodernists can be divided into two very broad camps, Skeptics and Affirmatives.

- Skeptical Postmodernists – They are extremely critical of the modern subject. They consider the subject to be a "linguistic convention" (Rosenau 1992:43). They also reject any understanding of time because for them the modern understanding of time is oppressive in that it controls and measures individuals. They reject Theory because theories are abundant, and no theory is considered more correct that any other. They feel that "theory conceals, distorts, and obfuscates, it is alienated, disparate, dissonant, it means to exclude, order, and control rival powers" (Rosenau 1992: 81).
- Affirmative Postmodernists – Affirmatives also reject Theory by denying claims of truth. They do not, however, feel that Theory needs to be abolished but merely transformed. Affirmatives are less rigid than Skeptics. They support movements organized around peace, environment, and feminism (Rosenau 1993: 42).

Realism - "...is the platonic doctrine that universals or abstractions have being independently of mind" (Gellner 1980: 60). Marcus and Fischer note that: "Realism is a mode of writing that seeks to represent the reality of the whole world or form of life. Realist ethnographies are written to allude to a whole by means of parts or foci of analytical attention which can constantly evoke a social and cultural totality (1986: 2323).

Relativism – Relativism is the notion that different perspectives have no absolute truth or validity, but rather possess only relative, subjective value according to distinctions in perception and consideration. Gellner writes about the relativistic-functionalist view of thought that goes back to the Enlightenment: "The (unresolved) dilemma, which the thought of the Enlightenment faced, was between a relativistic-functionalist view of thought, and the absolutist claims of enlightened Reason. Viewing man as part of nature...requires (us) to see cognitive and evaluative activities as part of nature too, and hence varying from organism to organism and context to context. (Gellner in [Asad 1986: 147]). Anthropological theory of the 1960s may be best understood as the heir of relativism. Contemporary interpretative anthropology is the essence of relativism as a mode of inquiry about communication in and between cultures (Marcus & Fischer, 1986:32).

Self-Reflexivity - In anthropology, self-reflexivity refers to the anthropologists in the process of question, both theoretically and practically, themselves and their work. Bishop notes that, "The scientific observer's objectification of structure as well as strategy was seen as placing the actors in a framework not of their own making but one produced by the observer, " (1996: 1270). Self-Reflexivity therefore leads to a consciousness of the process of knowledge creation (1996: 995). There is an increased awareness of the collection of data and the limitation of methodological systems. This idea underlies the postmodernist affinity for studying the culture of anthropology and ethnography.

Methodologies:

One of the essential elements of Postmodernism is that it constitutes **an attack against theory and methodology**. In a sense proponents claim to relinquish all attempts to create new knowledge in a systematic fashion, instead substituting an "anti-rules" fashion of discourse (Rosenau 1993:117). Despite this claim, however, there are two methodologies characteristic of Postmodernism. These methodologies are interdependent in that interpretation is inherent in Deconstruction. "Post-modern methodology is post-positivist or anti-positivist. As substitutes for the scientific method the affirmatives look to feelings and personal experience. . . the skeptical

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text to reveal internal arbitrary hierarchies and presuppositions. By examining the margins of a text, the effort of deconstruction examines what it represses, what it does not say, and its incongruities. It does not solely unmask error, but redefines the text by undoing and reversing polar opposites. Deconstruction does not resolve inconsistencies, but rather exposes hierarchies involved for the distillation of information (Rosenau 1993).

Rosenau's Guidelines for Deconstruction Analysis:

- Find an exception to a generalization in a text and push it to the limit so that this generalization appears absurd. Use the exception to undermine the principle.
- Interpret the arguments in a text being deconstructed in their most extreme form.
- Avoid absolute statements and cultivate intellectual excitement by making statements that are both startling and sensational.
- Deny the legitimacy of dichotomies because there are always a few exceptions.
- Nothing is to be accepted, nothing is to be rejected. It is extremely difficult to criticize a deconstructive argument if no clear viewpoint is expressed.
- Write so as to permit the greatest number of interpretations possible.....Obscurity may "protect from serious scrutiny" (Ellis 1989: 148). The idea is "to create a text without finality or completion, one with which the reader can never be finished" (Wellberg, 1985: 234).
- Employ new and unusual terminology in order that "familiar positions may not seem too familiar and otherwise obvious scholarship may not seem so obviously relevant"(Ellis 1989: 142).
- "Never consent to a change of terminology and always insist that the wording of the deconstructive argument is sacrosanct." More familiar formulations undermine any sense that the deconstructive position is unique (Ellis 1989: 145). (Rosenau 1993, p.121)

Intuitive Interpretation - Rosenau notes that, "Postmodern interpretation is introspective and anti-objectivist which is a form of individualized understanding. It is more a vision than data observation. In anthropology interpretation gravitates toward narrative and centers on listening to and talking with the other, "(1993:119). For postmodernists there are an endless number of interpretations. Foucault argues that everything is interpretation (Dreyfus and Rabinow 1983: 106). "There is no final meaning for any particular sign, no notion of unitary sense of text, no interpretation can be regarded as superior to any other" (Latour 1988: 182-3). Anti-positivists defend the notion that every interpretation is false. "Interpretative anthropology is a covering label for a diverse set of reflections upon the practice of ethnography and the concept of culture" (Marcus and Fisher 1986: 60).

Accomplishments:

Critical Examination of Ethnographic Explanation - The unrelenting re-examination of the nature of ethnography inevitably leads to a questioning of ethnography itself as a mode of cultural analysis. Postmodernism adamantly insists that anthropologists must consider the role of their own culture in the explanation of the "other" cultures being studied. Postmodernist theory has led to a heightened sensitivity within anthropology to the collection of data.

Demystification - Perhaps the greatest accomplishments of postmodernism is the focus upon uncovering and criticizing the epistemological and ideological motivations in the social sciences, as well as the increased attention to the factors contributing to the production of knowledge.

Polyvocality – The self-reflexive regard for the ways in which social knowledge is produced, as well as a general skepticism regarding the objectivity and authority of scientific knowledge, has led to an increased appreciation for the voice of the anthropological Other. Even if we do not value all interpretations as equally valid for whatever reason, today it is generally recognized (although perhaps not always done in practice) that anthropologists must actively consider the perspectives and wellbeing of the people being studied.

Criticisms:

Roy D'Andrade (1931-) - In the article "Moral Models in Anthropology," D'Andrade critiques postmodernism's definition of objectivity and subjectivity by examining the moral nature of their models. He argues that these moral models are purely subjective. D'Andrade argues that despite the fact that utterly value-free objectivity is

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because it produces unbiased accounts but because its accounts are objective enough to be proved or disproved no matter what anyone wants to be true." (D'Andrade 1995: 404).

Ryan Bishop - "The Postmodernist genre of ethnography has been criticized for fostering a self-indulgent subjectivity, and for exaggerating the esoteric and unique aspects of a culture at the expense of more prosiac but significant questions." (Bishop 1996: 58)

Patricia M. Greenfield Greenfield believes that postmodernism's complete lack of objectivity, and its tendency to push political agendas, makes it virtually useless in any scientific investigation (Greenfield 2005). Greenfield suggests using resources in the field of psychology to help Anthropologists gain a better grasp on cultural relativism, while still maintaining their objectivity.

Bob McKinley **-** McKinley believes that Postmodernism is more of a religion than a science (McKinley 2000). He argues that the origin of Postmodernism is the Western emphasis on individualism, which makes Postmodernists reluctant to acknowledge the existence of distinct multi-individual cultures.

Christopher Norris - Norris believes that Lyotard, Foucault, and Baudrillard are too preoccupied in the idea of the primacy of moral judgments (Norris 1990: 50).

Pauline Rosenau (1993) Rosenau identifies seven contradictions in Postmodernism:

1. Its anti-theoretical position is essentially a theoretical stand.
2. While Postmodernism stresses the irrational, instruments of reason are freely employed to advance its perspective.
3. The Postmodern prescription to focus on the marginal is itself an evaluative emphasis of precisely the sort that it otherwise attacks.
4. Postmodernism stress intertextuality but often treats text in isolation.
5. By adamantly rejecting modern criteria for assessing theory, Postmodernists cannot argue that there are no valid criteria for judgment.
6. Postmodernism criticizes the inconsistency of modernism, but refuses to be held to norms of consistency itself.
7. Postmodernists contradict themselves by relinquishing truth claims in their own writings.

Marshall Sahlins (1930 -)**-** Sahlins criticizes the postmodern preoccupation with power. "The current Foucauldian-Gramscian-Nietzschean obsession with power is the latest incarnation of anthropology's incurable functionalism. . . Now 'power' is the intellectual black hole into which all kinds of cultural contents get sucked, if before it was social solidarity or material advantage." (Sahlins, 1993: 15).

Melford Spiro (1920 -) - Spiro argues that postmodern anthropologists do not convincingly dismiss the scientific method (1996). Further, he suggests that if anthropology turns away from the scientific method then anthropology will become the study of meanings and not the discovery of causes that shape what it is to be human. Spiro further states that, "the causal account of culture refers to ecological niches, modes of production, subsistence techniques, and so forth, just as a causal account of mind refers to the firing of neurons, the secretions of hormones, the action of neurotransmitters . . ." (1996: 765).

Spiro critically addresses six interrelated propositions from John Searle's 1993 work, "Rationality and Realism":

1. Reality exists independently of human representations. If this is true then, contrary to postmodernism, this postulate supports the existence of "mind-independent external reality" which is called "metaphysical realism".
2. Language communicates meanings but also refers to objects and situations in the world which exist independently of language. Contrary to postmodernism, this postulate supports the concept of language as have communicative and referential functions.
3. Statements are true or false depending on whether the objects and situations to which they refer correspond to a greater or lesser degree to the statements. This "correspondence theory" of truth is to some extent the

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researcher to assess competing knowledge claims through proof, validity, and reason.
6. Objective and intersubjective criteria judge the merit of statements, theories, interpretations, and all accounts.

Spiro specifically assaults the assumption that the disciplines that study humanity, like anthropology, cannot be "scientific" because subjectivity renders observers incapable of discovering truth. Spiro agrees with postmodernists that the social sciences require very different techniques for the study of humanity than do the natural sciences, but while insight and empathy are critical in the study of mind and culture, intellectual responsibility requires objective (scientific methods) in the social sciences (Spiro 1996)

Comments:

Schematic Differences between Modernism and Postmodernism	
Modernism	**Postmodernism**
romanticism/symbolism	paraphysics/Dadaism
purpose	play
design	chance
hierarchy	anarchy
matery, logos	exhaustion, silence
art object, finished word	process, performance
distance	participation
creation, totalization	deconstruction
synthesis	antithesis
presence	absence
centering	dispersal

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paradigm	syntagm
hypotaxis	parataxis
metaphor	metonymy
selection	combination
depth	surface
interpretation	against interpretation
reading	misreading
signified	signifier
lisible (readerly)	scriptible
narrative	anti-narrative
grande histoire	petite histoire
master code	idiolect
symptom	desire
type	mutant
genital, phallic	polymorphous
paranoia	schizophrenia
origin, cause	difference-difference
God the Father	The Holy Ghost

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determinacy	indeterminacy
transcendence	immanence

(SOURCE: Hassan "The Culture of Postmodernism" Theory, Culture, and Society, V 2 1985, 123-4.)

For more information on the foundational theories of Postmodernism, Phenomenology, Existentialism, and Marxism, you may wish to reference such philosophers as Heidegger, Hegel, Marx, and Kant. This information may be accessed easily from the this Web site, http://www.connect/net/ron

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Relevant Web Links:

- Postmodernism Generator:: A little fun with postmodernism. And yes, some of it is almost this bad.
- Postmodern Thought (U of Colorado, Denver): A great source for weblinks on postmodernism.
- After Postmodernism (U of Chicago): What happens after postmodernism?
- The PoMo Page (U of Georgetown): A solid overview on postmodernism.
- Anthrobase Postmodernism Page: An encyclopedia-like description of postmodernism with relevant links.
- Writing, General Knowledge, and Postmodern Anthropology: An essay by Paul Smith.
- Dinosaur Comic on Postmodernism: Pretty self explanatory.
- Postmodernisnm and Psychology

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The University of Alabama

Department of Anthropology

ANTHROPOLOGICAL THEORIES

A GUIDE PREPARED BY STUDENTS FOR STUDENTS

The guides to anthropological theories and approaches listed below have been prepared by graduate students of the University of Alabama under the direction of Dr. Michael D. Murphy. As always, *!Caveat Retis Viator!* (Let the Net Traveller Beware!)

Select a Theory: Go

OR

Search the theory database

Social Evolutionism

Heather Long and Kelly Chakov

(Note: authorship is arranged stratigraphically with the most recent author listed first)

Basic Premises:

In the early years of anthropology, the prevailing view of anthropologists and other scholars was that culture generally develops (or evolves) in a uniform and progressive manner. The Evolutionists, building from Darwin's theory of evolution and natural selection, sought to track the development of culture through time. Just as species were thought to evolve into increasing complexity, so too were cultures thought to progress from a simple to complex states. It was thought that most societies pass through the same series of stages to arrive, ultimately, at a common end. Change was thought to originate from within the culture, so development was thought to be internally determined.

The evolutionary progression of societies had been accepted by some since The Enlightenment. Both French and Scottish social and moral philosophers were using evolutionary schemes during the 18th century. Among these was Montesquieu, who proposed an evolutionary scheme consisting of three stages: hunting or savagery, herding or barbarism, and civilization. This division became very popular among the 19th century social theorists, with figures such as Tylor and Morgan in adopting this scheme (Seymour-Smith 1986:105).

By the middle of the nineteenth century, Europe had successfully explored, conquered and colonized many heretofore unknown and alien parts of the globe. This global movement led to products and peoples that lived quite different lifestyles than the Europeans and proved politically and scientifically problematic. The discipline of anthropology, beginning with these early social theories arose largely in response to this

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was fundamental to the new ideas of the nineteenth century social evolutionists. Drawing upon Enlightenment thought, Darwin's work, and new cross-cultural, historical, and archaeological evidence, a whole generation of social evolutionary theorists emerged such as Tylor and Morgan. These theorists developed rival schemes of overall social and cultural progress, as well as the origins of different institutions such as religion, marriage, and the family.

Edward B. Tylor disagreed with the contention of some early-nineteenth-century French and English writers, led by Comte Joseph de Maistre, that groups such as the American Indians and other indigenous peoples were examples of cultural degeneration. He believed that peoples in different locations were equally capable of developing and progressing through the stages. Primitive groups had "reached their position by learning and not by unlearning" (Tylor 2006:36). Tylor maintained that culture evolved from the simple to the complex, and that all societies passed through the three basic stages of development suggested by Montesquieu: from savagery through barbarism to civilization. "Progress," therefore, was possible for all.

To account for cultural variation, Tylor and other early evolutionists postulated that different contemporary societies were at different stages of evolution. According to this view, the "simpler" peoples of the day had not yet reached "higher" stages. Thus, simpler contemporary societies were thought to resemble ancient societies. In more advanced societies one could see proof of cultural evolution through the presence of what Tylor called survivals - traces of earlier customs that survive in present-day cultures. The making of pottery is an example of a survival in the sense used by Tylor. Earlier peoples made their cooking pots out of clay; today we generally make them out of metal because it is more durable, but we still prefer dishes made out of clay.

Tylor believed that there was a kind of psychic unity among all peoples that explained parallel evolutionary sequences in different cultural traditions. In other words, because of the basic similarities in the mental framework of all peoples, different societies often find the same solutions to the same problems independently. But, Tylor also noted that cultural traits may spread from one society to another by simple diffusion - the borrowing by one culture of a trait belonging to another as the result of contact between the two.

Another nineteenth-century proponent of uniform and progressive cultural evolution was Lewis Henry Morgan. A lawyer in upstate New York, Morgan became interested in the local Iroquois Indians and defended their reservation in a land-grant case. In gratitude, the Iroquois adopted Morgan, who regarded them as "noble savages."

In his best-known work, *Ancient Society*, Morgan divided the evolution of human culture into the same three basic stages Tylor had suggested (savagery, barbarism, and civilization). But he also subdivided savagery and barbarism into upper, middle, and lower segments (Morgan 1877: 5-6), providing contemporary examples of each of these three stages. Each stage was distinguished by a technological development and had a correlate in patterns of subsistence, marriage, family, and political organization. In *Ancient Society*, Morgan commented, "As it is undeniable that portions of the human family have existed in a state of savagery, other portions in a state of barbarism, and still others in a state of civilization, it seems equally so that these three distinct conditions are connected with each other in a natural as well as necessary sequence of progress" (Morgan 1877:3).

Morgan distinguished these stages of development in terms of technological achievement, and thus each had its identifying benchmarks. Middle savagery was marked by the acquisition of a fish diet and the discovery of fire; upper savagery by the bow and arrow; lower barbarism by pottery; middle barbarism by animal domestication and irrigated agriculture; upper barbarism by the manufacture of iron; and civilization by the phonetic alphabet (Morgan 1877: chapter 1). For Morgan, the cultural features distinguishing these various stages arose from a "few primary germs of thought"- germs that had emerged while humans were still savages and that later developed into the "principle institutions of mankind."

Morgan postulated that the stages of technological development were associated with a sequence of different cultural patterns. For example, he speculated that the family evolved through six stages. Human society

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lived with other people. In the next stage husband-dominant families arose in which the husband could have more than one wife simultaneously. Finally, the stage of civilization was distinguished by the monogamous family, with just one wife and one husband who were relatively equal in status.

Morgan believed that family units became progressively smaller and more self-contained as human society developed. His postulated sequence for the evolution of the family, however, is not supported by the enormous amount of ethnographic data that has been collected since his time. For example, no recent society that Morgan would call savage indulges in group marriage or allows brother-sister mating.

Although their works reached toward the same end, the evolutionary theorists each had very different ideas and foci for their studies. Differing from Morgan and Tylor, Sir James Frazer focused on the evolution of religion and viewed the progress of society or culture from the viewpoint of the evolution of psychological or mental systems. Among the other evolutionary theorists who put forth schemes of development of society, including different religious, kinship, and legal institution were Maine, McLellan, and Bachofen.

It is important to note that all of the early evolutionary schemes were unilineal. Unilineal evolution refers to the idea that there is a set sequence of stages that all groups will pass through at some point, although progress through these stages will vary. Groups, both past and present, that are at the same level or stage of development were considered nearly identical. Thus a contemporary "primitive"group could be taken as a representative of an earlier stage of development of more advanced types.

The evolutionist program can be more or less summed up in this segment of Tylor's *Primitive Culture* which notes:

- "The condition of culture among the various societies of mankind…is a subject apt for the study of laws of human thought and action. On the one hand, the uniformity which so largely pervades civilization may be ascribed, in great measure, to the uniform action of uniform causes; while on the other hand its various grades may be regarded as stages of development or evolution, each the outcome of previous history, and about to do its proper part in shaping the history of the future (Tylor 1871:1:1)."

Points of Reaction:

One debate arising from the evolutionist perspective was whether civilization had evolved from a state of savagery or had always coexisted with primitive groups. Also the degeneration theory of savagery (that primitives regressed from the civilized state and that primitivism indicated the fall from grace) had to be fought vigorously before social anthropology could progress.

Social evolutionism offered an alternative to the current Christian/theological approach to understanding cultural diversity, and thus encountered more opposition. This new view proposed that evolution was a line of progression in which the lower stages were prerequisite to the upper. This idea seemed to completely contradict traditional ideas about the relationships between God and mankind and the nature of life and progress. Evolutionists criticized the Christian approach as requiring divine revelation to explain civilization.

Reactions within evolutionist thought:

Within the school of social evolution there were debates particularly concerning the most primitive stages of society. It was highly debated as to the order of primitive promiscuity, patriarchy, and matriarchy.

Reactions to evolutionism:

Karl Marx was struck by the parallels between Morgan's evolutionism and his own theory of history. Marx and his co-worker, Friedrich Engels, devised a theory in which the institutions of monogamy, private property, and the state were assumed to be chiefly responsible for the exploitation of the working classes in modern industrialized societies. Marx and Engels extended Morgan's evolutionary scheme to include a future

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leading opponent was Franz Boas, whose main disagreement with the evolutionists involved their assumption that universal laws governed all human culture. Boas argued that these nineteenth-century individuals lacked sufficient data (as did Boas himself) to formulate many useful generalizations. Thus historicism and, later, functionalism were reactions to nineteenth century social evolutionism.

Leading Figures:

- **Johann Jacob Bachofen** (1815-1887). Swiss lawyer and classicist who developed a theory of the evolution of kinship systems. He postulated that primitive promiscuity was first characterized by matriarchy and later by patrilineality. This later stage of patrilineality was developed in relation to Bachofen's theory of the development of private property and the want of man to pass this on to their children. Bachofen's postulation of a patrilianeal stage following a matrilineal stage was agreed upon by Morgan (Seymour-Smith 1986:21).
- **Sir James George Frazer** (1854 - 1873). Educated at Cambridge, he was considered to be the last of the British classical evolutionists. Frazer was an encyclopedic collector of data (although he never did any fieldwork), publishing dozens of volumes including the popular work *The Golden Bough*. Frazer summed up this study of magic and religion by stating that "magic came first in men's minds, then religion, then science, each giving way slowly and incompletely to the other (Hays 1965:127)." First published in two volumes and later expanded to twelve, Frazer's ideas from *The Golden Bough* were widely accepted. Frazer went on to study the value of superstition in the evolution of culture saying that it strengthened the respect for private property, strengthened the respect for marriage, and contributed to the stricter observance of the rules of sexual morality.
- **Sir John Lubbock** (1834-1914; Lord Avebury). Botanist and antiquarian who was a staunch pupil of Darwin. He observed that there was a range of variation of stone implements from more to less crude and that deposits that lay beneath upper deposits seemed older. He coined the terms ‘Paleolithic’ and ‘Neolithic’. The title of Lubbock's book, *Prehistoric Times: As Illustrated by Ancient Remains and the Customs of Modern Savages* illustrates the evolutionists analogies to "stone age contemporaries." This work also countered the degenerationist views in stating "It is common opinion that savages are, as a general rule, only miserable remnants of nations once more civilized; but although there are some well established cases of national decay, there is no scientific evidence which would justify us in asserting that this is generally the case (Hays 1965:51-52)." Lubbock also contributed a gradual evolution of religion, seen in five stages: atheism, nature worship (totemism), shamanism, idolatry, and monotheism.
- **Sir Henry James Sumner Maine** (1822-1888). English jurist and social theorist who focused on the development of legal systems as the key to social evolution. His scheme traces society from systems based on kinship to those based on territoriality, and from status to contract and from civil to criminal law. Maine argued that the most primitive societies were patriarchal. This view contrasted with the believers in the primacy of primitive promiscuity and matriarchy. Maine also contrasted with other evolutionists in that he was not a proponent of unilinear evolution (Seymour-Smith 1986:175-176).
- **John F. McLellan** (1827-1881). Scottish lawyer who was inspired by ethnographic accounts of bride capture. From this he built a theory of the evolution of marriage. Like others, including Bachofen, McLellan postulated an original period of primitive promiscuity followed by matriarchy. His argument began with primitive peoples practicing female infanticide because women did not hunt to support the group. The shortage of women that followed was resolved by the practice of bride capture and fraternal polyandry. These then gave rise to patrilineal descent. McLellan, in his *Primitive Marriage*, coined the terms ‘exogamy’ and ‘endogamy’ (Seymour-Smith 1986:185-186).
- **Lewis Henry Morgan** (1818 - 1881). One of the most influential evolutionary theorists of the 19th century and has been called the father of American anthropology. An American lawyer whose interest in Iroquois Indian affairs led him to study their customs and social system, giving rise to the first modern ethnographic study of a Native American group, the *League of the Iroquois* in 1851. In this, he considered ceremonial, religious, and political aspects and also initiated his study of kinship and marriage which he was later to develop into a comparative theory in his 1871 work, *Systems of Consanguinity and Affinity*. This latter work is also a milestone in the development of anthropology, establishing kinship and marriage as central areas of anthropological inquiry and beginning an

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Morgan subdivided the first two categories into three stages (lower, middle, and upper) and gave contemporary ethnographic examples of each stage. Each stage was characterized by a technological advance and was correlated with advances in subsistence patterns, family and marriage and political organization (Seymour-Smith 1986:201).

- **Sir Edward Burnett Tylor** (1832 - 1917). Put the science of anthropology on a firm basis and discounted the degeneration theory. Tylor formulated a definition of culture: "Culture or civilization is that complex whole which includes knowledge, belief, art, morals, law, custom and any other capabilities and habits acquired by man as a member of society," and also developed the idea of survivals. His major contributions were in the field of religion and mythology, and he cited magic, astrology, and witchcraft as clues to primitive religion. In Tylor's best known work, *Primitive Culture*, he attempts to illuminate the complicated aspects of religious and magical phenomena. It was an impressive and well-reasoned analysis of primitive psychology and far more general in application than anything which had been earlier suggested. Tylor correlates the three levels of social evolution to types of religion: savages practicing animatism, barbarians practicing polytheism, and civilized man practicing monotheism. The primary importance of Tylor in relation to his contemporaries results from his use of statistics in his research.

Key Works:

- Frazer, James George. 1890 [1959]. The New Golden Bough. 1 vol, abr.
- Lubbock, John. 1872. Prehistoric Times: As Illustrated by Ancient Remains and the Manners and Customs of Modern Savages. New York: Appleton.
- Maine, Henry. 1861. Ancient Law.
- McLellan, John. 1865. Primitive Marriage.
- Morgan, Lewis Henry. 1876. Systems of Consanguinity and Affinity of the Human Family.
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- Tylor, Edward B. 1871 [1958]. Primitive Culture. 2 vols. New York: Harper Torchbook.

Principal Concepts:

These terms are added only as a supplement; more elaborate understandings can be discerned from reading the above basic premises:

- **unilinear social evolution** - the notion that culture generally develops (or evolves) in a uniform and progressive manner. It was thought that most societies pass through the same series of stages, to arrive ultimately at a common end. The scheme originally included just three parts, savagery, barbarism, and civilization, but was later subdivided into several to account for a greater cultural diversity.
- **psychic unity of mankind** - the belief that the human mind was everywhere essentially similar. "Some form of psychic unity is …implied whenever there is an emphasis on parallel evolution, for if the different peoples of the world advanced through similar sequences, it must be assumed that they all began with essentially similar psychological potentials (Harris 1968:137)."
- **survivals** - traces of earlier customs that survive in present-day cultures. Tylor formulated the doctrine of survivals in analyzing the symbolic meaning of certain social customs. "Meaningless customs must be survivals, they had a practical or at least a ceremonial intention when and where they first arose, but are now fallen into absurdity from having been carried on into a new state in society where the original sense has been discarded" (Hays 1965: 64).
- **primitive promiscuity** - the theory that the original state of human society was characterized by the lack of incest taboos, or rules regarding sexual relations or marriage. Early anthropologists such as Morgan, McLellan, Bachofen and Frazer held this view. It was opposed on the other hand by those

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was carried into the thinking of the social evolutionists, and in particular Tylor and Morgan.

Methodologies:

The Comparative Method

Harris (1968:150-151) has an excellent discussion of this approach. "…The main stimulus for [the comparative method] came out of biology where zoological and botanical knowledge of extant organisms was routinely applied to the interpretation of the structure and function of extinct fossil forms. No doubt, there were several late-nineteenth-century anthropological applications of this principle which explicitly referred to biological precedent. In the 1860's, however, it was the paleontology of Lyell, rather than of Darwin, that was involved. … John Lubbock justified his attempt to "illustrate" the life of prehistoric times in terms of an explicit analogy with geological practices:

"… the archaeologist is free to follow the methods which have been so successfully pursued in geology - the rude bone and stone implements of bygone ages being to the one what the remains of extinct animals are to the other. The analogy may be pursued even further than this. Many mammalia which are extinct in Europe have representatives still living in other countries. Our fossil pachyderms, for instance, would be almost unintelligible but for the species which still inhabit some parts of Asia and Africa; the secondary marsupials are illustrated by their existing representatives in Australia and South America; and in the same manner, if we wish clearly to understand the antiquities of Europe, we must compare them with the rude implements and weapons still, or until lately, used by the savage races in other parts of the world. In fact, Van Diemaner and South American are to the antiquary what the opossum and the sloth are to the geologist (1865:416)."

All theorists of the latter half of the nineteenth century proposed to fill the gaps in the available knowledge of universal history largely by means of a special and much-debated procedure known as the "comparative method." The basis for this method was the belief that sociocultural systems observable in the present bear differential degrees of resemblance to extinct cultures. The life of certain contemporary societies closely resembled what life must have been like during the Paleolithic, Neolithic, or early state-organized societies. Morgan's view of this prolongation of the past into the present is characteristic:

"…the domestic institutions of the barbarous, and even of the savage ancestors of mankind, are still exemplified in portions of the human family with such completeness that, with the exception of the strictly primitive period, the several stages of this progress are tolerably well preserved. They are seen in the organization of society upon the basis of sex, then upon the basis of kin, and finally upon the basis of territory; through the successive forms of marriage and of the family, with the systems of consanguinity thereby created; through house life and architecture; and through progress in usages with respect to the ownership and inheritance of property." (1870:7)

To apply the comparative method, the varieties of contemporary institutions are arranged in a sequence of increasing antiquity. This is achieved through an essentially logical, deductive operation. The implicit assumption is that the older forms are the simpler forms.

Accomplishments:

The early evolutionists represented the first efforts to establish a scientific discipline of anthropology (although this effort was greatly hampered by the climate of supernatural explanations, a paucity of reliable empirical materials, and their engagement in "armchair speculation"). They aided in the development of the foundations of an organized discipline where none had existed before. They left us a legacy of at least three basic assumptions which have become an integral part of anthropological thought and research methodology:

- the dictum that cultural phenomena are to be studied in naturalistic fashion
- the premise of the "psychic unity of mankind," i.e., that cultural differences between groups are not due to differences in psychobiological equipment but to differences in sociocultural experience; and

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Criticisms:

Morgan believed that family units became progressively smaller and more self-contained as human society developed. However, his postulated sequence for the evolution of the family is not supported by the enormous amount of ethnographic data that has been collected since his time. For example, no recent society that Morgan would call savage indulges in group marriage or allows brother-sister mating.

A second criticism is for the use by Tylor, McLellan, and others of 'recurrence' - if a similar belief or custom could be found in different cultures in many parts of the world, then it was considered to be a valid clue for reconstructing the history of the development, spread, and contact in human societies. The great weakness of this method lay in the evaluation of evidence plucked out of context, and in the fact that much of the material, at a time when there were almost no trained field workers, came from amateur observers.

The evolutionism of Tylor, Morgan, and others of the nineteenth century is largely rejected today largely because their theories cannot satisfactorily account for cultural variation - why, for instance, some societies today are in "upper savagery" and others in "civilization." The "psychic unity of mankind" or "germs of thought" that were postulated to account for parallel evolution cannot also account for cultural differences. Another weakness in the early evolutionists' theories is that they cannot explain why some societies have regressed or even become extinct. Also, although other societies may have progressed to "civilization," some of them have not passed through all the stages. Thus, early evolutionist theory cannot explain the details of cultural evolution and variation as anthropology now knows them. Finally, one of the most common criticisms leveled at the nineteenth century evolutionists is that they were highly ethnocentric - they assumed that Victorian England, or its equivalent, represented the highest level of development for mankind.

"[The] unilineal evolutionary schemes [of these theorists] fell into disfavor in the 20th century, partly as a result of the constant controversy between evolutionist and diffusionist theories and partly because of the newly accumulating evidence about the diversity of specific sociocultural systems which made it impossible to sustain the largely "armchair" speculations of these early theorists" (Seymour-Smith 1986:106).

Comments:

Harris called Morgan and Tylor racists (1968:137,140), but they were some of the great thinkers of their time. Today, students continue to learn Tylor's definition of culture and all cultural anthropology classes discuss Morgan's stages of development. These men got the ball rolling in terms of anthropological theory. Their works represent the some of the earliest attempts to understand culture. These theories caused a new wave of thinking by people who agreed and changed their views and also by people who disagreed and came up with new theories to replace those of the evolutionists.Regardless of how their opinions of other cultures is viewed today, they were able to accumulate a vast body of knowledge of non-Western groups. The work of the nineteenth century social evolutionists represents an important step toward the field of anthropology today.

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Relevant Web Links:

- Social Evolution (not just the human variety)
- Sociocultural Evolution
- Evolutionism
- Nineteenth-century Evolution
- Cultural Evolution – Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy
- Evolutionism - Wikipedia
- Unilineal Evolution - Wikipedia
- Cultural Evolution

Lewis Henry Morgan

- Lewis Henry Morgan: A Founding Figure
- Lewis Henry Morgan entry in Encyclopedia Britannica
- Lewis Henry Morgan – Wikipedia

E.B. Tylor

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ANTHROPOLOGICAL THEORIES

A GUIDE PREPARED BY STUDENTS FOR STUDENTS

The guides to anthropological theories and approaches listed below have been prepared by graduate students of the University of Alabama under the direction of Dr. Michael D. Murphy. *Caveat Lector!* (Let the Reader Beware!)

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Structuralism

Rachel Briggs and Janelle Meyer

(Note: authorship is arranged stratigraphically with the most recent author listed first)

Basic Premises:

Structuralism was predominately influenced by the schools of phenomenology and of Gestalt psychology, both of which were fostered in Germany between 1910 and the 1930s (Sturrock 2003: 47). Phenomenology was a school of philosophical thought that attempted to give philosophy a rational, scientific basis. Principally, it was concerned with accurately describing consciousness and abolishing the gulf that had traditionally existed between subject and object of human thought. Consciousness, as they perceived, was always conscious of something, and that picture, that whole, cannot be separated from the object or the subject but is the relationship between them (Sturrock 2003: 50-51). Phenomenology was made manifest in the works of Edmund Husserl, Martin Heidegger and Jean-Paul Sartre among others.

Gestalt psychology maintained that all human conscious experience is patterned, emphasizing that the whole is always greater than the parts, making it a holistic view (Sturrock 2003: 52). It fosters the view that the human mind functions by recognizing or, if none are available, imposing structures.

Structuralism developed as a theoretical framework in linguistics by Ferdinand de Saussure in the late 1920s, early 1930s. De Saussure proposed that languages were constructed of hidden rules that practitioners known but are unable to articulate. In other words, though we may all speak the same language, we are not all able to fully articulate the grammatical rules that govern why we arrange words in the order we do. However, we

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he proposed that the proper focus of anthropological investigations was on the underlying patterns of human thought that produce the cultural categories that organize worldviews hitherto studied (McGee and Warms, 2004: 345). He believed these processes were not deterministic of culture, but instead, operated within culture. His work was heavily influenced by Emile Durkheim and Marcel Mauss as well as the Prague School of structural linguistics (organized in 1926) which include Roman Jakobson (1896 to 1982), and Nikolai Troubetzkoy (1890 to 1938). From the latter, he derived the concept of binary contrasts, later referred to in his work as binary oppositions, which became fundamental in his theory.

In 1972, his book *Structuralism and Ecology* was published detailing the tenets of what would become structural anthropology. In it, he proposed that culture, like language, is composed of hidden rules that govern the behavior of its practitioners. What made cultures unique and different from one another are the hidden rules participants understood but are unable to articulate; thus, the goal of structural anthropology is to identify these rules. He maintained that culture is a dialectic process: thesis, antithesis, and synthesis. Levi-Strauss proposed a methodological means of discovering these rules—through the identification of binary oppositions.

The structuralist paradigm in anthropology suggests that the structure of human thought processes is the same in all cultures, and that these mental processes exist in the form of binary oppositions (Winthrop 1991). Some of these oppositions include hot-cold, male-female, culture-nature, and raw-cooked. Structuralists argue that binary oppositions are reflected in various cultural institutions (Lett 1987:80). Anthropologists may discover underlying thought processes by examining such things as kinship, myth, and language. It is proposed, then, that a hidden reality exists beneath all cultural expressions. Structuralists aim to understand the underlying meaning involved in human thought as expressed in cultural acts.

Further, the theoretical approach offered by structuralism emphasizes that elements of culture must be understood in terms of their relationship to the entire system (Rubel and Rosman 1996:1263). This notion, that the whole is greater than the parts, appeals to the Gestalt school of psychology. Essentially, elements of culture are not explanatory in and of themselves, but rather form part of a meaningful system. As an analytical model, structuralism assumes the universality of human thought processes in an effort to explain the "deep structure" or underlying meaning existing in cultural phenomena. "…[S]tructuralism is a set of principles for studying the mental superstructure" (Harris 1979:166, from Lett 1987:101).

Points of Reaction:

Some concerns have been expressed as to the epistemological and theoretical assumptions of structuralism. The validity of structural explanations has been challenged on the grounds that structuralist methods are imprecise and dependent upon the observer (Lett 1987:103). Lett (1987) poses the question of how independent structural analyses of the same phenomena could arrive at the same conclusions. The paradigm of structuralism is primarily concerned with the structure of the human psyche, and it does not address historical aspects or change in culture (Lett 1987, Rubel and Rosman 1996). This synchronic approach, which advocates a "psychic unity" of all human minds, has been criticized because it does not account for individual human action historically.

Maurice Godelier incorporated a dynamic aspect into his structural analysis of Australian marriage-class systems and their relationship to demographic factors (Rubel and Rosman 1996:1269). He did so by incorporating Marxist ideas of structures representing an organized reality and the importance of change in society. Godelier took structuralism a step further with his examination of infrastructural factors. In structuralist thought, inherently conflicting ideas exist in the form of binary oppositions, but these conflicts do not find resolution. In structural Marxist thought, the importance of perpetual change in society is noted: "When internal contradictions between structures or within a structure cannot be overcome, the structure does not reproduce but is transformed or evolves" (Rubel and Rosman 1996:1269). This dialectic accounts for the process of antithesis into thesis into synthesis.

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In addition to those who modified the structuralist paradigm and its critics exists another reaction known as "poststructuralism." Although poststructuralists are influenced by the structuralist ideas put forth by Lévi-Strauss, their work has more of a reflexive quality. Pierre Bourdieu is a poststructuralist who "…sees structure as a product of human creation, even though the participants may not be conscious of the structure" (Rubel and Rosman 1996:1270). Instead of the structuralist notion of the universality of human thought processes found in the structure of the human mind, Bourdieu proposes that dominant thought processes are a product of society and determine how people act (Rubel and Rosman 1996). However, in poststructuralist methods, the person describing the thought processes of people of another culture may be reduced to just that —description—as interpretation imposes the observer's perceptions onto the analysis at hand (Rubel and Rosman 1996). Poststructuralism is much like postmodernism in this sense.

Materialists would also generally object to structural explanations in favor of more observable or practical explanations. As Lett (1987) points out, Lévi-Strauss' analysis of the role of the coyote as trickster in many different Native American mythologies rationalizes that the coyote, because it preys on herbivores and carnivores alike, is associated with agriculture and hunting, and life and death (Lett 1987:104) is thus a deviation from natural order, or abnormal. Lett further shows that a materialist perspective is offered by Marvin Harris in the explanation of the recurrent theme of coyote as trickster: "The coyote enjoys the status of a trickster because it is an intelligent, opportunistic animal" (Lett 1987:104). Lévi-Strauss helped to spawn the rationalist-empiricist debate by furthering the inquiry into the idea of panhuman mental processes, and what determines culture.

Another reaction to structuralism is grounded in scientific inquiry. In any form of responsible inquiry, theories must be falsifiable. Structural analyses do not allow for this or for external validation (Lett 1987). Although these analyses present "complexity of symbolic realms" and "insight about the human condition," they simply cannot be subjected to scientific scrutiny (Lett 1987:108-9).

Leading Figures:

Claude Lévi-Strauss: (1908 to 2009) "Father of Structuralism;" born in Brussels in 1908. Obtained a law degree from the University of Paris. He became a professor of sociology at the University of Sao Paulo in Brazil in 1934. It was at this time that he began to think about human thought cross-culturally and alterity, when he was exposed to various cultures in Brazil. His first publication in anthropology appeared in 1936 and covered the social organization of the Bororo (Bohannan and Glazer 1988:423). After WWII, he taught at the New School for Social Research in New York. There he met Roman Jakobson, from whom he took the structural linguistics model and applied its framework to culture (Bohannan and Glazer 1988:423). Lévi-Strauss has been noted as singly associated for the elaboration of the structuralist paradigm in anthropology (Winthrop 1991).

Ferdinand de Saussure: (1857 to 1913) Swiss linguist born in Geneva whose work in structural linguistics and semiology greatly influenced Lévi-Strauss (Winthrop 1991; Rubel and Rosman 1996). Widely considered to be the father of 20th c. linguistics.

Roman Jakobson: (1896 to 1982) a Russian structural linguist. Was influenced by the work of Ferdinand de Saussere and worked with Nikolai Trubetzkoy to develop techniques for the analysis of sound in language. His work influenced Lévi-Strauss while they were colleagues at the New School for Social Research in New York.

Marcel Mauss: (1872 to 1952) French sociologist. His uncle was Emile Durkheim. He taught Lévi-Strauss and influenced his thought on the nature of reciprocity and structural relationships in culture (Winthrop 1991).

Jacques Derrida: (1930 to 2004) French social philosopher and literary critic who may be labeled both a "structuralist' and a "poststructuralist" and was the founder of deconstructionism. Derrida wrote critiques of his contemporaries' works, and of the notions underlying structuralism and poststructuralism (Culler 1981).

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(Lotringer 1989:60). However, he has publicly scoffed at being labeled a structuralist because he did not wish to be permanently associated with one paradigm (Sturrock 1981). Foucault deals largely with issues of power and domination in his works, arguing that there is no absolute truth, and thus the purpose of ideologies is to struggle against other ideologies for supremecy (think about competing news networks, arguing different points of view). For this reason, he is more closely associated with poststructuralist thought.

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Principal Concepts:

Methodologies:

Folk stories, religious stories, and fairy tales were the principle subject matter for structuralists because they believed these made manifest the underlying universal human structures, the binary oppositions. For example, in the story of Cinderella, some of the binary oppositions include good versus evil, pretty versus ugly (Cinderella versus her two stepsisters), clean versus dirty, etc. Because of this focus, the principle methodology employed was hermeneutics. Hermeneutics originated as a study of the Gospels, and has since come to refer to the interpretation of the meaning or written works.

Accomplishments:

Though there are few anthropologists today who would declare themselves structuralists, structuralism was highly influential. Work of the poststructuralist Pierre Bourdieu, particularly his idea of the habitus, laid the groundwork for agency theory. Structuralism also continued the idea that there were universal structuring elements in the human mind that shaped culture. This concept is still pursued in cognitive anthropology which looks at the way people think in order to identify these structures, instead of analyzing oral or written texts.

Criticisms:

- Static, ahistorical nature of theory (Seymour-Smith 1986)

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Relevant Web Links:

Structuralism

- Google Book: Structuralism, 2nd Edition by John Sturrock.
- Google Book: Structuralist Poetics by Jonathan Culler
- Structuralism and Poststructuralism
- Structuralism and Literary Criticism: despite the fact that some of this site in is Chinese, it provides an excellent overview of some key structuralist points, such as the analysis of narrative
- Regarding Methodology: a blog post that contains a brief conceptualization of a structuralist methodology

Claude Levi-Strauss

- Profile from Minnesota State University, Mankato
- Google Book: Claude Levi Strauss by Edmund Leach
- Obituary
- Remembering Claude Levi Straus
- Google Book (limited preview): Structural Anthropology
- Other excerpts from Structural Anthropology
- Google Book (limited preview): The Raw and the Cooked
- Google Book (limited preview): The Elementary Structures of Kin
- The Structural Study of Myth

Michel Foucault

- Michel-Foucault.com
- Michel Foucault, info
- Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison (Part 3, Chapter 3: Panopticism)

Inspirations for Structuralism

- Marcel Mauss
- Ferdinand de Saussure

Reactions to Structuralism

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Symbolic and Interpretive Anthropologies

Scott Hudson and Carl Smith and Michael Loughlin and Scott Hammerstedt

(Note: authorship is arranged stratigraphically with the most recent author listed first)

Basic Premises:

Symbolic anthropology studies the way people understand their surroundings, as well as the actions and utterances of the other members of their society. These interpretations form a shared cultural system of meaning--i.e., understandings shared, to varying degrees, among members of the same society (Des Chene 1996:1274). Symbolic anthropology studies symbols and the processes,such as myth and ritual, by which humans assign meanings to these symbols to address fundamental questions about human social life (Spencer 1996:535). According to Geertz, man is in need of symbolic "sources of illumination" to orient himself with respect to the system of meaning that is any particular culture (1973a:45). Turner states that symbols initiate social action and are "determinable influences inclining persons and groups to action" (1967:36). Geertz's position illustrates the interpretive approach to symbolic anthropology, while Turner's illustrates the symbolic approach.

Symbolic anthropology views culture as an independent system of meaning deciphered by interpreting key symbols and rituals (Spencer 1996:535). There are two major premises governing symbolic anthropology. The first is that "beliefs, however unintelligible, become comprehensible when understood as part of a cultural system of meaning" (Des Chene 1996:1274). Geertz's position illustrates the interpretive approach to symbolic anthropology, while Turner's illustrates the symbolic approach. The second major premise is that actions are guided by interpretation, allowing symbolism to aid in interpreting ideal as well as material activities. Traditionally, symbolic anthropology has focused on religion, cosmology, ritual activity, and

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group of people (Des Chene 1996:1274).

Symbolic anthropology can be divided into two major approaches. One is associated with Clifford Geertz and the University of Chicago and the other with Victor W. Turner at Cornell. David Schneider was also a major figure in the development of symbolic anthropology, however he does not fall entirely within either of the above schools of thought. Interestingly, however,Turner, Geertz, and Schneider were all at the University of Chicago briefly in the 1970s).

The major difference between the two schools lies in their respective influences. Geertz was influenced largely by the sociologist Max Weber, and was concerned with the operations of "culture" rather than the ways in which symbols operate in the social process. Turner, influenced by Emile Durkheim, was concerned with the operations of "society" and the ways in which symbols operate within it. (Ortner 1983:128-129; see also Handler 1991). Turner, reflecting his English roots, was much more interested in investigating whether symbols actually functioned within the social process the way symbolic anthropologists believed they did. Geertz focused much more on the ways in which symbols operate within culture, like how individuals "see, feel, and think about the world" (Ortner 1983:129-131).

Points of Reaction:

Symbolic anthropology can be considered as a reaction to structuralism that was was grounded in linguistics and semiotics and pioneered by L�vi-Strauss (Des Chene 1996:1275). This dissatisfaction with structuralism can be seen in Geertz's article The Cerebral Savage: On the Work of Claude L�vi-Strauss (1973b). L�vi-Strauss's focus on meaning, as established by contrasts between various aspects of culture and not on meaning, was derived from the symbols alienating the mostlyAmerican symbolic anthropologists. Structuralists also saw actions as being separate from the actors, whereassymbolic anthropologists believed in "actor-centric" actions (Ortner 1983:136). Further, structuralism utilized symbols only with respect to their place in the "system" and not as an integral part of understanding the system (Prattis 1997:33). This split between the idealism of the symbolic anthropologists and the materialism of the structuralists dominated the 1960s into the 1970s.

Symbolic anthropology was also a reaction against materialism and Marxism. Materialists define culture in terms of observable behavior patternswhere technoenvironmental factors are primary and causal" (Langness 1974:84). Symbolic anthropologists, instead, view culture in terms of symbols and mental terms. The primary reaction against Marxism was its basis on historically specific Western assumptions about material and economic needs which cannot be properly applied to non-Western societies (Sahlins 1976; see also discussion in Spencer 1996:538).

Leading Figures:

Clifford Geertz (1926-2006) studied at Harvard University in the 1950s. He was strongly influenced by the writings of philosophers such as Langer, Ryle, Wittgenstein, Heidegger, and Ricouer, as well as by Weber, adopting various aspects of their thinking as key elements in his interpretive anthropology (Handler 1991; Tongs 1993), the results of which can be found in his compilation of essays entitled "The Interpretation of Cultures" (1973c).He believed that an analysis of culture should "not [be] an experimental science in search of law but an interpretive one in search of meaning" (Geertz 1973d:5). Culture is expressed by the external symbols that a society uses rather than being locked inside people's heads. He defined culture as "an historically transmitted pattern of meanings embodied in symbols, a system of inherited conceptions expressed in symbolic forms by means of which men communicate, perpetuate, and develop their knowledge about and their attitudes toward life" (Geertz 1973e:89). Societies use these symbols to express their "worldview, value-orientation, ethos, [and other aspects of their culture]" (Ortner 1983:129). For Geertz symbols are "vehicles of 'culture'" (Ortner 1983:129), meaning that symbols should not be studied in and of themselves, but for what they can reveal about culture. Geertz's main interest was the way in which symbols shape the ways that social actors see, feel, and think about the world (Ortner 1983:129). Throughout his

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in Scotland, Turner was influenced early on by the structional-functionalist approach of British social anthropology (Turner 1980:143). However, upon embarking on a study of the Ndembu in Africa, Turner's focus shifted from economics and demography to ritual symbolism (McLaren 1985). Turner's approach to symbols was very different from that of Geertz. Turner was not interested in symbols as vehicles of "culture" as Geertz was but instead investigated symbols as "operators in the social process" (Ortner 1983:131) believing that "the symbolic expression of shared meanings, not the attraction of material interests, lie at the center of human relationships" (Manning 1984:20). Symbols "instigate social action" and exert "determinable influences inclining persons and groups to action" (Turner 1967:36). Turner felt that these "operators," by their arrangement and context, produce "social transformations" which tie the people in a society to the society's norms, resolve conflict, and aid in changing the status of the actors (Ortner 1983:131).

David Schneider *(1918-1995)* was another important figure in the "Chicago school" of symbolic anthropology. He did not make the complete break from structuralism that had been made by Geertz and Turner, rather he retained and modified L&#65533;vi-Strauss' idea of culture as a set of relationships (Ortner 1983; Spencer 1996). Schneider defined culture as a system of symbols and meanings (Keesing 1974:80). Schneider's system can be broken into categories, however there are no rules for the categories. According to Schneider (1980:5), regularity in behavior is not necessarily "culture," nor can culture be inferred from a regular pattern of behavior. A category can be made for an observable act, or can be created through inference. Therefore, things that cannot be seen, such as spirits, can embody a cultural category (Keesing 1974:80). Schneider was interested in the connections between the cultural symbols and observable events and strove to identify the symbols and meanings that governed the rules of a society (Keesing 1974:81). Schneider differed from Geertz by detaching culture from everyday life. He defined a cultural system as "a series of symbols" where a symbol is "something which stands for something else (1980:1). This contrasted with the elaborate definitions favored by Geertz and Turner.

Mary Douglas (1921-2007) was an important British social anthropologist influenced by Durkheim and Evans-Pritchard and known for an interest in human culture and symbolism.&#65533; One of her most notable research accomplishments was tracing the words and meanings for dirt&#65533;matter considered out of place&#65533;in different cultural contexts (Douglas 1966).&#65533; With this framework, she explored the differences between sacred and unclean illustrating the importance of social history and context.&#65533; An important case study traced Jewish food taboos to a symbolic-boundary maintenance system based on taxonomic classification of pure and impure animals (Douglas 1966).&#65533; Douglas also introduced the concept of group and grid.&#65533; Group refers to how clearly defined an individual's position is within or outside a social group, and grid refers to how well defined an individual's social roles are within privilege, claim, and obligation networks (Douglas 1970).&#65533;

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Jews and other Anthropological Stories. Durham and London: Duke University Press.
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Principal Concepts:

Thick Description is a term Geertz borrowed from Gilbert Ryle to describe and define the aim of interpretive anthropology. He argues that social Anthropology is based on ethnography, or the study of culture. Culture is based on the symbols that guide community behavior. Symbols obtain meaning from the role which they play in the patterned behavior of social life. Culture and behavior cannot be studied separately because they are intertwined. By analyzing the whole of culture as well as its constituent parts, one develops a "thick description" which details the mental processes and reasoning of the natives Thick description, however, is an interpretation of what the natives are thinking made by an outsider who cannot think like a nativebut is made possible by anthropological theory (Geertz 1973d; see also Tongs 1993).

To illustrate thick description, Geertz uses Ryle's example which discusses the difference between a "blink" and a "wink." One, a blink, is an involuntary twitch --the thin description-- and the other, a wink, is a conspiratorial signal to a friend--the thick description. While the physical movements involved in each are identical, each has a distinct meaning "as anyone unfortunate enough to have had the first taken for the second knows" (Geertz 1973d:6). A wink is a special form of communication which consists of several characteristics: it is deliberate; to someone in particular; to impart a particular message; according to a socially established code; and without the knowledge of the other members of the group of which the winker and winkee are a part. In addition, the wink can be a parody of someone else's wink or an attempt to lead others to believe that a conspiracy of sorts is occuring. Each type of wink can be considered to be a separate cultural category (Geertz 1973d:6-7). The combination of the blink and the types of winks discussed above (and those that lie between them) produce "a stratified hierarchy of meaningful structures" (Geertz 1973d:7) in which winks and twitches are produced and interpreted. This, Geertz argues, is the object of ethnography: to decipher this hierarchy of cultural categories. The thick description, therefore, is a description of the particular form of communication used, like a parody of someone else's wink or a \conspiratorial wink.

Hermeneutics is a term first applied to the critical interpretation of religious texts. The modern use of the term is a "combination of empirical investigation and subsequent subjective understanding of human phenomena" (Woodward 1996:555). Geertz used hermeneutics in his studies of symbol systems to try to understand the ways that people "understand and act in social, religious, and economic contexts " (Woodward 1996:557). The hierarchy that surrounds Balinese cockfighting provides an interesting example (Geertz 1973f:448).[illegible] Geertz (1973f:443-8) identifies cockfighting as an art form representing status arrangements in the community and a subsequent self-expression of community identity. Turner used hermeneutics as a method for understanding the meanings of "cultural performances" [illegible]likedance, drama, etc. (Woodward 1996:557).

Social Drama is a concept devised by Victor Turner to study the dialectic of social transformation and continuity. A social drama is "a spontaneous unit of social process and a fact of everyone's experience in every human society" (Turner 1980:149).[illegible] Social dramas occur within a group that shares values and interests and has a shared common history (Turner 1980:149). This drama can be broken into four acts. The first act is a rupture in social relations, or breach. The second act is a crisis that cannot be handled by normal strategies. The third act is a remedy to the initial problem, or redress and the re-establishment of social relations. The final act can occur in two ways: reintegration, the return to the status quo, or recognition of schism, an alteration in the social arrangements (Turner 1980:149). In both of the resolutions there are symbolic displays in which the actors show their unityin the form of rituals (Des Chene 1996:1276). In Turner's theory, ritual is a kind of plot that has a set sequencewhich is linear, not circular (Turner and Turner 1978:161-163; Grimes 1985).

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For examples of some published discussions of social dramas, see Turner (1[illegible]7[illegible]) and Grimes (1[illegible]5).

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Chene 1996:1274). One of the major changes made by symbolic anthropology was the movement to a literary-based rather than a science-based approach. Symbolic anthropology, with its emphasis on the works of non-anthropologists such as Ricoeur, utilized literature from outside the bounds of traditional anthropology (see Handler 1991:611). In addition, symbolic anthropology examines symbols from different aspects of social life, rather than from one aspect at a time isolated from the rest. This is an attempt to show that a few central ideas expressed in symbols manifest themselves in different aspects of culture (Des Chene 1996:1274).

This contrasted the structuralist approach favored by European social anthropologists such as L&#65533;vi-Strauss (Spencer 1996:536; see also mention of rebellion against "the establishment" with respect to social theory in Schneider 1995:174). Symbolic anthropology focuses largely on culture as a whole rather than on specific aspects of culture that are isolated from one another.

Accomplishments:

The major accomplishment of symbolic anthropology has been to turn anthropology towards issues of culture and interpretation rather than the development of grand theories. Geertz, through his references to social scientists such as Ricouer and Wittgenstein, has become the most often cited anthropologist by other disciplines (Spencer 1996:536-538). The use of similar citations by Schneider, Turner, and others helped anthropology turn to sources outside the bounds of traditional anthropology, such as philosophy and sociology.

Geertz's main contribution to anthropological knowledge, however, was in changing the ways in which American anthropologists viewed culture, shifting the concern from the operations of culture to the way in which symbols act as vehicles of culture. Another contribution was the emphasis on studying culture from the perspective the actors within that culture. This emic perspective means that one must view individuals as attempting to interpret situations in order to act (Geertz 1973b). This actor-centered view is central to Geertz's work, however, it was never developed into an actual theory or model. Schneider developed the systematic aspects of culture and separated culture from the individual even more than Geertz (Ortner 1984:129-130).

Turner's major addition to anthropology was the investigation of how symbols actually operate, whether they function the ways in which symbolic anthropologists say they do. This was an aspect of symbolic anthropology that Geertz and Schneider never addressed in any great detail. This appears indicative of the influence of British social anthropology (Ortner 1984:130-131).

Douglas played a role in developing the Cultural Theory of Risk which has spawned diverse, interdisciplinary research programs.&#65533; This theory asserts that the structures of social organizations offer perceptions to individuals that reinforce those structures rather than alternatives.&#65533; Two features of Douglas' work were imported and synthesized.&#65533; The first was her account of the social functions of individual perceptions of danger and risk, where harm was associated with disobeying the norms of society (Douglas 1966, 1992).&#65533; The second feature was her characterization of cultural practices along the group and grid which can vary from society to society (Douglas 1970).&#65533;

Criticisms:

Symbolic anthropology has come under fire from several fronts, most notably from Marxists. Asad attacks the dualism evident in Geertz's arguments. While acknowledging Geertz's strengths, Asad believes that Geertz's weakness lies in the interruption between external symbols and internal dispositions. This further corresponds to the gap between "cultural system" and "social reality" when attempting to define the concept of religion in universal terms. Asad argues that anthropologists should instead focus on the historical conditions that are crucial to the development of certain religious practices (Asad 1983). Moving away from the definition of religion as a whole is important, Asad argues, because the development of religious practices differ from society to society. In addition, Marxists charge that symbolic anthropology, while describing

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assumptions about material and economic needs. Due to this fact, it cannot be properly applied to non-Western societies (Sahlins 1976; Spencer 1996:538).

Another attack on symbolic anthropology came from cultural ecology. Cultural ecologists considered symbolic anthropologists to be "fuzzy headed mentalists, involved in unscientific and unverifiable flights of subjective interpretation" (Ortner 1984:134). In other words, symbolic anthropology did not attempt to carry out their research in a manner so that other researchers could reproduce their results. Mental phenomenon and symbolic interpretation, they argued, was scientifically untestable. Also, since different anthropologists could view the same symbol in different ways, it was attacked as being too subjective.

Symbolic anthropologists answered the cultural ecologists by asserting that cultural ecology was too scientific. Cultural ecologists ignored the fact that culture dominates all human behavior, thus they had lost sight of what anthropology had established previously (Ortner 1984:134).

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The University of Alabama

Department of Anthropology

ANTHROPOLOGICAL THEORIES

A GUIDE PREPARED BY STUDENTS FOR STUDENTS

The guides to anthropological theories and approaches listed below have been prepared by graduate students of the University of Alabama under the direction of Dr. Michael D. Murphy. As always, *!Caveat Retis Viator!* (Let the Net Traveller Beware!)

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Cognitive Anthropology

Bobbie Simova and Tara Robertson and Duke Beasley

(Note: authorship is arranged stratigraphically with the most recent author listed first)

Basic Premises:

Cognitive anthropology addresses the ways in which people conceive of and think about events and objects in the world. It provides a link between human thought processes and the physical and ideational aspects of culture (D'Andrade 1995: 1). This subfield of anthropology is rooted in Boasian cultural relativism, influenced by anthropological linguistics, and closely aligned with psychological investigations of cognitive processes. It arose as a separate area of study in the 1950s, as ethnographers sought to discover "the native's point of view," adopting an emic approach to anthropology (Erickson and Murphy 2003: 115). The new field was alternatively referred to as **Ethnosemantics, Ethnoscience, Ethnolinguistics,** and **New Ethnography.**

In the first decades of practice, cognitive anthropologists focused on folk taxonomies, including concepts of color, plants, and diseases. During the 1960s and 1970s a theoretical adjustment and methodological shift occurred within cognitive anthropology. Linguistic analyses continued to provide methods for understanding and accessing the cognitive categories of indigenous people. However, the focus was no longer restricted to items and relationships within indigenous categories but stressed analyzing categories in terms of mental processes. Scholars of this generation assumed that there were mental processes based on the structure of the mind and, hence, common to all humans. This approach extended its scope to study not only components of abstract systems of thought but also to examine how mental processes relate to symbols and ideas (McGee & Warms 1996).

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consensus theory. Cognitive anthropology is closely aligned with psychology, because both explore the nature of cognitive processes (D'Andrade 1995:1). It has also adopted theoretical elements and methodological techniques from structuralism and linguistics. Cognitive anthropology is a broad field of inquiry; for example, studies have examined how people arrange colors and plants into categories as well how people conceptualize disease in terms of symptoms, cause, and appropriate treatment. Cognitive anthropology not only focuses on discovering how different peoples organize culture but also how they utilize culture. Contemporary cognitive anthropology attempts to access the organizing principles that underlie and motivate human behavior. Though the scope of cognitive anthropology is expansive its methodology continues to depend strongly on a long-standing tradition of ethnographic fieldwork and structured interviews.

Cognitive anthropologists regard anthropology as a formal science. They maintain that culture is composed of logical rules that are based on ideas that can be accessed in the mind. Cognitive anthropology emphasizes the rules of behavior, not behavior itself. It does not claim that it can predict human behavior but delineates what is socially and culturally expected or appropriate in given situations, circumstances, and contexts. It is not concerned with describing events in order to explain or discover processes of change. Furthermore, this approach declares that every culture embodies its own unique organizational system for understanding things, events, and behavior. Some scholars contend that it is necessary to develop several theories of cultures before striving toward the creation of a grand theory of Culture (Applebaum, 1987:409). In other words, researchers insist that studies should be aimed at understanding particular cultures in forming theoretical explanations. Once this has been achieved, then valid and reliable cross-cultural comparisons become possible, enabling a general theory of all Culture.

It was not until the 1950s that cognitive anthropology came to be regarded as a distinct theoretical and methodological approach within anthropology. However, its intellectual roots can be traced back much further. Tarnas (1991:333) notes that the Enlightenment produced at least one distinct avenue for explaining the natural world and humans' place within it: the foundation of human knowledge, including encounters with the material world, was located in the mind. Thus philosophy turned its attention to the analysis of the human mind and cognitive processes.

The interaction of society and the mind has long been an area of intellectual interest. The Enlightenment thinkers Rousseau, Hobbes, and Locke all contended that this intersection was of utmost importance for understanding society. Rousseau postulated that humans were essentially good, but ruined by civilization and society, and he urged a return to a "natural state." Hobbes maintained that humans are by nature a brutish and selfish lot; society and government are necessary to control and curb our basic nature. Locke, on the other hand, rejected the Cartesian idea of innate ideas and presumed that humans are at birth "blank slates," neither good nor bad, with the experience of their culture shaping the type of person they would become (Garbarino 1983:12-13).

Perhaps the most long-lasting contribution of Enlightenment philosophers was Locke's advocacy of empiricism: He conceived of knowledge of the world as having roots in sensory experience. Locke argued that "combining and compounding of simple sensory impressions or 'ideas' (defined as mental contents) into more complex concepts, through reflection after sensation, the mind can arrive at sound conclusions," (Tarnas, 1991:333). Cognition was conceived as beginning with sensation and resting on experience. In competition with the empiricist tradition was the rationalist orientation, which contended that the mind alone could achieve knowledge. The Enlightenment, nevertheless, combated this claim, maintaining that reason depended on sensory experience to know anything about the world excluding the mind's own concoctions (Tarnas, 1991:334). Rationalist claims of knowledge were increasingly illegitimated. The mind void of sensory experience could only speculate. These premises translated into different scientific approaches. Science was regarded as a mechanism for discovering the probable truths of human existence not as a device for attaining absolute knowledge of general, universal truths. These epistemological concepts still resonate today in contemporary cognitive anthropology, as well as among other approaches, and in the school's theoretical and methodological basis.

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stages of increasing complexity: hunting, pastoralism, and farming. Condorcet's intellectual history of mankind, "The Outline of Progress of the Human Mind" (1795), concentrated on European thought, dividing history into ten stages, culminating with the French Revolution (Garbarino 1983:15). In the early nineteenth century, Auguste Comte developed a philosophy that became known as positivism. Comte proposed that earlier modes of thought were imperfectly speculative, and that knowledge should be gained by empirical observation. He reasoned that intellectual complexity evolved in much the same way as society and biological beings (Garbarino 1983:20).

The earliest practitioners of anthropology were also interested in the relationship between the human mind and society. By viewing his data through the prism of evolution, Morgan continued the Enlightenment tradition of explaining the phenomenon he observed as a result of increasing rationality (Garbarino 1983:28-29). E.B. Tylor, who shared many of the views of Morgan, was also interested in aspects of the mind in less developed societies. His definition of culture as the, "complex whole which includes knowledge, beliefs, arts, morals, and any other capabilities and habits acquired by man as a member of society," reflects this interest (Garbarino 1983:31).

One concept that is central to cultural anthropology, and particularly to cognitive anthropology, is the psychic unity of mankind. This concept was developed by the German Adolf Bastian in the closing years of the nineteenth century. After observing similarities in customs throughout the world, Bastian concluded that all humans must have the same basic psychic or mental processes, and that this unity produced similar responses to similar stimuli (Garbarino 1983:32). While most anthropologists tend to take this concept as a given, some contemporary cognitive anthropologists question this assumption (Shore 1996:15-41).

Cognitive studies in modern anthropology can be traced back to Franz Boas (Colby 1996:210). Boas, who first turned to anthropology during his research on the Eskimo and their perception of the color of ice and water, realized that different peoples had different conceptions of the world around them. He was so affected that he began to focus his life's work on understanding the relation between the human mind and the environment (Shore 1996:19). This work, which was fueled by his revolt against the racist thinking of the day, would direct Boas towards trying to understand the psychology of tribal peoples. This aspect of his work is best expressed in his essay "Psychological Problems in Anthropology" (1910), and culminates in his volume *The Mind of Primitive Man* (1911). Boas encouraged investigations of tribal categories of sense and perception, such as color, topics that would be critical in the later development of cognitive anthropology (Shore 1996:20-21).

Some of the methodological rigor and theoretical grounding of cognitive anthropology grew out of linguistic anthropology. The Sapir-Whorf hypothesis, in particular, was an important precursor to the field. In the 1930s, linguists Edward Sapir and Benjamin Lee Whorf formulated the view that the structures of language and culture create classificatory categories that shape meaning and world views (Erickson and Murphy 2003: 115-116). Parallel developments in psychology in the 1950s also owe much to linguistics. Psychologists, dissatisfied with the behaviorist explanations of B.F. Skinner, looked to the linguistic insights of Noam Chomsky to legitimate the reality of mental events (Miller 2003: 142). Early cognitive anthropological approaches to culture exhibit the influence of linguistics both in theory and in methods.

In recent years, the methodologies of cognitive anthropology have been subsumed in wider anthropological research, with few departments offering cognitive anthropology as a distinct field of study. Anthropologists interested in cognition can look to the interdisciplinary field of cognitive science, which increasingly centers on advancements in neuroscience, cognitive linguistics, and computer sciences, especially in relation to the development of artificial intelligence. Medical anthropology has also proved to be a fertile ground for the development of cognitive methods and practical understandings of the impact of cultural models of disease and well-being.

Points of Reaction:

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roles of the members, political organization, and the nature of magic, religion, witchcraft, and other forms of native beliefs (D'Andrade 1995:5). As more and more scholars entered the field, it was found that the ethnographies of places revisited did not always match the ethnographies of a previous generation. The best known examples of this were the divergent accounts of the Robert Redfield and Oscar Lewis of the Mexican village of Tepoztlan published in 1930 and 1951 respectively. Ethnographic validity became a central issue in cultural anthropology (Colby 1996:210).

The problem of validity was first tackled through the use of linguistics. The discovery of the phoneme, the smallest unit of a meaningful sound, gave anthropologists the opportunity to understand and record cultures in the native language. This was thought to be a way of getting around the analyst's imposition of his own cultural bias on a society (Colby 1996:211). This led to an approach known as Ethnoscience. The seminal papers of this genre, to which much of the development of cognitive anthropology can be credited, are traceable to Floyd Lounsbury and Ward Goodenough, particularly Goodenough's "Componential Analysis" of 1956 (Applebaum, 1987). Goodenough laid out the basic premises for the "new ethnography," as ethnoscience was sometimes known. He states that "culture is a conceptual mode underlying human behavior " (1957, quoted in Keesing 1972:300), in that, it refers to the "standards for deciding what is . . . for deciding how one feels about it, and . . . for deciding how to go about doing it," (Goodenough 1961:522, quoted in Keesing 1972:300). No longer was a simple description of what was observed by the ethnographer sufficient; the new aim was to find the underlying structure behind a peoples' conception of the world around them. See Conklin's study of color categories in the "Leading Figures" section for an exemplary of ethnoscientific study.

This early period of cognitive anthropology basically pursued an adequate ethnographic methodology. Scholars found previous ethnographic accounts to be problematic and biased and endeavored to study culture from the viewpoint of indigenous people rather than from the ethnographer's construction of a culture. The primary theoretical underpinning of the ethnoscientific approach is that culture exists only in people's minds (Applebaum, 1987:409). For example, Goodenough proposed that to successfully navigate their social world individuals must control a certain level of knowledge, that he calls a "mental template." The methodology of ethnoscience attempted to remove the ethnographer's categories from the research process. This position lead to the development of new information eliciting techniques that tried to avoid the imposition of the ethnographer's own preconceived cultural assumptions and ideas. Methods were developed that relied on linguistic techniques based in the indigenous language and if employed successfully could produce taxonomies or models free of the ethnographer's bias.

The principal research goal identified by cognitive anthropologists was to determine the content and organization of culture as knowledge. This was demonstrated by Anthony Wallace's notion of the mazeway, "a mental image of the society and its culture" (D'Andrade 1995:17). He applied this concept to explain the Iroquois revitalization movement brought about by the Seneca prophet, Handsome Lake. While the mazeway concept was useful for reformulating traditional terms such as religion and magic, the concept lacked specificity in addressing how to determine the organization of these elements. From the late 1950s to the 1970s, research was strongly oriented towards method, formalization, and quantification. The attraction for many was that the field was using methods developed in the study of semantics, and served as an access to the mind (D'Andrade 1995:246). Much of this early work centered on taxonomies and domains such as kinship, plants, animals, and colors.

While the methodology was productive in reducing the anthropologist's bias, ethnoscience was subject to several criticisms, most focused on the limited nature and number of domains. The significance that color, kin terms, and plant classifications had for understanding the human condition was questioned. Some critics charged that it appeared that some cognitive anthropologists valued the eliciting technique more than the actual data produced from the procedures. Moreover, the data often did not lead to explanations of the respondents' worldview (Applebaum, 1987:407). Other critics noted that the ethnoscientific approach to culture implied extreme cultural relativism. Since ethnoscience stressed the individuality of each culture it made cross-cultural comparisons very difficult. Others noted deficiencies in addressing intracultural variation. Practitioners claimed they were trying to capture the indigenous, not the anthropologist's, view of culture;

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During the 1960s and 1970s a theoretical adjustment and methodological shift occurred within cognitive anthropology. Linguistic analyses continued to provide methods for understanding and accessing the cognitive categories of indigenous people. However, the focus was no longer restricted to items and relationships within indigenous categories but stressed analyzing categories in terms of mental processes. Scholars of this generation assumed that there were mental processes based on the structure of the mind and, hence, common to all humans. This approach extended its scope to study not only components of abstract systems of thought but also to examine how mental processes relate to symbols and ideas (McGee & Warms, 1996).

By the early 1980s, schema theory had become the primary means of understanding the psychological aspect of culture. Schemas are entirely abstract entities and unconsciously enacted by individuals. They are models of the world that organize experience and the understandings shared by members of a group or society. Schemata, in conjunction with connectionist networks, provided even more abstract psychological theory about the nature of mental representations. Schema theory created a new class of mental entities. Prior to schema theory, the major pieces of culture were thought be either material or symbolic in nature. Culture, as conceptualized by anthropologists, started to become thought of in terms of parts instead of wholes. The concept of parts, however, was not used in the traditional functionalist sense of static entities constituting an integrated whole, but was used in the sense that the nature of the parts changed. Through the use of schemata, culture could be placed in the mind, and the parts became cognitively formed units: features, prototypes, schemas, propositions, and cognitive categories. Culture could be explained by analyzing these units, or pieces of culture. Contemporary questions include (1) if cultural pieces are in fact shared; (2) if they are shared, to what extent; (3) how are these units distributed across persons; and (5) which distribution of units are internalized. These issues have in fact taken cognitive studies away from the mainstream of anthropology and moved it closer to psychology (D'Andrade 1995:246-247).

Cognitive anthropology trends now appear to be leaning towards the study of how cultural schemas are related to action. This brings up issues of emotion, motivation, and how individuals internalize culture during socialization. And finally, cognitive structure is being related to the physical structure of artifacts and the behavioral structure of groups (D'Andrade 1995:248).

Leading Figures:

Ward Goodenough (b. 1919) is one of cognitive anthropology's early leading scholars, inaugurating the subdiscipline in 1956 with the publication of "Componential Analysis and the Study of Meaning" in a volume of *Language*. He helped to establish a methodology for studying cultural systems. His fundamental contribution was in the framing of componential analysis, now more commonly referred to as feature analysis. Basically, componential analysis, borrowing its methods from linguistic anthropology, involved the construction of a matrix that contrasted the binary attributes of a domain in terms of pluses (presence) and minuses (absence). The co-occurrence of traits could then be analyzed as well as attribute distribution. For specifics refer to "Property, Kin, and Community on Truk" (1951), "Componential Analysis and the Study of Meaning" (1956) and "Componential Analysis of Konkama Lapp Kinship Terminologies" (1964). Several years later he analyzed the terminology of Yankee kinship to critique an apparent flaw with the method: the possibility of constructing many valid models using the same data. Essentially, he challenged the reliability of the results produced stating that the finding had "profound implications for cultural theory, calling into question the anthropological premise that a society's culture is 'shared' by its members," (1969: 256). He concluded that the relationship of componential analysis and cognition must remain inconclusive until further debate has been settled. Indeed, componential analysis presently serves as only a part of analytic methodology instead of its primary method.

Floyd Lounsbury (1914-1998) was another influential figure in the rise of the subdiscipline. His analysis of Pawnee kinship terms, "A Semantic Analysis of the Pawnee Kinship Usage" was published in 1956.

Charles Frake (b. 1930) wrote an interesting article in the late sixties in which he commented extensively on the nature of current ethnographic data collection beyond kinship studies. Instead of collecting data by

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domain. He argued that studies of how people think have historically sought evidence of "primitive thinking" instead actually investigating the processes of cognition. He contends that future studies should match the methodological rigor of kinship and should aim for developing a native understanding of the world. He promotes a "bottom up" approach where the ethnographer firsts attains the domain items (on the segregates) of different categories (or contrast sets). The goal, according to Frake, is to create a taxonomy so differences between contrasting sets are demonstrated in addition to how the attributes of contrasting sets relate to each other.

Harold Conklin (b. 1926) conducted extensive research in Southeast Asia, producing one of the largest ethnographic collections for the Philippines. His interest in linguistics and ecology and commitment to ethnoscience led to pioneering investigations of indigenous systems of tropical forest agriculture. He also made important contributions to the study of kinship terminology including "Lexicographical Treatment of Folk Taxonomies" (1969) and "Ethnogenealogical Method" (1969). Conklin's investigation of color perception in "Hanunóo Color Categories" (1955) is characteristic of the sort of study produced by the early ethnoscientific approach. In this article, Conklin demonstrates that Hanunóo color terms do not segment the color spectrum in the same manner as western color terms, and in fact incorporate additional sensory information, such as wetness and dryness. A key observation of the study was that the type of eliciting material used made a difference in the consistency of the responses. In 1969, Brent Berlin and Paul Kay presented a study of color categories in which they trace universal tendencies and historical and cultural development, arguing against the cultural relativism implied in Conklin's publication.

Roy D'Andrade (b. 1931) has made important contributions to methodology and theory in cognitive anthropology. One of his earlier studies is particularly noteworthy for its methodology. In 1974 D'Andrade published an article criticizing the reliability and validity of a widely practiced method of social sciences. Researchers conducted studies of how people judge other's behavior. Judgments of informants, he argued, were influenced not only by what they witnessed, but also by the cultural models they entertained about the domain in question. He noted that their judgment was related to the limitations of human memory.

Aside from his methodological contributions, D'Andrade (1995) has synthesized the field of cognitive anthropology in one of the first books discussing the approach as a whole. The *Development of Cognitive Anthropology* (1995) has provided scholars and students with an account of the development of cognitive anthropology from early experiments with the classic feature model to the elaboration of consensus theory in the late 20th century.

A. Kimball Romney's (b. 1925) many contributions to cognitive anthropology include the development of consensus theory. Unlike most methods that are concerned with the reliability of data, the consensus method statistically measures the reliability of individual informants in relation to each other and in reference to the group as a whole. It demonstrates how accurately a particular person's knowledge of a domain corresponds with the domain knowledge established by several individuals. In other words, the competency of individuals as informants is measured. For specifics about how cultural consensus works, see the "Methodology" section of this web page. In a recent article in Current Anthropology, "Cultural Consensus as a Statistical Model" (1999), there is an intriguing exchange between Aunger who opposes consensus theory and Romney who rebuts Aunger's criticisms. Romney maintains that cultural consensus is a statistical model that does not pre-suppose an ideological alignment, as Aunger asserts, but rather it demonstrates any existing relationships between variables.

Furthermore, Romney asserts that all shared knowledge is not cultural, but cultural knowledge has the elements of being shared among relevant participants and is socially learned (1999: S104). Romney proceeds to outline three central assumptions of consensus theory: (1) there is a single, shared conglomerate of answers that constitute a coherent domain; (2) each respondent's answers are given independently and only afterwards is the correlation between respondents known; and (3) items are relatively homogeneously known by all respondents. Cultural consensus, as other statistical methods, helps to eliminate bias in analyzing data. It can also reveal patterns, like the degree of intracultural variation, which may go unnoticed by research using

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Romney and Batchelder. Her current research interests include medical topics such as diabetes, AIDS, and asthma, as well as social topics such as stress and folk illnesses (see web site section for a link to her profile).

Stephen Levinson is currently one of the directors of the Max Planck Institute for Psycholinguistics. His interest in linguistic diversity and cognition has made him a leading figure in the revival of linguistic relativity in the early 1990s. His own research has challenged ideas on the universality of linguistic and cognitive spatial categories (Levinson 2003). The Max Planck Institute also has a division devoted to comparative studies on cognition, conducting innovative, large scale studies on the topic.

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Principal Concepts:

Cultural Consensus Theory: Developed by A. Kimball Romney, William Batchelder, and Susan Weller in the 1980s as a way to approach cultural knowledge. CCT assumes that cultural knowledge is shared, but too large to be held by a single individual, and thus unevenly distributed. Using a collection of analytical techniques, CCT estimates culturally correct answers to a series of questions while also estimating each participant's degree of knowledge or sharing of answers (Weller 2007). It has become a major component of social, cultural, and medical anthropology and is used in other cognitive sciences and cross-culturally based research. (For more information see Methods section of webpage)

Cultural Consonance Theory: This theory was developed by Alabama's own William Dressler and colleagues (Dressler, Baliero et al. 2007). Cultural consonance refers to the degree to which people's activities match with their beliefs about how they should be. The more their lives match their ideas of

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Cultural Model: "Cultural model" is not a precisely articulated concept but rather it "serves as a catchall phrase for many different kinds of cultural knowledge" (Shore 1996:45). Also known as folk models, cultural models generally refer to the unconscious set of assumptions and understandings members of a society or group share. They greatly affect people's understanding of the world and of human behavior. Cultural models can be thought of as loose, interpretative frameworks. They are both overtly and unconsciously taught and are rooted in knowledge learned from others as well as from accumulated personal experience. Cultural models are not fixed entities but are malleable structures by nature. As experience is ascribed meaning, it can reinforce models; however, specific experiences can also challenge and change models if experiences are considered distinct. Models, nevertheless, can be consciously altered. Most often cultural models are connected to the emotional responses of particular experiences so that people regard their assumptions about the world and the things in it as "natural." If an emotion evokes a response of disgust or frustration, for example, a person can deliberately take action to change the model.

Strauss and Quinn (1994) give an example of a fictional female who has learned the schema for "mother" in conjunction with the schema of a "kitchen." The actor also recognizes the emotional responses of her mother, who feels "stuck" in the kitchen, which incidentally goes unnoticed by the actor's brother. In turn, the actor responds emotionally and acts purposely so she does not end up in a similar situation within her own marriage. It is interesting that Strauss and Quinn note that when the actor and the actor's husband are not acting consciously, but that they unconsciously reproduce the same pattern as the actor's parents.

Domain: A domain is comprised of a set of related ideas or items that form a larger category. Weller and Romney define domain as "an organized set of words, concepts, or sentences, all on the same level of contrast that jointly refer to a single conceptual sphere," (1988: 9). The individual items within a domain partially achieve their meaning from their relationship to other items in a "mutually interdependent system reflecting the way in which a given language or culture classified the relevant conceptual sphere," (1988:9). The respondents should define domain items in their own language. The purpose of having respondents define the domain is to avoid the imposition of the anthropologist's own categories onto the culture or language being studied.

Ethnographic semantics, **ethnoscience**, the **new ethnography**: All of these terms refer to the new directions that the practice of ethnographic collection and interpretation began to take in the 1950s. This approach regards culture as knowledge (D'Andrade 1995:244), as opposed to the materialist notions that had dominated the field. These new movements also produced rigorous formal approaches to informant interviewing, exemplified best in Werner and Schoepfle's methodological compendium, Systematic Fieldwork (1987).

Folk Models: These include games, music, and god sets, used to instruct individuals to negotiate potentially stressful situations (Colby 1996: 212). Thus, a child may learn how to judge speed and distance from hide and seek, which can then be translated into crossing a busy street. John Roberts was the first to use folk models as a subject of study in cognitive anthropology. Some folk and decision models, such as god sets with well-recited attributes, form larger cognitive systems, such as divinatory readings. The diviner, by collecting several readings and training under another diviner learns to read people, and produce divinations that are socially acceptable (Colby 1996:212).

Folk Taxonomies: Much of the early work in ethnoscience concentrated on folk taxonomies, or the way in which people organize certain classes of objects or notions. There is an enormous amount of work in this area. For a sampling of what is out there, interested readers can refer to Harold Conklin's (1972) Folk Classification: A Topically Arranged Bibliography of Contemporary and Background References Through 1971, Department of Anthropology, Yale University.

Knowledge structures: Knowledge structures go beyond the analysis of taxonomies to try to elucidate the knowledge and beliefs associated with the various taxonomies and terminology systems. This includes the study of consensus among individuals in a group, and an analysis of how their knowledge is organized and used as mental scripts and schemata (Colby 1996:210).

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ought to be. The realization of this vision required a change in the social mazeway.

Mental Scripts: Scripts can be thought of as a set of certain actions one performs in a given situation. Examples would include behavior in a doctor's office, or in a restaurant. There are certain codified and predictable exchanges with minor individual variations (Shore 1996:43). Existing scripts do not determine the details of an interaction, but rather set schemes or recipes for action in a given social situation.

Prototypes: Prototype theory is a theory of categorization. The "best example" of a category is a prototype (Lakoff, 1987). Prototypes are used as a reference point in making judgments of the similarities and differences in other experiences and things in the world. Lakoff (1982:16), for example, states that in comparison to other types of birds the features of robins are judged to be more representative of the category "bird" just as desk chairs are considered more exemplary of the category chair than are rocking chairs or electric chairs. Membership largely hinges on a cluster of features a form embodies. Every member may not possess all of the attributes, but is nonetheless still regarded as a type. When a type is contrasted with the prototype certain clusters of features are typically more crucial for category measurement (Lakoff 1984:16). Furthermore, two members of a category can have no resemblance with each other, but share resemblance with the prototype and therefore be judged as members of the same category. However, the qualities of a prototype do not dictate category membership exclusively. The degree to which similarity is exhibited by an object or experience does not automatically project that object or experience into category membership. For example, pigs are not categorized as dogs just because they share some features with the prototype of dog (Lakoff 1982: 17).

Schemata: This has been one of the most important and powerful concepts for cognitive anthropology in the past twenty years. Bartlett first developed the notion of a schema in the 1930s. He proposed that remembering is guided by a mental structure, a schema, "an active organization of past reactions, or of past experiences, which must always be supposed to be operational in any well-adapted organic response (Schacter 1989:692). Cognitive anthropologists and scientists have modified this notion somewhat since then. A schema is an "organizing experience," implying activation of the whole. An example is the English term writing. When one thinks of writing, several aspects come into play that can denote the action of guiding a trace leaving implement across a surface, such as writer, implement, surface, and so on. While an individual schemas may differ, cognitive anthropologists search for the common notions that can provide keys to the mental structures behind cultural notions. These notions are not necessarily culturally universal. In Japanese, the term kaku is usually translated into English as writing. However, whereas in English, nearly everyone would consider writing to imply that language is being traced onto a surface, the term kaku in Japanese can mean language, doodles, pictures, or anything else that is traced onto a surface. Therefore, schemas are culturally specific, and the need for an emic view is still a primary force in any ethnographic research (D'Andrade 1995:123).

Semantic studies: Concerned primarily with terminology classifications, especially kinship classification (e.g. Lounsbury 1956), and plant taxonomies. In recent years, a greater emphasis has been directed towards the development of semantic theory (Colby 1996:210).

Semantic theory: A recent development, semantic theory is built upon an extensionistic approach that was first developed with kin terminologies and then extended to other domains (Colby 1996: 211). There are core meanings and extensional meanings, the core meanings varying less among informants than the extensional meanings. For example, the term cups can have a core meaning, or referent, that most Americans would agree to, such as a "semi-cylindrical container, made of porcelain, having a handle, and being approximately 4 to 5 inches tall." However, some would disagree about whether a large plastic container with no handle whose purpose is to hold beverages is a cup, or a glass, or neither (Kronenfeld 1996:6-7).

Methodologies:

Hallmarks of cognitive anthropology are the rigorous elicitation procedures and controlled questioning of native speakers, which produced greater precision, and the careful analysis of the distinctive mental features of human cognition and social activity (Atran in Boyer 1993: 48). Several early methodologies used by

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with a general concept, which is divided into more precise categories and terms, which are in turn segmented again. This process is repeated until no further subdivisions are possible. Complete paradigms, on the other hand, occur when general terms can be combined with other general terms within the paradigm so that all potential features transpire; however, most paradigms are incomplete. Paradigms can be thought of in terms of a matrix structure. So, for example, D'Andrade (1995) depicts an almost complete paradigmatic structure of English terms for humans. The possible combinations of types of humans consist of woman, man, girl, boy and baby. The features that are contrasted are age (adult, immature and newborn) and gender (female and male). The paradigm would be complete if there were particular terms to refer to female and male newborns rather than the generic term baby. The fundamental difference between a paradigm and taxonomy is the way distinctions are structured; the primary commonality is that terms within each are structured in relation to other terms to form patterns based on the discrimination of features.

Folk taxonomies as briefly alluded to above, are also aimed at understanding how people cognitively organize information. Folk taxonomies are classes of phenomena arranged by inclusion criteria that show the relationship between kinds of things. Simply put, is X a kind of Y. They are based on levels. The first level, called the unique beginner, is the all-inclusive general category. Succeeding distinctions are then made by the judgment of similarity and dissimilarity of items to form additional levels. With each separation the levels become more explicit and the differences between groups of items more miniscule. Take for example, as D'Andrade notes (1995:99), the category of creature in the English language. Creature, the unique beginner is rank zero, is subdivided into insect, fish, bird and animal forming rank one, or the life form level. Each class of items can be further subdivided into another level, termed the intermediate level. One of the "animal" divisions is cat. Items in the "cat" category can then be distributed into the following level, known as the generic level or rank two, to include cat, tiger, and lion. The cat occurring in rank two can be divided into the specific level, or rank three. Specific level terms include Persian cat, Siamese cat, ordinary cat, and Manx cat.

Feature models are not only concerned with how people organize information, but also what the organization means in terms of mental information processing. Bruner, Goodnow, and Austin (1956 described in D'Andrade 1995:93) maintain that there are two primary mechanisms for reducing the strain on short-term memory: attribute reduction and configurational recoding. Attribute reduction describes the tendency to contract the number of criterial features of an object down to a very small number, five or six, and ignore other attributes. Configurational recoding is based on the chunking together of several features to form a single characteristic. Chunking is a mental process where the short-term memory segments information by grouping items together. Local phone numbers, such as 378-9976, are chunked into two parts 378 and 9976. The second segment can again be chunked into 99 and 76.

The psychobiological constraints placed on the human mind's capacity for organizing materials and phenomena are of central importance in cognitive anthropology. There are a myriad of things in the world that the mind comes into contact with in daily life. To be able to function, the mind manufactures discriminations of attributes so it can process information without responding to information as if it were new e[illegible] short-term memory. In a cross-cultural study of kinship terminologies Wallace (1964 in D'Andrade 1995) noted that c[illegible]e the social and technological complexity of societies that the size of kinship terminologies ge[illegible]y remain constant. He found terminologies basically consisted of a maximum of six binary distinctions between classes producing a possibility of sixty-four combinations of terms. He concluded there must be a psychobiological foundation for this limitation or greater variety would be observed across societies. This finding became known as the 26 rule. Wallace was, nonetheless, not the first to propose this kind of finding. In 1956 Miller, in a now famous paper "The Magical Number Seven, Plus or Minus Two" (known as the 27 rule), reported that people could make seven concurrent distinctions in processing information in short-term memory before a notable drop-off transpired.

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The implications these finding have for cognitive anthropology cannot be underestimated. Essentially, they help to create a cognitive model of the mind that combines both cultural and biological aspects of human life (D'Andrade, 1995). Cultural information and criteria for organizing information is culturally-based, but the

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but instead are used to produce ethnographic data in aid of advancing theoretical knowledge of how the mind operates. The editors of a book devoted to cognitive methodology note that "this volume compels field researchers to take very seriously not only what they hear, but what they ask," (Weller and Romney 1988:5). This transformation has substantially altered the variety of work produced by cognitive anthropologists. While modern methodologies have become more elaborate and sophisticated they remain anchored in the premises of the early feature model.

Moreover, methods also remain centered on the concept of domain, yet they go beyond simply eliciting lists of things belonging to a particular category. Current methodologies have attempted to overcome the earlier problem of pursuing allegedly "meaningless" subjects such as taxonomies of plants, although these subjects were critical in isolating cognitive mechanisms of information processing at the onset of this scientific project. Modern methodologies tackle more complex topics. For example, Garro (1988) examined the explanatory model of two domains, causes and symptoms, of high blood pressure among Ojibway Indians living in Manitoba, Canada to assess how they were related to each other.

Cognitive anthropologists stress systematic data collection and analysis in addressing issues of reliability and validity and, consequently, rely heavily on structured interviewing and statistical analyses. Their techniques can be divided into three groups that produce different sorts of data: similarity techniques, ordering techniques, and test performance techniques (Weller and Romney, 1988). Similarity methods call for respondents to judge the likeness of particular items. Ordered methods require the ranking of items along a conceptual scale. Test performance methods regard respondents as "correct" or "incorrect" depending on how they execute a specified task. Specific methods used by cognitive anthropologists include free listing, frame elicitation, triad tests, pile sorts, paired comparisons, rank order, true and false tests, and cultural consensus tasks.

A key feature of cognitive studies is that respondents are asked to define categories and terms in their own language. It is assumed that the anthropologist and the respondents do not have identical understandings of domains. Therefore, the elicitation of a specific domain is typically the first step in these studies. The boundaries of culturally relevant items within a domain can be determined through a variety of techniques. Domains can be delineated by the free listing method where respondents are asked to list all the kinds of X they know, or why they chose X over Y. Sometimes group interviews are used to define domains. Free lists can be analyzed in three ways: by the ordering of terms, by the frequency of terms, and by the use of modifiers. The saliency of mentioned items is determined either by the ordering of terms, where the most salient items occur at the top of the list, or by the frequency elicited. Weller and Romney (1988:11) note that most free lists produced by individuals are not complete but as the sample increases the list stabilizes. Items in a free list must be recorded verbatim to probe for the definition of the item cited. The decision about where the cut-off point should be located is subjective, but depends on the purpose of the study, the number of elicited terms, and the type of data collection employed (Weller and Romney, 1988).

Once a domain has been delimited a number of possibilities face the researcher. One option is the pile sort method, which can be either a single sort or a successive sort. In a single sort terms (or sometimes pictures or colors depending on the subject) from the free list are placed on individual index cards. They are shuffled at the beginning of each interview to ensure randomness. Respondents are asked to group the cards in terms of similarity so that most like terms are in the same pile and unlike terms are not. After the piles have been arranged the respondent is asked why terms were grouped as they were. An item-by-item matrix is then created. If terms were placed in the same pile they receive a code of one, if terms were not placed in the same pile they receive a code of zero. Matrices are tabulated for both individuals and the group. Conducting a successive pile sort is slightly different. Terms from the free list are sorted into piles, as in the single sort method, but respondents are restricted into separating the terms into two groups. Respondents are then asked to subdivide the initial piles. The continual process of subdividing a pile is repeated until it can no longer occur. This method enables the creation of a taxonomic tree for individuals, a group, or both. The structures produced by individuals can be compared.

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[illegible] informants. Triad sorts have been used in studies of kinship terminologies, animal terms, occupations and disease terms (Weller and Romney, 1988). To conduct a triad test the number of triads must be calculated with a mathematical formula. All potential combinations of items are then compiled. If items in a domain are vast, a balanced incomplete block triad design can reduce the total number of triads (see Weller and Romney for details, 1988). Triad sets and the position of terms within each triad are then randomized. Interpretative data can be collected from the respondents after they have completed the triad task to find out the criteria for the choices they made. Tabulation varies depending on the kind of data used in the triad. If the data were rank ordered, the ranks are summed across items for each informant; however, if similarity data were used, responses are arranged in a similarity matrix (Weller and Romney, 1988:36). A similarity matrix can be created for each individual and for the group. Weller and Romney (1988) suggest hierarchical clustering or multidimensional scaling for descriptive analysis.

Consensus theory directly addresses issues of reliability in data collection not of the information collected, but rather of the people interviewed. It aids a researcher to, "describe and measure the extent to which cultural beliefs are shared . . . If the beliefs represented by the data are not shared, the analysis will show this," (Romney, 1999). Data is determined to be correct or incorrect by the respondents; the researcher codes their answers. True-false, multiple choice, fill-in-the-blank, rank order, interval estimates and matching formats can all be used in consensus theory. For example, in true-false formats respondents are asked to determine whether a set of statements is correct, coded as one, or incorrect, coded as zero.

Consensus theory requires response data (either interval or dichotomous), rather than performance data in which respondents themselves are coded as being correct or incorrect. Consensus theory measures how much a respondent knows and seeks to aggregate the answers of several respondents to achieve a synthesized representation of their knowledge. The goal of consensus theory is to use the pattern of agreement among respondents to make inferences about their knowledge (Weller and Romney, 1988:74). Furthermore, a consensus model assumes that the relationship between respondents is a function of the level of their competency with respect to some domain of knowledge; it allows a researcher to gauge how much a particular respondent knows in relation to other respondents. Respondents can then be weighted in terms of their competency relative to each other.

Using a true-false format, Garro (1988) employed consensus theory in a study of high blood pressure among Ojibway Indians. Garro combined the complementary methods explanatory models (EMs) in addition to true-false tests. Different EMs were elicited. EMs collect data about the descriptions of, the meaning of, the experience and the consequences of illness. True-false questions were aimed at uncovering the reasoning behind the answers of the EMs. In describing consensus theory she states, "the purpose of this analysis is to determine the level of sharing and the degree to which individual informants approach the shared knowledge," (1988:100). After conducting the EM interviews she took several items (causes and symptoms) and constructed a similarity matrix. Factor analysis was then performed to determine the degree to which the domain was shared among respondents. Also using factor analysis to achieve competency values, respondents were then rated in terms of their degree of knowledge of the domain. Respondents' competency values were weighted with more weight given to more knowledgeable respondents. A true-false test was given to all respondents. Individual answers were determined to be correct or incorrect from the pattern of correspondence as compared with the previously weight values of respondents who exhibited a high agreement with the group.

Although this review has not exhausted all of the various methods contemporary cognitive anthropologist use, it does portray them in general. Cognitive anthropology is driven by methodology. Emphasis is and always has been given to systematic data collection in an effort to attain reliable and valid results. The ultimate aim, however, is nothing less than discovering and representing mental processes. But a shift has occurred recently. Many anthropologists are using cognitive techniques for the purpose of eliciting information to facilitate ethnographic description. Applied anthropologists are particularly interested in these techniques. If the past is any indicator of the future, cognitive anthropology will continue to develop around the systematic and structured collection of data.

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descriptions of cultural representations. Additionally, it has challenged ideas of monolithic culture and has helped to bridge culture and the functioning of the mind. The culture and personality approach helped demonstrate how an individual's socialization influenced personality systems that, in turn, influenced cultural practices and beliefs. The psyche is influenced by the representations it learns by participating in the human cultural heritage. That heritage is in turn influenced by the limitations and capacities of the human cognitive system (D'Andrade 1995:251-252). Cognitive anthropology has helped reveal some of the inner workings of the human mind, and given us a greater understanding of how people order and perceive the world around them. By far, cognitive anthropology's most notable achievement is its development of cultural methodologies that are valid and reliable representations of human thought.

Criticisms:

Some of the most severe criticisms of cognitive anthropology have come from its own practitioners. According to Keesing (1972:307) the so-called "new ethnography" was unable to move beyond the analysis of artificially simplified and often trivial semantic domains. Ethnoscientists tended to study such things as color categories and folk taxonomies, without being able to elucidate their relevance to understanding culture as a whole. Taking a lead from generative grammar in linguistics, ethnoscientists sought cultural grammars, intending to move beyond the analyses of semantic categories and domains into wider behavioral realms. Ethnoscientists attempted to discern how people construe their world from the way they label and talk about it (Keesing 1972:306). However, this study of elements rather than relational systems failed to reveal a generative cultural grammar for any culture, and while generating elaborate taxonomies, failed to discover any internal cultural workings that could be compared internally or externally.

While the cognitive anthropologists of the last two decades have attempted to address these problems, they have created problems of their own. One of the most glaring problems is that almost all investigators do the majority of their research in English. This is to be expected, given the elaborate nature of the investigative methods now being used, but begs the question of just how applicable the results can be for other cultures. In addition, there are multiple factors in operation at any given moment that are difficult to account for using standard methods of cognitive anthropology. Recently, cognitive anthropologists have attempted to explore the emotional characteristics of culture that Bateson, Benedict, and Mead had recognized long ago. The difficulties of managing emotion as a factor in schemata are now being addressed, but it remains to be seen just how successful the cognitive anthropologists will be in linking emotion and reason.

Cognitive anthropology deals with abstract theories regarding the nature of the mind. While there have been a plethora of methods for accessing culture contained in the mind, questions remain about whether results in fact reflect how individuals organize and perceive society, or whether they are merely manufactured by investigators, having no foundation in their subjects' reality. A recent article by Romney and Moore (1998), however, suggests that people do think in terms of loosely articulated categories (domains). They review some pertinent work in the fields of neuroscience and psychology and correlate it with findings in cognitive anthropology. In particular, they note that when people see an object, a representation of the image is constructed in the brain in a one-to-one manner (Romney and Moore, 1998:322). Images that visually appear close to one another are mapped as such in mental representations (like multidimensional scaling). Furthermore, people who have experienced some sort of head trauma lose memory not randomly, but systematically. Chunks of knowledge are forgotten, knowledge that concerns certain domains, implying that, "the set of words in a semantic domain may be localized functional units in the brain," (Romney and Moore, 1998:325).

Another criticism is that universal agreement on how to find culture in the mind has yet to emerge. When one compares the works of major figures in the field, such as D'Andrade, Kronenfeld, and Shore, it is clear they each have a different idea about just how to pursue the goals of the field. While some may contend that this is a deficiency, it attests to the field's vitality and the centrality of the issues under contention. Moreover, when approaching an issue as complex as the human mind, mental processes, and culture, it is salutary to seek a multifaceted convergence.

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and in understanding people's worldviews through cognitive anthropology. It is an exciting and fascinating field that offers both theoretical and methodological insight to nearly every anthropologist. Cognitive anthropology has something to offer each of anthropology's four fields: archaeology, biological anthropology, linguistics, and cultural anthropology. Moreover, it has significantly changed the face of cultural anthropology, particularly with respect to its methodological development. Cognitive methods are used in a variety of anthropological contexts and applied to a variety of subjects. While cognitive anthropology has relied on a strong tradition of linguistic and cultural approaches, perhaps its greatest challenge lay in demonstrating its applicability to the biological and archaeological subfields. In short, cognitive anthropology holds much promise for the future of cultural analysis.

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Relevant Web Links:

- Cognitive Science. Paul Thagard's entry in the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy.
- Connectionism James Garson's entry in the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy.
- http://www.cognitionandculture.net/ - A blog maintained by the Institute of Cognition and Culture, featuring information on recent articles and lectures on relevant topics. See also http://www.qub.ac.uk/schools/InstituteofCognitionCulture/
- http://cocoa.eva.mpg.de/ - Max Planck Research Group Comparative Cognitive Anthropology.
- http://cogsnews.ucsd.edu/ - Listings of some recent articles relating to cognitive science.
- http://cognition.clas.uconn.edu/~jboster/articles/coganth.pdf - A discussion of representations of three key domains in cognitive anthropology: kinship terminologies, color categories, and enthnobiology.
- http://www.brill.nl/journal-cognition-and-culture - Interdisciplinary publication concerned with "the mental foundations of culture and the cultural foundations of mental life." (Institutional or individual subscription required, inquire with your local library).

People (most feature publication lists and/or CVs)

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- http://www.yale.edu/seas/Conklin.htm - Brief biographical sketch of Harold Conklin.
- http://www.imbs.uci.edu/personnel/romney/romney.html - Faculty page for A. Kimball Romney.
- http://anthropology.usf.edu/faculty/baer/ - Roberta Baer's information page.
- http://www.mpi.nl/people/levinson-stephen-c. – Stephen Levinson's Max Planck page.

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The University of Alabama

Department of Anthropology

ANTHROPOLOGICAL THEORIES

A GUIDE PREPARED BY STUDENTS FOR STUDENTS

The guides to anthropological theories and approaches listed below have been prepared by graduate students of the University of Alabama under the direction of Dr. Michael D. Murphy. As always, *!Caveat Retis Viator!* (Let the Net Traveller Beware!)

Select a Theory: Go

OR

Search the theory database

Cultural Materialism

Catherine Buzney and Jon Marcoux

(Note: authorship is arranged stratigraphically with the most recent author listed first)

Basic Premises:

Coined by Marvin Harris in his 1968 text, The Rise of Anthropological Theory, cultural materialism embraces three anthropological schools of thought, cultural materialism, cultural evolution and cultural ecology (Barfield 1997: 232). Risen as an expansion of Marxism materialism, cultural materialism explains cultural similarities and differences as well as models for cultural change within a societal framework consisting of three distinct levels: infrastructure, structure and superstructure. Cultural materialism promotes the idea that infrastructure, consisting of "material realities" such as technological, economic and reproductive (demographic) factors mold and influence the other two aspects of culture. The "structure" sector of culture consists of organizational aspects of culture such as domestic and kinship systems and political economy, while the "superstructure" sector consists of ideological and symbolic aspects of society such as religion. Therefore, cultural materialists believe that technological and economic aspects play the primary role in shaping a society. Cultural materialism aims to understand the effects of technological, economic and demographic factors on molding societal structure and superstructure through strictly scientific methods. As stated by Harris, cultural materialism strives to "cre ate a pan-human science of society whose findings can be accepted on logical and evidentiary grounds by the pan-human community" (Harris 1979: xii). Cultural materialism is an expansion upon Marxist materialism. Marx suggested that there are three levels of culture, infrastructure, structure, and superstructure; however, unlike Marxist theory, cultural materialism views both productive (economic) and reproductive (demographic) forces as the primary factors which shape society. Therefore, cultural materialism explains the

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structural features of a society in terms of production within the infrastructure only (Harris 1996: 277). As such, demographic, environmental, and technological changes are invoked to explain cultural variation (Barfield 1997: 232).

In contrast to cultural materialists, Marxists argue that production is a material condition located in the base (See American Material Page) that acts upon and is acted upon by the infrastructure (Harris 1996: 277-178). Furthermore, while Marxist theory suggests that production is a material condition located in the base of society that engages in a reciprocal relationship with societal structure, both acting and being acted upon by the infrastructure sector, cultural materialism proposes that production lies within the infrastructure and that the infrastructure-structure relationship is unidirectional (Harris 1996: 277-278). Thus, cultural materialists see the infrastructure-structure relationship as being mostly in one direction, while Marxists see the relationship as reciprocal. Cultural materialism also differs from Marxism in its lack of class theory. While Marxism suggests that culture change only benefits the ruling class, cultural materialism addresses relations of unequal power recognizing innovations or changes that benefit both upper and lower classes (Harris 1996: 278). Despite the fact that both cultural materialism and Marxism are evolutionary in proposing that culture change results from innovations selected by society because of beneficial increases to productive capabilities, cultural materialism does not envision a final utopian form as visualized by Marxism (Engels, quoted by Harris 1979: 141-142; Harris 1996: 280).

Cultural Materialists believe that all societies operate according to model in which production and reproduction dominate and determine the other sectors of culture (See Key Concepts 'Priority of Infrastructure'), effectively serving as the driving forces behind all cultural development. They propose that all non-infrastructure aspects of society are created with the purpose of benefitting societal productive and reproductive capabilities. Therefore, systems such as government, religion, law, and kinship are considered to be constructs that only exist for the sole purpose of promoting production and reproduction. Calling for empirical research and strict scientific methods in order to make accurate comparisons between separate cultures, proponents of cultural materialism believe that its perspective effectively explains both intercultural variation and similarities (Harris 1979: 27). As such, demographic, environmental, and technological changes are invoked to explain cultural variation (Barfield 1997: 232).

Points of Reaction:

As with other forms of materialism, cultural materialism emerged in the late 1960s as a reaction to cultural relativism and idealism. At the time, anthropological thought was dominated by theorists who located culture change in human systems of thought rather than in material conditions (i.e. Durkheim and Levi-Strauss). Harris critiqued idealist and relativist perspectives which claimed that comparisons between cultures are non-productive and irrelevant because each culture is a product of its own dynamics. Marvin Harris argued that these approaches remove culture from its material base and place it solely within the minds of its people. With their strictly emic approach, Harris stated that idealists and relativists fail to be holistic, violating a principal tenet of anthropological research (see Key Concepts) (Harris 1979; 1996: 277). By focusing on observable, measurable phenomena, cultural materialism presents an etic (viewed from outside of the target culture) perspective of society.

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Leading Figures:

Marvin Harris (1927-) was educated at Columbia University where he received his Ph.D. in 1953. In 1968, Harris wrote The Rise of Anthropological Theory in which he lays out the foundations of cultural materialism (CM) and critically considers other major anthropological theories; this work drew significant criticism from proponents of other viewpoints. (Barfield 1997: 232). Harris studied cultural evolution using a CM research strategy. His work with India's sacred cow myth (1966) is seen by many as his most successful CM analysis (Ross 1980). In this work, Harris considers the taboo against cow consumption in India, demonstrating how economic and technological factors within the infrastructure affect the other two sectors of culture, resulting in superstructural ideology. In this work, Harris shows the benefits of juxtaposing both etic and emic perspectives in demonstrating how various phenomena which appear non-adaptive are, in fact, adaptive. Harris also made a concerted effort to write for a more general audience. His 1977 work Cannibals and Kings: The Origins of Culture laid out in CM terms the evolutionary trajectories that lead to all features of human society (i.e., population growth, technological change, ecological change) (Harris 1977). This work also represents the point at whi ch many believe Harris started placing too much emphasis on material conditions in explaining human society (Brfield 1997: 232). Harris' critics argued that his use of CM to explain all cultural phenomena was too simplistic and, as a result, many criticized and even dismissed his work (Friedman 1974).

In spite of his critics, Harris left a significant legacy having successfully created an anthropological theory and disseminated it to both students and the public. His work is widely cited by both proponents and critics of cultural materialism, and as of 1997, Harris' anthropological textbook Culture, People, Nature was in its seventh edition, attesting to the quality of his work (Barfield 1997: 232).

Julian Steward (1902 – 1972) developed the principal of cultural ecology, which holds that the environment is an additional, contributing factor in the shaping of cultures. He defined multilinear evolution as a methodology concerned with regularity in social change, the goal of which is to develop cultural laws empirically. He termed his approach multilinear evolution, and defined it as "a methodology concerned with regularity in social change, the goal of which is to develop cultural laws empirically" (Bohannan and Glazer 1988:321). In essence, Steward proposed that, methodologically, one must look for "parallel developments in limited aspects of the cultures of specifically identified societies" (Hoebel 1958:90). Once parallels in development are identified, one must then look for similiar causal explanations. Steward also developed the idea of culture types that have "cross-cultural validity and show the following characteristics: (1) they are made up of selected cultural elements rather than cultures as wholes; (2) these cultural elements must be selected in relationship to a problem and to a frame of reference; and (3) the cultural elements that are selected must have the same functional relationships in every culture fitting the type" (Bohannan and Glazer 1988:321).

Leslie White (1900 – 1975) was concerned with ecological anthropology and energy capture as a measure by which to define the complexity of a culture. He was heavily influenced by Marxian economic theory as well as Darwinian evolutionary theory. He proposed that Culture = Energy * Technology, suggesting that "culture evolves as the amount of energy harnessed per captia per year is increased, or as the efficiency of the instrumental means of putting the energy to work is increased" (Bohannan and

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Glazer 1988:340). Energy capture is accomplished through the technological aspect of culture so that a modification in technology could, in turn, lead to a greater amount of energy capture or a more efficient method of energy capture thus changing culture. In other words, "we find that progress and development are effected by the improvement of the mechanical means with which energy is harnessed and put to work as well as by increasing the amounts of energy employed" (Bohannan and Glazer 1988:344). Another premise that White adopts is that the technological system plays a primary role or is the primary determining factor within the cultural system. White's materialist approach is evident in the following quote: "man as an animal species, and consequently culture as a whole, is dependent upon the material, mechanical means of adjustment to the natural environment" (Bohannan and Glazer 1988).

R. Brian Ferguson is a professor within the Department of Anthropology at Rutgers University. Ferguson's research interests include warfare and political economy in Puerto Rico. He has published several books including Warfare, Culture, and Environment (1984) and Yanomami Warfare: A Political History (1995). Ferguson's approach to anthropology is very similar to that of cultural materialism, but he argues that the infrastructural factors are not the only sources of culture change;Fergusoninstead, he argues that causal factors may exist throughout the entire sociocultural system, including both structural and superstructural sectors (Ferguson 1995: 24). For example, Ferguson argues that Puerto Rican sugar plantations were, in fact, cartels politically maintained by statutes of the U.S. congress (Ferguson 1995: 33). Furthermore, he argued that these structural factors allowed for economic inefficiency which ultimately led to the collapse of Puerto Rico's sugar plantations, subsequently causing hardships for all citizens (Ferguson 1996: 33). In this case, he argues that the infrastructure was affected by the structure (i.e., the biological well being of citizens of Puerto Rico was affected by a wholly structural factor).

Martin F. Murphy is the chairperson of the Anthropology Department at the University of Notre Dame. . He has published widely on the subject of political organization in the Caribbean, including the book Dominican Sugar Plantations: Production and Foreign Labor Integration (1991) (Murphy and Margolis 1995: 213). In this 1991 work, Murphy seeks to explain the use of foreign labor in sugar production as a response to material conditions such as demography and technology. Specifically, the use of foreign labor, such as Haitian immigrants, is seen as a response to a shortage of native Dominicans who are willing to do that type of intensive labor (1991).

Maxine L. Margolis is a professor of anthropology who works with Marvin Harris at the University of Florida. She has studied culture both in the United States and Brazil with a focus on gender, international migration, and anthropological ecology (Murphy and Margolis 1995: 213). Her works include Mothers and Such: Views of American Women and Why They Changed (1984) and The Moving Frontier: Social and Economic Change in a Southern Brazilian Community (1973). See "Methodologies" for an example of her CM analysis.

Allen Johnson currently teaches at the University of California, Los Angeles. His research applies a cultural materialism framework to economic anthropology (Murphy and Margolis 1995: 212). One of his most notable works, The Evolution of Human Societies: From Foraging Group to Agrarian State (1987) was co-written with

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the notable materialist archaeologist Timothy Earle. In this work, the authors use empirical grounds to argue that population growth is a prime cause for culture change; population growth leads to competition for resources among egalitarian groups, and this competition acts as a catalyst in forming new adaptive modes (Johnson and Earle 1987). Some of these new adaptive modes involve an increase in inequality and the rise of stratified societies. Thus, they argue that social evolution is driven by infrastructural causes.

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Principal Concepts:

Emic: This term denotes an approach to anthropological inquiry where the observer attempts to "get inside the heads" of the natives and learn the rules and categories of a culture in order to be able to think and act as if they were a member of the population (Harris 1979: 32). For example, an emic approach might attempt to understand native Faeroe islanders' highly descriptive system for naming geographic locations. Cultural materialism focuses on how the emics of thought and the behavior of a native population are the results of etic processes (i.e., observable phenomena).

Etic: This term denotes an approach to anthropological inquiry where the observer does not emphasize or use native rules or categories but instead uses "alien" empirical categories and rules derived from the strict use of the scientific method. Quantifiable measurements such as fertility rates, kilograms of wheat per household, and average rainfall are used to understand cultural circumstances, regardless of what these measurements may mean to the individuals within the population (Harris 1979:32). An example of this approach can be found in Paynter and Cole's work on tribal political economy (Paynter and Cole 1980). Cultural materialism focuses on the etics of thought and the etics of behavior of a native population to explain culture change.

Etic behavioral mode of production: The etic behavioral mode of production involves the actions of a society that satisfy the minimal requirements for subsistence (Harris 1979: 51). The important thing to remember here is that these actions are determined and analyzed from a scientific perspective, without regard for their meaning to the members of the native society.

Etic behavioral mode of reproduction: The etic behavioral mode of reproduction involves the actions that a society takes in order to limit detrimental increases or decreases to population (Harris 1979: 1951). These actions are determined and analyzed from a scientific perspective by the observer, without regard for their meaning to the members of the native society.

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Infrastructure: The infrastructure consists of etic behavioral modes of production and etic modes of reproduction as determined by the combination of ecological, technological, environmental, and demographic variables (Harris 1996: 277).

Structure: The structure is characterized by the organizational aspects of a culture consisting of the domestic economy (e.g., kinship, division of labor) and political economy (Harris 1996: 277). Political economy involves issues of control by a force above that of the domestic household whether it be a government or a chief.

Superstructure: The superstructure is the symbolic or ideological segment of culture. Ideology consists of a code of social order regarding how social and political organization is structured (Earle 1997: 8). It structures the obligations and rights of all the members of society. The superstructure involves things such as ritual, taboos, and symbols (Harris 1979: 229).

Priority of Infrastructure: In Harris' words, "The etic behavioral modes of production and reproduction probabilistically determine the etic behavioral domestic and political economy, which in turn probabilistically determine the behavioral and mental emic superstructures" (Harris 1979: 55-56). In other words, the main factor in determining whether a cultural innovation is selected by society lies in its effect on the basic biological needs of that society. These innovations can involve a change in demographics, technological change and/or environmental change in the infrastructure. The innovations within the infrastructure will be selected by a society if they increase productive and reproductive capabilities even when they are in conflict with structural or superstructural elements of society (Harris 1996: 278). Innovations can also take place in the structure (e.g., changes in government) or the superstructure (e.g., religious change), but will only be selected by society if they do not diminish the ability of society to satisfy basic human needs. Therefore, the driving force behind culture change is satisfying the basic needs of production and reproduction.

Methodologies:

Harris writes, "Empirical science...is the foundation of the cultural materialist way of knowing" (Harris 1979: 29). Epistemologically, cultural materialism focuses only on those entities and events that are observable and quantifiable (Harris 1979: 27). In keeping with the scientific method, these events and entities must be studied using operations that are capable of being replicated (Harris 1979: 27). Using empirical methods, cultural materialists reduce cultural phenomena into observable, measurable variables that can be applied across societies to formulate nomothetic theories.

Harris's basic approach to the study of culture is to show how emic (native) thoughts and behaviors are a result of material considerations. Harris focuses on practices that contribute to the basic biological survival of those in society (i.e., subsistence practices, technology, and demographic issues). In order to demonstrate this point, analysis often involves the measurement and comparison of phenomena that might seem trivial to the native population (Harris 1979: 38). Harris used a cultural materialist model to examine the Hindu belief that cows are sacred and must not be killed.. First, he argued that the taboos on cow slaughter (emic thought) were superstructural elements resulting from the economic need to utilize cows as draft animals rather than as food (Harris 1966: 53-5 4). He also observed that the Indian farmers claimed that no calves died because cows are sacred (Harris 1979: 38). In

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reality, however, male calves were observed to be starved to death when feed supplies are low (Harris 1979: 38). Harris argues that the scarcity of feed (infrastructural change) shaped ideological (superstructural) beliefs of the farmers (Harris 1979: 38). Thus, Harris shows how, using empirical methods, an etic perspective is essential in order to understand culture change holistically.

Another good example of cultural materialism at work involves the study of women's roles in the post-World War II United States. Maxine Margolis empirically studied this phenomenon and interpreted her findings according to a classic cultural materialist model. The 1950's was a time when ideology held that the duties of women should be located solely in the home (emic thought); however, empirically, Margolis found that women were entering the workforce in large numbers (actual behavior) (Margolis 1984). This movement was an economic necessity that increased the productive and reproductive capabilities of U.S. households (Margolis 1984).Furthermore, Margolis argues that the ideological movement known as "feminism" did not cause this increase of women in the workforce, but rather was a result of this movement by women into the workforce (Margolis 1984). Thus, here we see how infrastructure determined superstructure as ideology changed to suit new infrastructural innovations.

For more examples see Ross 1980.

Accomplishments:

Cultural materialism can be credited with challenging anthropology to use more scientific research methods. Rather than rely solely on native explanations of phenomenon, Harris and others urged analysts to use empirical and replicable methods. Cultural materialism also promoted the notion that culture change can be studied across geographic and temporal boundaries in order to get at so-called universal, nomothetic theories. Some of Harris' work (1966, 1977) shows that logical, scientific explanations for cultural phenomena such as India's beef taboos are possible without invoking mystical or ephemeral causal factors such as are present in structuralist or functionalist interpretations.

Archaeologists, too, have adopted cultural materialist approaches. Archaeologist William Rathje wanted to test many of the assumptions archaeologists have in dealing with waste from the past (Rathje 1992). In pursuit of this aim, Rathje excavated modern landfills in Arizona and other states and took careful measurements of artifact frequencies. One of the many things he did with this data was to test the difference between stated alcohol consumption of informants and actual alcohol consumption (based on refuse evidence). In order to do this, Rathje selected a sample of households from which he collected and analyzed refuse. He also gave those households a questionnaire that asked questions relating to alcohol consumption. After analyzing what people said they drank and what was actually found in the refuse, Rathje found a significant discrepancy between stated and actual alcohol consumption (Rathje 1992). This case study demonstrates that an etic approach to cultural phenomena may uncover vital information that would be otherwise missed by a wholly emic analysis.

Criticisms:

Criticisms of cultural materialism are plentiful in anthropology. As with all of the different paradigms in anthropology (e.g., functionalism, structuralism, and

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Marxism), cultural materialism does have its flaws. Cultural materialism has been termed "vulgar materialism" by Marxists such as J. Friedman because opponents believe that the cultural materialists empirical approach to culture change is too simple and straightforward (Friedman 1974). Marxists believe that cultural materialists rely too heavily on the one-directional infrastructure-superstructure relationship to explain culture change, and that the relationship between the "base" (a distinct level of a sociocultural system, underlying the structure, in Marxist terminology) and the superstructure must be dialectically viewed (Friedman 1974). They argue that a cultural materialist approach can disregard the superstructure to such an extent that the effect of superstructure on shaping structural elements can be overlooked.

Idealists such as structuralists (e.g., Durkheim and his followers) argue that the key to understanding culture change lies in the emic thoughts and behaviors of members of a native society. Thus, in contrast to cultural materialists, they argue that there is no need for an etic/emic distinction (Harris 1979: 167). To idealists, the etic view of culture is irrelevant and full of ethnocentrism; furthermore, they argue that culture itself is the controlling factor in culture change (Harris 1979: 167). In their view, culture is based on a panhuman structure embedded within the brain, and cultural variation is the result of each society's filling that structure in their own way (Harris 1979: 167). They argue that the cultural materialist emphasis on an etic perspective creates biased conclusions.

Postmodernists also argue vehemently against cultural materialism because of its use of strict scientific method. Postmodernists believe that science is itself a culturally determined phenomenon that is affected by class, race and other structural and infrastructural variables (Harris 1995: 62). In fact, some postmodernists argue that science is a tool used by upper classes to oppress and dominate lower classes (Rosenau 1992: 129). Thus, postmodernists argue that the use of any science is useless in studying culture, and that cultures should be studied using particularism and relativism (Harris 1995: 63). This is a direct attack on cultural materialism with its objective studies and cross-cultural comparisons.

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- **Description of Cultural Materialism** (Wikipedia, http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cultural_materialism_(anthropology))
- **Marvin Harris' "The Rise of Anthropological Theory: A History of Theories of Culture"** (Google Books, http://books.google.com/books?id=yUUYN3X18dwC&pg=PR15&lpg=PR15&dq=Marvin+Harris&source=bl&ots=87FpIeTdS6)
- **Kenneth E. Lloyd's "Behavioral anthropology: A review of Marvin Harris' Cultural Materialism"** (Google Scholar, http://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC1348137/)
- **Marvin Harris's Description of Cultural Materialism** (Rogers State University, http://www.faculty.rsu.edu/~felwel l/Theorists/Harris/Index.htm)
- **Marvin Harris' "Cultural Materialism and Behavior Analysis: Common Problems and Radical Solutions"** (PubMed Central, http://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC2223157/)
- **Online Powerpoint Presentation on New Historicism and Cultural Materialism** (AuthorStream, http://www.authorstream.com/Presentation/Haylee-15615-new-historicism-cultural-materialism-Outline-Foucault-traditional-vs-Archaelogy-historic-presentazione-estetis)
- **Marvin Harris' "Cultural Materialism is Alive and Well and Won't Go Away Until Something Better Comes Along"** (Google Scholar, http://scholar.google.com/scholar?cluster=10125241419856996308&hl=en&as_sdt=200)
- **Marvin Harris' "Theory of Culture and Postmodern Times"** (Google Scholar, http://books.google.com/books?hl=en&lr=&id=t_Iy78J0r-8C&oi=fnd&pg=PA13&dq=Cultural+materialism,+marvin+harris&ots=EvslN3XrXZ&4_yuJpX-Ix5Einzp5AMKkGohM#v=onepage&q=Cultural%20m)
- **Description of Cultural Materialism** (Indiana University, http://www.indiana.edu/~wanthro/theory_pages/Materialism.htm)
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- **Description of Cultural Materialism and Marxist Philosophy** (All about Philosophy, http://www.allaboutphilosophy.org/cultural-materialism.htm)
- **Description of Cultural Materialism** (Psychology Wiki, http://psychology.wikia.com/wiki/Cultural_materialism)
- **Book Review of Harris' "Cultural Materialism: The Struggle for a Science of Culture"** (Danny Reviews, http://dannyreviews.com/h/Cultural_Materialism.html)
- **J. Higgins' "Raymond Williams: Literature, Marxism and Cultural Materialism"** (Google Books, http://books.google.com/books?hl=en&lr=&id=bVL0qrIxkzUC&oi=fnd&pg=PR8&dq=%22cultural+materialism%22&
- **New Historicism and Cultural Materialism** (Google Books, http://books.google.com/books?id=oWicmc9ivqoC&pg=PA9&lpg=PA9&dq=what+is+cultural+materialism&source=b
- **"Cultural Materialism: A Critique by R.S. Neale"** (Google Books, http://www.informaworld.com/smpp/content~content=a793577760&db=all)

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- **Andrew Milner's "Cultural Materialism"** (Google Books, http://books.google.com/books?id=ZcoD4WF3j1wC&printsec=frontcover&dq=cultural+materialism&source=bl&ots=PmnIUk91JKQ6g&hl=en&ei=nRzbS9b3BY_u9QTZ-f1R&sa=X&oi=book_result&ct=)
- **Cultural Materialism: Theory and Practice** (Wiley Publishers, Google Scholar, http://www.wiley.com/WileyCDA/WileyTitle/productCd-063118533X.html)
- **Description of Marvin Harris** (Wikipedia, http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Marvin_Harris)
- **Quotes from Cultural Materialism** (Jon Mattox, http://www.jonmattox.com/grids/people/harris.html)
- **Listing of Books by Marvin Harris on Cultural Materialism** (Book Finder, http://www.bookfinder.com/author/marvin-harris/)

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ANTHROPOLOGICAL THEORIES

A GUIDE PREPARED BY STUDENTS FOR STUDENTS

The guides to anthropological theories and approaches listed below have been prepared by graduate students of the University of Alabama under the direction of Dr. Michael D. Murphy. As always, *!Caveat Retis Viator!* (Let the Net Traveller Beware!)

Select a Theory: Go

OR

Search the theory database

Culture and Personality

Petrina Kelly and Xia Chao and Andrew Scruggs and Lucy Lawrence and Katherine Mcghee-Snow

(Note: authorship is arranged stratigraphically with the most recent author listed first)

Basic Premises:

The culture and personality movement was at the core of anthropology in the first half of the 20th century. It examined the interaction between psychological aspects of the individual and the overreaching culture. Culture and personality was too divided to really be considered a "school of thought." It had no orthodox viewpoint, centralized leadership, or coherent training program (LeVine 2001); however, there were also some basic ideas that most practitioners would agree with. This would include: adult behavior as being "culturally patterned," childhood experiences influencing the individual's personality as an adult, and the adult personality characteristics influencing the cultural institutes such as religion (LeVine 2001). Theorists of culture and personality school argued that socialization creates personality patterns. It shapes a person's emotions, thoughts, behaviors, cultural values and norms to fit into and function as productive members in the surrounding human society. The study of culture and personality wanted to examine how different socialization practices resulted in different personality types.

Culture and personality was one of the reactions against the 19th social evolution and diffusionism just as the functionalism school of Radcliff-Brown and Malinowski was. The views of Franz Boas and some his students (such as Ruth Benedict) argued against that of the early evolutionists, such as Louis Henry Morgan and Edward Tylor, who believe each culture goes through the same hierarchical evolutionary system.

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personality is a ground of the causal explanation of social happenings; when viewed as a product of social evolution it is causally explicable by social happenings."

The field developed more withlater work by Margaret Mead and Ruth Benedict. Mead's Coming of Age in Samoa (1928) provided "the first sustained consideration of the relation between personality and culture," (Winthrop 1991:214). Culture and Personality reached a peak during the 1930s and 1940s and lost support after 1950. It was viewed as being unscholarly, and the few remaining practitioners changed the name to psychological anthropology to avoid the stigma (LeVine 2001). Modern psychological anthropology attempts to bridge the gap between anthropology and psychology by examining how cultures understand human identity and with "cross-cultural study of social, political, and cultural-historical constitution of the self" (Lindholm 2001).

Points of Reaction:

Because of the lack of uniformity in the study of Culture and Personality, there were at least five different viewpoints when studying the interaction between culture and personality. This particular way of dividing the field was taken from LeVine in *Culture, Behavior and Personality* (1982).

Perhaps the most recognizable view was used by Ruth Benedict, Margret Mead, and Geoffrey Gore. It was known as the configuration approach and combined the Boasian idea of cultural relativism with psychological ideas (LeVine 1982:53). It took the stance that the culture and personality were so interconnected that they could not be viewed separately. Often this view is criticized as exaggerating the consistency of the culture and avoiding particulars. Benedict specifically was criticized as being too humanistic and not using enough quantitative data.

A second view was that anti-culture-personality relationship. This view held that there was no need to discuss an individual's psyche. In this view, humans have developed adapted responses to the environmental conditions in order to survive. "Personality types or traits have a single normal distribution replicated in each human society" (LeVine 1982:45). A third view is psychological reductionism. This involved looking at individual psychological aspects as the cause of social behavior. Freud and those who followed him were contenders of this view. Overall, it seems to have gotten the least amount of attention or followers in Culture and Personality.

The last two views, personality mediation and two-systems, are the only two that theories maintained in contemporary anthropology (LeVine 1982:59). Personality mediation was developed by Abram Kardiner, a psychoanalyst, with Ralph Linton, an anthropologist. It theorizes that the environment affects the primary institutions, like the subsistence and settlement patterns, of a society. This, in turn, affects the basic personality structure which then affects the secondary institutions, such as religion. Personality becomes an intervening variable. This view reconciled sociological and cultural approached with that of psychological reductionism.

The two-systems view was developed by Inkeles and Levinson and Melford Spiro. It held that culture and personality interact and balance one another. Spiro specifically was interested "in the ways in which personality affects the operations of the sociocultural system" (LeVine 1981:59). Culture and personality are viewed as aspects of a total field rather than as separate systems or even as legitimate analytical abstractions from data of the same order (Kluckhohn 1954: 685). In other words, culture and personality are interdependent and track along an interconnected curve. Culture influences socialization patterns, which in turn shapes some of the variance of personality (Maccoby 2000). Because of distinctive socialization practices in different societies, each society has unique culture and history. Based on this perspective, one should not assume universal laws govern how cultures run.

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taken into consideration.

Leading Figures:

Sigmund Freud (1856-1939) Freud was a Jewish-Austrian psychiatrist and the most influential psychological theorist of 20th century. He coined the Oedipus complex in psychoanalytical theory. This was a universal phenomenon in which a group of unconscious feelings and ideas centered on the desire to possess the parent of the opposite sex and the harboring of hostility towards the parent of the same sex. Freud's long-sustained interests in anthropology reflect in his anthropological work, *Totem and Taboo*.

Erik Erikson (1902-1994) Erikson was a neo-Freudian, Danish-German-American psychoanalyst who was culture-oriented than other Freudians. He was known for his socio-cultural theory and its impact on human development. Erikson developed Freud's five pscychosexual stages to eight stages of human socialization that were marked by an internal conflict. Erikson believed that the coherence of beliefs and values were very important in structuring personality and that frustrations during infancy were directly reflected in the religion and ritual of the culture (Lindholm 2001).

Edward Sapir (1884-1939) Edward Sapir was born in Germany and came to the United States at age five. He was a close colleague of Ruth Benedict and studied under the tutelage of Franz Boas and Alfred Kroeber. Sapir was recognized as one of the first to explore the relationship between language and anthropology. He perceived language as a tool in shaping human mind and described language as a verbal symbol of human relations. He was noted for exploring the connection among language, personality and social behavior and for the idea of culture best being understood as analogous to personality (Lindholm 2001).

Ruth Benedict (1887-1948) Ruth Benedict was a student of Franz Boas at Columbia University. Her well-known contribution was to the configuration view of Culture and Personality. Like Boas, she believed that culture was the product of human choices rather than cultural determinism. Benedict conducted fieldwork among American Indians, contemporary European and Asian societies. Her key works, *Patterns of Culture* and the *Chrysanthemum and the* Sword, spread the importance of culture in individual personality formation. *Patterns of Culture* summarized Benedict's views on culture and has been one of the best-selling anthropological books.

Margaret Mead (1901-1978) Margaret Mead was born in Philadelphia. She was a student, a lifelong friend, and collaborator of Ruth Benedict. They both studied the relationship among the configuration of culture, socialization in each particular culture and individual personality formation. Mead's works explored human development in a cross-cultural perspective and covered topics on gender roles and childrearing in both American and foreign cultures. Her first work, *Coming of Age in Samoa*, was a best seller and built up Mead as a leading figure in cultural anthropology. The book described how individual development was determined by cultural expectations and was not biologically determined.

Abram Kardiner (1891-1981) Kardiner was born in New York City and was one of the founders of the New York Psychoanalytic Institute. His contribution concerned the interplay of individual personality development and the situated cultures. He developed a psycho-cultural model for the relationship between child-rearing, housing and decent types in the different cultures. He distinguished primary institutions (e.g. child training, toilet behavior and family structure) and secondary institutions (such as religion and art). He explained that basic personality structures in a society influenced the personality types which further influenced the secondary institutions. He also was noted for studying the object relations and ego psychology in psychoanalysis. His interpretations were documented in *The Individual and His Society* (1939) and *Psychological Frontiers of Society* (1945).

Ralph Linton (1893-1953) Ralph Linton was born in Philadelphia, Pennsylvania. He was one of the founders of the basic personality structure theory. He worked on ethnographies of Melanesians and American

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her mentor and collaborator Abram Kardiner in cross-cultural diagnosis and the psychoanalytic study of culture. Between 1937 and 1939, Dubois investigated the island of Alor (now Indonesia) using participant observation, detailed case studies, life-history interviews, and various personality tests. Based on her ethnographic and psychoanalytic study, she wrote the book entitled *The People of Alor* (1944). In this social-psychological study, she advanced the concept of modal personality structure. Cora Dubois stated that individual variation within a culture exists, and each culture shares the development of a particular type which might not exist in its individuals. In 1945, Cora Dubois, Abram Kardiner and Ralph Linton coauthored the book, the *Psychological Frontiers of Society* which consisted of careful descriptions and interpretations of three cultures (the Comanche culture, the Alorese culture, and the culture of an American rural community). It explained the basic personality formed by the diversity of subject matter in each culture.

Clyde Kluckhohn (1905- 1960) Clyde Kluckhohn was an American anthropologist and social theorist. He is noted for his long-term ethnographic work about the Navajo which resulted in two books, *To the Foot of the Rainbow* (1927) and *Beyond the Rainbow* (1933). He co-edited *Personality in Nature, Society, and Culture* (1953) with Henry Murray which demonstrated the variety found within Culture and Personality.

Robert LeVine (1931-Present) Robert LeVine received his degree from the University of Chicago and has taught at Harvard University, University of Chicago, and Northwestern University. He has participated in field research in Kenya, Nigeria, Mexico, Nepal, Zambia, and Venezuela. He is known for keeping helping to revive psychological anthropology and has designed studies that can be applied to a wide variety of social context (Shweder 1999).

Key Works:

Benedict, Ruth

1934 Patterns of Culture. Boston: Houghton Mifflin.

Benedict, Ruth

1946 The Chrysanthemum and the Sword: Patterns of Japanese Culture. Boston: Houghton Mifflin.

Dubois, Cora

1960 The People of Alor. Cambridge Mass.: Harvard University.

Erikson, Erik H.

1950 Childhood and Society. New York: Norton.

Freud, Sigmund

1913 The Interpretation of Dreams. New York: Macmillan

Freud, Sigmund

1950 Totem and Taboo. New York: Norton.

Hsu, Francis

1961 Psychological Anthropology: Approaches to Culture and Personality. Homewood Illinois: Dorsey Press.

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Kluckhohn, et. al.

1945 The Psychological Frontiers of Society. New York: Columbia University Press.

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1953 Personality in Nature, Society and Culture. New York: Alfred A. Knopf.

Linton, Ralph

1945 The Cultural Background of Personality. New York: Appleton-Century-Crofts.

Mead, Margaret

1928 Coming of Age in Samoa: A Psychological Study of Primitive Youth for Western Civilization. New York: William Morrow

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1935 Sex and Temperament in Three Primitive Societies.London: Routledge.

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1949 Culture, Language, and Personality. Berkeley: University of California

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1951 Culture and personality; the natural history of a false dichotomy. Psychiatry: Journal for the Study of Interpersonal Processes, 14:19-40.

Wallace, Anthony

1961 Culture and personality. New York: Random.

Wallace, Anthony & Fogelson, Raymond

1961 Culture and Personality. Biennial Review of Anthropology, 2: 42-78

Principal Concepts:

Basic Personality Structure Approach This approach was developed jointly by Abram Kardiner and Ralph Linton in response to the configurational approach. Kardiner and Linton did not believe that culture types were adequate for differentiating societies. Instead, they offered a new approach which looks at individual members within a society and then compares the traits of these members in order to achieve a basic personality for each culture.

Configurational Approach Edward Sapir and Ruth Benedict developed this school of thought early in the culture and personality studies. The configurational approach believed that culture takes on the character of the members' personality structure. Thus, members of a culture display similar personalities that are further collected as a form of types. Patterns within a culture would be linked by symbolism and interpretation. A culture was defined through a system of common ideas and beliefs, and individuals were considered an integral component of culture.

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Ethnographic field research Study employs empirical data on a society and culture. Data should be collected through participant observation, interviews, questionnaires, etc. Ethnography aims to describe the nature of those who are studied.

Gestalt theory The idea that phenomena need to be studied as whole units rather than in dissected parts (Barnard and Spencer 1996). This German school of thought entered scholarly circles during the late nineteenth and early twentieth century culture and personality approaches.

Modal Personality Approach Modal personality assumes that a certain personality structure is the most frequently occurring structure within a society, but this does not necessarily mean that the structure is common to all members of that society. This approach utilizes projective tests in addition to life histories to create a stronger basis for personality types due to the use of statistics to backup the conclusions (Barnard and Spencer 1996). The concept was developed by cora DuBois.

National Character These studies began during and after World War II. It Ruth Benedict and Margaret Mead led this new attempt to understand different peoples. Through Mead's study of the British, she learned that English women were reliant upon young male's self-control and conditioned not to have to quiet the men's urges. On the other hand, American society held the belief that women should exert their self-control over the men's urges (Singer 1961). Ruth Benedict's The Chrysanthemum and the Sword: Patterns of Japanese Culture (1946) was a national character study on the Japanese culture. Geoffery Gorer wrote *The People of Great Russia* in which he hypothesized that the Russian technique of swaddling their infants led them to develop personalities that are cold and distant. Most national character studies have been heavily criticized as being unanthropological for being too general and having no ethnographic field work incorporated.

Personality Personality is a configuration of cognitions, emotions and habits. Funder offered the specific definition of personality, "An individual's characteristic pattern of thought, emotion, and behavior, together with the psychological mechanisms—hidden or not—behind those patterns" (1997: 1-2). In more modern studies, personality is determined by the trait approach, which assesses individual dispositions. An important turning point in the study of personality was the discovery of the Five-Factor Model, which divided the many descriptive personality words into five categories (Hofstede and McCrae 2004).

Methodologies:

Clinical Interviews Through a variety of methods, the professional is able to record and attempt to understand the internal thoughts and motivations of an individual within a society. The interviews are usually conducted in a specific room or office. This is a method used more by psychoanalysts like Freud than other anthropologists

Dream Analysis This was a part of Freud's psychoanalysis and attempts to seek out the repressed emotions of a person by peeling back the subconscious. This is accomplished through discussion of an individual's dreams.

Life Histories The documentation of an individual's experiences throughout his life. It is most used by members of the Modal Personality Approach and ethnographers. For psychoanalysts, this aids in understanding the underlying reasons for actions in the same way that dream analysis would.

Person-centered Ethnography The term was first used by Robert I. Levy. It is an approach that draws interpretations from psychiatry and psychoanalysis to see how individuals relate and interact with the socio-cultural context.

Participant Observation This is a popular technique with anthropologists in which they spend a prolonged amount of time living with the culture he is studying. This involves a balancing act between watching and

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Projective Tests These are personality tests which have an ambiguous meaning so that a person's thoughts or emotions can be revealed. This can then be compared to other responses. One common test is the Rorschach inkblot test. In this test, an individual must describe what he sees and his perceptions are compared with other results from the society. These tests, however, are very influenced by Western thought which sometimes presents problems when used cross-culturally especially in non-Western cultures.

Accomplishments:

Culture and personality studies have greatly limited the number of racist, hierarchical descriptions of culture types that were common in the early part of this century. Through these studies, a new emphasis on the individual emerged and one of the first links between anthropology and psychology was made. From culture and personality, psychological anthropology developed which is small but still active today.

Criticisms:

Culture and Personality came under the heavy scrutiny of Radcliffe-Brown and other British social anthropologists. They dismissed this view due as a 'vague abstraction' (Barnard and Spencer 1996:140). It was criticized as being unscientific and hard to disprove, and little evidence was given for the connection between child-rearing practices and adulthood personality traits. Benedict and Mead were critiqued for not considering individual variation within a culture and discussing the society as a homologous unit.

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The University of Alabama

Department of Anthropology

ANTHROPOLOGICAL THEORIES

A GUIDE PREPARED BY STUDENTS FOR STUDENTS

The guides to anthropological theories and approaches listed below have been prepared by graduate students of the University of Alabama under the direction of Dr. Michael D. Murphy. As always, *!Caveat Retis Viator!* (Let the Net Traveller Beware!)

Select a Theory: Go

OR

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Diffusionism and Acculturation

Michael Goldstein and Gail King and Meghan Wright

(Note: authorship is arranged stratigraphically with the most recent author listed first)

Basic Premises:

Diffusionism

Diffusionism as an anthropological school of thought, was an attempt to understand the nature of culture in terms of the origin of culture traits and their spread from one society to another. Versions of diffusionist thought included the conviction that all cultures originated from one culture center (heliocentric diffusion); the more reasonable view that cultures originated from a limited number of culture centers (culture circles); and finally the notion that each society is influenced by others but that the process of diffusion is both contingent and arbitrary (Winthrop 1991:83-84).

Diffusion may be simply defined as the spread of a cultural item from its place of origin to other places (Titiev 1959:446). A more expanded definition depicts diffusion as the process by which discrete culture traits are transferred from one society to another, through migration, trade, war, or other contact (Winthrop 1991:82).

Diffusionist research originated in the middle of the nineteenth century as a means of understanding the nature of the distribution of human culture across the world. By that time scholars had begun to study not only advanced cultures, but also cultures of nonliterate people (Beals and Hoijer 1959:664). Studying these very diverse cultures created the major issue of discerning how humans progressed from primeval conditions to superior states (Kuklick 1996:161). Among the major questions about this issue was whether human culture had evolved in a manner similar to biological evolution or whether culture spread from innovation centers by diffusion (Hugill 1996:343).

Two schools of thought emerged in response to these questions. The most extreme view was that there were a very limited number of locations, possibly only one, from which the most important culture traits diffused to the rest of the world. Evolutionism, on the other hand, proposed the "psychic unity of mankind", which argues that all human beings share psychological traits that make them equally likely to innovate (see social evolutionism for more on the psychic unity of mankind). According to evolutionists, innovation in a culture, was considered to be continuous or at least triggered by variables that are relatively exogenous. This set the foundation for the idea that many inventions occurred independently of each other and that diffusion had little effect on cultural development (Hugill 1996:343).

During the 1920's the school of cultural geography at the University of California, Berkeley purposely separated innovation from diffusion and argued that innovation was relatively rare and that the process of diffusion was quite common. It generally avoided the trap of Eurocentric notion of the few hearths or one hearth origination of culture traits. The school of cultural geography combined idealism, environmentalism, and social structural explanations, which made the process of diffusion more feasible than the process of innovation (Hugill 1996:344).

Boas (1938) argued that although the independent invention of a culture trait can occur at the same time within widely separated societies where there is limited control of individual members, allowing them freedom to create a unique style, a link such as genetic relationship is still suspected. He felt this was especially true in societies where there were similar combinations of traits (Boas 1938:211). Boas emphasized that culture traits should not be viewed casually, but in terms of a relatively unique historical process that proceeds from the first introduction of a trait until its origin becomes obscure. He sought to understand culture traits in terms of two historical processes, diffusion and modification. Boas used these key concepts to explain culture and interpret the meaning of culture. He believed that the cultural inventory of a people was basically the cumulative result of diffusion. He viewed culture as consisting of countless loose threads, most of foreign origin, but which were woven together to fit into their new cultural context. Discrete elements become interrelated as time passes (Hatch 1973:57-58).

The American, Lewis Henry Morgan, infuriated his British contemporaries, when his research demonstrated that social change involved both independent invention and diffusion. He agreed with British sociocultural anthropologists that human progress was due to independent innovation, but his work on kinship terminology showed that diffusion occurred among geographically dispersed people (Kuklick 1996:161).

During the mid-twentieth century studies of acculturation and cultural patterning replaced diffusion as the focus of anthropological research. Ethnological research conducted among Native American tribes, even though influenced by the diffusionist school of thought, approached the study of culture traits with a more holistic interpretation. Presently, the concept of diffusion has value in ethnological studies, but at best plays a secondary role in interpreting the processes of culture change (Winthrop 1991:84).

Recently there have been theoretical developments in anthropology among those seeking to explain contemporary processes of cultural globalization and transnational culture flows. This "anthropology of place" approach is not an attempt to polarize autonomous local cultures against the homogenizing movement of cultural globalization. Instead, the emphasis of this line of research is to understand and explain how dominant cultural forms are "imposed, invented, reworked, and transformed." In order to do this, an ethnographic approach must be taken to study the inter-relations of culture, power, and place: place making, identity, and resistance. Anthropologists have long studied spatial units larger than "the local" (Gupta and Ferguson 1997:5-7).

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Diffusion is well documented in the business and industrial world. The creation of copyright and patent laws to protect individual innovations, point to the fact that borrowing ideas is a decidedly human practice. It is often easier to copy an invention, than to create a new invention. Japanese business historians have been very interested in the role diffusion has played in the industrial development of Japan. Business historians give credit to the role diffusion has played in the development of industrial societies in the U.S. and continental Europe. It is hard to justify the view that diffusion in preindustrial societies was any less prevalent than it is in the industrialized societies of today (Hugill 1996:344).

Acculturation: Kroeber (1948) stated that acculturation comprises those changes in a culture brought about by another culture and will result in an increased similarity between the two cultures. This type of change may be reciprocal, however, very often the process is asymmetrical and the result is the (usually partial) absorption of one culture into the other. Kroeber believed that acculturation is gradual rather than abrupt. He connected the process of diffusion with the process of acculturation by considering that diffusion contributes to acculturation and that acculturation necessarily involves diffusion. He did attempt to separate the two processes by stating that diffusion is a matter of what happens to the elements of a culture; whereas acculturation is a process of what happens to a whole culture (Kroeber 1948:425).

Acculturation, then, is the process of systematic cultural change of a particular society carried out by an alien, dominant society (Winthrop 1991:82-83). This change is brought about under conditions of direct contact between individuals of each society (Winthrop 1991:3). Individuals of a foreign or minority culture learn the language, habits, and values of a standard or dominant culture by the cultural process of acculturation. The process by which these individuals enter the social positions, as well as acquire the political, economic, and educational standards of the dominant culture is called assimilation. These individuals, through the social process of assimilation, become integrated within the standard culture (Thompson 1996:112).

Milton Gordon (1964) proposed that assimilation can be described as a series of stages through which an individual must pass. These three stages are *behavioral assimilation* (acculturation), *structural assimilation* (social assimilation), and *marital assimilation* of the individuals of the minority society and individuals of the dominant society. Although this proposal has been criticized, it does indicate that there is a continuum through which individuals pass, beginning with acculturation and ending with complete assimilation (Gordon 1964: 71).

Complete assimilation is not the inevitable consequence of acculturation due to the value systems of the minority or weaker culture being a part of the entire configuration of culture. It may not always be possible for the minority culture to take over the complete way of life of the majority culture. Often a period of transition follows where the minority society increasingly loses faith in its own traditional values, but is unable to adopt the values of the dominant culture. During this transition period there is a feeling of dysphoria, in which individuals in the minority society exhibit feelings of insecurity and unhappiness (Titiev 1958:200).

Acculturation and assimilation have most often been studied in European immigrants coming to the United States during the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, as well as minority groups already living in the United States. European "white ethnics" have experienced a higher rate of assimilation than nonwhite, non-European, and more recently immigrated groups. These studies have resulted in several important cross-cultural generalizations about the process of acculturation and assimilation (Thompson 1996:113).

According to Thompson (1996), these generalizations are as follows: *First*, dominant cultures coerce minorities and foreigners to acculturate and assimilate. This process is slowed down considerably when minorities are territorially or occupationally concentrated, such as in the case of large native minorities who often become ethnonationalistic. *Second*, acculturation must precede assimilation. *Third*, even though a minority may be acculturated, assimilation is not always the end result. *Fourth*, acculturation and assimilation serve to homogenize the minority group into the dominant group. The many factors facilitating or preventing this homogenization include the age of the individual, ethnic background, religious and political affiliations, and economic level (Thompson 1996:114).

Points of Reaction:

Diffusionism: The Biblical theory of human social origin was taken for granted in Renaissance thought (14th century-17th century). The role diffusion played in cultural diversity was acknowledged, but could only be interpreted as the result of cultural decline from an "original Adamic condition" (Hodgen 1964:258). The Renaissance conception of a "Great chain of Being", the hierarchical ordering of human societies, reinforced this Biblical interpretation (Hodgen 1964: ch. 10).

During the later part of the fifteenth century, European voyages of discovery resulted in contact with diverse cultures startlingly unlike those of Europe. The resulting cross-cultural encounters provided the impetus for the development of concepts concerning the processes involved in cultural progress (Davis and Mintz 1998:35).

Actual diffusion research would not take place until the nineteenth century when some scholars attempted to understand the nature of culture and whether it spread to the rest of the world from few or many innovation centers. The concept of diffusion strengthened in its opposition to the more powerful concept of evolution, which proposed that all human beings were possessed equal potential for inovation. Evolutionism eventually became linked to the idea of independent invention and the related notion that contact between preindustrial cultures was minimal (Hugill 1996:343).

Acculturation: The most profound changes in a society result from direct, aggressive contact of one society with another. There is hardly any modern society which has not felt the impact of this contact with very different societies. The process of the intermingling of cultures is called acculturation. Because the influence of Euro-American culture on nonliterate, relatively isolated groups has been so widespread and profound, the term acculturation is most commonly applied to contact and intermingling between these two cultures (Titiev 1959:196-200).

Acculturation studies evolved into assimilation studies during the late nineteenth century and early twentieth centuries when great numbers of immigrants arrived in the United States. Studies of the rate of assimilation of minority groups already living in the United States became another area of focus. Explanations, as to why groups assimilate at different rates, have largely been the underlying reasons for acculturation and assimilation studies (Thompson 1996:113).

Leading Figures:

Franz Boas (1858-1942) was born in Germany where he studied physics and geography. After an expedition to Baffin Island (1883), where he conducted ethnographic work among the Eskimo, Boas's lifework changed. In 1886 he worked among American Indian tribes in British Columbia before his permanent move to America in 1888. This eventually lead to a professorship at Columbia University in 1899 which he held until his retirement in 1936 (Lowie 1937:128-129). Boas was a pioneering anthropological field worker and based many of his concepts on experiences gained while working in the field. He insisted that the fieldworker collect detailed cultural data, learn as much of the native language as possible, and become a part of the native society in order to interpret native life "from within." Boas hoped to document accurately aboriginal life and to alleviate the bias of "romantic outsiders." He used the technique of recording the reminiscences of informants as a valuable supplement to ethnography (Lowie 1937:132-135). He believed the cultural inventory of a people was cumulative and was the result of diffusion. Boas envisioned culture traits as being part of two historical processes, diffusion and modification (Hatch 1973:57-58).

Boas represented the American Museum of Natural History in the Jesup North Pacific Expedition, organized early in the year 1897. The underlying reason for the expedition was the search for laws that govern the growth of human culture. Interest in the Northwest Coast of the United States was based on the knowledge that the Old World and the New World came into close contact in this area. Migration along the coastline, because of favorable geographical conditions, could have facilitated a cultural exchange by diffusion between the Old and New Worlds (Stocking 1974:110-116).

Leo Frobenius (1873-1938) was a German, who was the originator of the concepts of the *Kulturkreise* (culture circles) and of the *Paideuma* (or "soul" of culture). Although he had no formal education, he was involved in extensive research in Africa, which was made possible by donors and by his own income from books and lectures (Barnard2002:862).

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criterion for identifying affinities and chronologies, called the Criterion of Form (Harris 1968:383-384).

A. C. Haddon (1855-1940) was a Cambridge zoologist and anthropologist who led the Cambridge Expedition to the Torres Straits (1898-1899). Assisted by W. H. R. Rivers, this expedition was undertaken just after the Jesup North Pacific Expedition led by Franz Boas (Lowie 1937:88-89). Haddon's book, *A History of Anthropology*, is still considered to be one of the finest histories of anthropology ever written (Barnard 1996:577).

Thor Heyerdahl (1914-) is a Norwegian adventurer best known for his attempts to sail across the oceans in replicas of water craft used by ancient peoples. His goal was to prove that such people could have migrated across the oceans and that the ancient diffusion of culture traits could have spread from one group to another, even across formidable barriers of water (Barnard 1996:578). Heyerdahl also studied the huge statues and numerous caves of Easter Island. Although he made some effort to become acquainted with the contemporary people in order to unlock many of the mysteries of the island (Heyerdahl 1958:Introduction), most anthropologists seriously question the scientific validity of his speculations.

A. L. Kroeber (1876-1960) was an early American student of Franz Boas. He helped establish the anthropology department at Berkeley as a prominent educational and research facility from where he conducted valuable research among the California Indians (Barnard 1996:581). Kroeber (1931) observed that the culture-area concept was "a community product of nearly the whole school of American Anthropologists (Rice, 1931)." Using the culture areas proposed by Otis T. Mason in the 1895 Annual Report of the Smithsonian, Kroeber published his well-known book, *Cultural and Natural Areas of Native North America*, in 1939 (Harris 1968:374).

Freidrich Ratzel (1844-1904) was a German anthropologist who was a significant contributor to nineteenth-century theories of diffusion and migration. He developed criteria by which the formal, non-functional characteristics of objects could be compared, because it would be unlikely that these characteristics would have been simultaneously invented (Barnard 1996:588). Ratzel warned that possible migration or other contact phenomena should be ruled out in each case before cross-cultural similarities were attributed to independent invention. He wrote *The History of Mankind, a three volume publication* in 1896, which was said to be "a solid foundation in anthropological study" by E. B. Tylor, a competing British cultural evolutionist (Harris 1968:383).

W. H. R. Rivers (1864-1922) was a British doctor and psychiatrist who became interested in ethnology after he went on a Cambridge expedition to the Torres Straits in 1898. He later pursued research in India and Melanesia. His interest in kinship established him as a pioneer in the genealogical method and his background in psychiatry enabled him to do research in the area of sensory perception (Barnard 1996:588). Rivers was converted to diffusionism while writing his book, *The History of Melanesian Society*, and was the founder of the diffusionist trend in Britain. In 1911, He was the first to speak out again evolutionism (Harris 1968:380).

Father Pater Wilhelm Schmidt (1868-1954) was a Catholic priest in Germany and an ethnologist who studied religions of the world and wrote extensively on their inter-relationship (Barnard 1996:589). At about the same time that Fritz Graebner (1906) was applying the culture-circle and culture-strata ideas on a worldwide scale, Father Schmidt helped to promote these ideas, began the journal *Anthropos,* and created his own version of the *Kulturkriese* (Harris 1968: 383).Although both Graebner and Schmidt believed that all culture traits diffused out of a limited number of original culture circles, Father Schmidt's list of *Kreise* (culture circles) was the most influential. He proposed four major temporal phases: Primitive, Primary, Secondary, and Tertiary. Within this framework was a grouping of cultures from various parts of the world in an evolutionary scheme, which was basically the very familiar sequences of "stages" progressing from hunter-gatherer, to horticulturalists, to pastoralists, and ending with complex stratified civilization (Harris 1968:385).

G. Elliot Smith (1871-1937) was a prominent British anatomist who produced a most curious view of cultural distribution that Egypt was the source of all higher culture. He based this on the following assumptions: (1) man was uninventive, culture seldom arose independently, and culture only arose in certain circumstances; (2) these circumstances only existed in ancient Egypt, which was the location from which all culture, except for its simplest elements, had spread after the advent of navigation; (3) human history was full of decadence and the spread of this civilization was naturally diluted as it radiated outwardly (Lowie 1937:160-161).

Smith and W. J. Perry, a student of W. H. R. Rivers, hypothesized that the entire cultural inventory of the world had diffused from Egypt. The development began in Egypt, according to them, about 6,000 years ago (Harris 1968:380; Smith 1928:22). This form of diffusion is known as heliocentrism (Spencer 1996:608). They believed that "Natural Man" inhabited the world before development began and that he had no clothing, houses, agriculture, domesticated animals, religion, social organization, formal laws, ceremonies, or hereditary chiefs. The discovery of barley in 4,000 B. C. enabled people to settle in one location. From that point invention in culture exploded and was spread during Egyptian migrations by land and sea. This account was similar to the Biblical version of world history (Harris 1968:389-381).

E.B. Tylor (1832-1917) was a cultural evolutionist who believed that diffusion was involved in the process of humankind's cultural evolution from savagery to civilization. He promoted the idea that culture probably "originated independently more than once, owing to the psychic similarity of man the world over (see psychic unity of mankind), but that actual historical development involved numerous instances of cultural diffusion, or inheritance from a common tradition" (Bidney 1958: 199). He traced "diffused traits side by side with a deep conviction that there had been a general uniformity in evolutionary stages" (Harris 1968: 174).

Clark Wissler (1870-1947) was an American anthropologist at the American Museum of Natural History in New York. Even though he was not in a university where he could train students, his writings still influenced and inspired many of his contemporaries. His ideas on the culture-area approach were especially significant (Barnard 1996:593). In 1917 Wissler created a "landmark treatment" of American Indian ethnology based on Otis T. Mason's 1895 article in the *Annual Report of the Smithsonian Institution*, which identified eighteen American Indian culture areas (Harris 1968:374). (See "A Criticism of Wissler's North American Culture Areas" by Carter A. Woods for commentary on Wissler's 1917 publication)

He expanded the idea of "culture center" by proposing a "law of diffusion," which stated that "... traits tend to diffuse in all directions from their center of origin." The law constituted that basis of the "age-area principle" which could determine the relative age of a culture trait by measuring the extent of its geographical distribution (Harris 1968:376).

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Principal Concepts:

Diffusionism: This school of thought proposed that civilization spread from one culture to another, because humans are basically conservative and lack inventiveness (Winthrop 1991:83). An extreme example of this theory was the idea proposed by English scholar Grafton Elliot Smith. He considered Egypt as the primary source for many other ancient civilizations (Smith 1931:393-394). This form of diffusionism is known as heliocentric diffusionism (Spencer 1996:608). A wider concept, explaining the diffusion of culture traits, was formulated by Leo Frobenius, through the inspiration of his teacher, Freidrich Ratzel. This version is called "culture circles" or *Kulturkreise* (Harris 1968:382-83). An even more expanded version of diffusiionism was proposed in the United States, where diffusionist ideas culminated in the concept of "culture areas." A. L. Kroeber and Clark Wissler with the main proponents of this version (Harris 1968:373-74).

Culture Circles German and Austrian diffusionists argued that there were a number of culture centers, rather than just one, in the ancient world. Culture traits diffused, not as isolated elements, but as a whole culture complex, due to migration of individuals from one culture to another (Winthrop 1991:83).

The *Kulturkreise* (culture circle) school of thought, even though inspired by Friedrich Ratzel, was actually created by his student, Leo Frobenius. This stimulated Fritz Graebner, at the Berlin Ethnological Museum, to write about this concept in his studies about Ocenia, then on a world-wide scale. Father Wilhelm Schmidt became a follower of these ideas, created his version of the *Kulturkriese*, and began the journal, *Anthropos* (Harris 1968:382-83).

Culture Areas: In 1895 Otis T. Mason wrote an article entitled "Influence of Environment upon Human Industries or Arts," which was published in *the Annual Report of the Smithsonian Institution*. This article identified eighteen American Indian "culture areas." It was a simple concept, in that tribal entities were grouped on an ethnographic map and related to a geographical aspect of the environment. In 1914, the "culture area" concept was refined by G. Holmes. This comprised the basis for a "landmark treatment of American Indian ethnology" by Clark Wissler. Even some years later in 1939, this same "culture area" concept was used by A. L. Kroeber's in his publication of *Cultural and Natural Areas* (Harris 1968:374).

Acculturation: Kroeber (1948) described acculturation as changes produced in a culture because of the influence of another culture, with the two cultures becoming similar as the end result. These changes may be reciprocal, which results in the two cultures becoming similar, or one-way and may result in the extinction of one culture, when it is absorbed by the other (Kroeber 1948:425). Acculturation contrasts with diffusion of culture traits in that it is a process of systematic cultural transformation of individuals in a society due to the presence on an alien, politically dominant society (Winthrop 1991:83). The *Encyclopedia of Social and Cultural Anthropology* (1996) defines acculturation as the process of acquiring culture traits as a result of contact and that it was a common term, especially used by American anthropologists, until recently.

Assimilation: Milton Gordon (1964) formulated a series of stages through which an individual must pass in order to be completely assimilated (Thompson 1996:113). Although he listed acculturation as the first stage in the series, not all individuals go past this stage. It is not always possible to adopt the dominant culture's way of life completely, in order to assimilate (Titiev 1958:200).

An individual is assimilated when he is capable of entering social positions and political, economic, and educational areas of the standard society. If he cannot, he may simply remain acculturated because he has learned the language, habits, and values of the standard or dominant culture (Thompson 1996:112).

Methodologies:

American School of Thought: The concept of diffusionism was based in American ethnographic research on the North and South American Indians. This research was involved in mapping and classifying the various American Indian tribes. The building of ethnographic collections at the American Museum of Natural History and the Chicago Field Museum occurred at the same time that American anthropologists were reacting to some of the schemes formulated by the evolutionists. This stimulated research concerned with determining how culture traits were arranged geographically in a "delineated aspect of the environment". Although "culture area" was a term originally used in 1895 by Otis T. Mason, the most prominent anthropologists who used the term in research were Clark Wissler and A. L. Kroeber. They used theconcept of culture areas to study American Indian ethnology (Harris 1968:374).

German School of Thought: German anthropologists were considered to be extreme diffusionsists. This school of thought was dominated by the Catholic clergy, who attempted to reconcile anthropological prehistory and cultural evolution with the Book of Genesis. One of the best known leaders in this attempt was Father

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concept provided the criteria by which Graebner could study Oceania at first and, two years later, cultures on a world-wide basis (Harris 1968:383). The "culture circle" concept proposed that a cluster of functionally-related culture traits specific to a historical time and geographical area (Spencer 1996:611) diffused out of a region in which they evolved. Graebner and Schmidt claimed that they had reconstructed a "limited number of original culture circles" (Harris 1968:384).

British School of Thought: Diffusionism occurred in its most extreme form in the ideas of the British school of thought. W. H. R. Rivers was the founder of these ideas. He confined his studies to Oceania, where he tried to organize the ethnography according to nomothetic principles and sought to explain the contrasts between Melanesian and Polynesian cultures by the spread of original complexes, which supposedly had been spread by successive waves of migrating people (Harris 1968:380). Rivers states that "a few immigrants possessed of a superior technology can impose their customs on a large autochthonous population" (Lowie 1937:174). He also applied this extreme concept of diffusionism to Australian burial practices. The obvious problem with Rivers' explanation appears when questioned as to why the technology of the "newcomers" disappeared if it was superior. Rivers solves the problem with a rather fantastical flare. He claims that because the "newcomers" were small in number, they failed to assert their "racial strain" into the population (Lowie 1937: 175).

The leading proponent of this extreme diffusionist school was Sir G. Elliot Smith. He claimed that Egypt was the source of culture and that every other culture in the world diffused from there, but that a dilution of this civilization occurred as it spread to increasingly greater distances. His theoretical scheme claimed that man is uninventive, so culture only arises under favorable circumstances. These favorable circumstances only existed in ancient Egypt (Lowie 1937: 161).

Accomplishments:

Lewis Henry Morgan claimed that diffusionism was one of the "mechanisms by which the substantial uniformity of sociocultural evolution was made possible" (Harris 1968: 177).

In the United States diffusionism resulted in the creation of the concept of culture areas, which were contiguous cultural element in relatively small, geographical units (Harris 1968:373). It also resulted in another methodological tool - the age area. Clark Wissler, a contemporary of Boas, formulated both of these concepts. The culture area is a tool to be used for classifying clusters of culture traits and has benefited museums as a way of arranging cultural data. Later the culture area concept was used as a tool for historical studies (Beals and Hiojer 1959:670-671).

Even though diffusion, as a school of thought, was replaced with a more holistic approach during the mid-twentieth century, the concept of diffusion still has value in ethnological studies (Winthrop 1991:84).Studies involving the diffusion of ideas and how they affect and motivate innovations have been of great value in many other fields, such as agriculture business studies, education, economic geography, history, political science, and rural sociology (Hugill 1996:343).

Acculturation Studies on European immigrants coming to the United States during the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries have helped to give insight into problems encountered when people from diverse cultures come into a dominant culture. At the same time, studies about minorities already living in the United States show how some groups are resistant to assimilation, and, in some cases, acculturation (Thompson 1996:113-14). Studies such as these could identify where the problems are for the acculturation and assimilation of a minority individual or group and how to establish better relationships between various groups and the dominant society. An understanding of the cultural processes can be gained from such studies (Titiev 1959:196-200).

Criticisms:

The diffusionist approach was slowly being replaced by studies concerning acculturation, patterns of culture, and the relation between culture and personality. Boas wrote the article, "Methods of ethnology," in which he discussed how the "impact of one society upon another could not be understood merely as the addition or subtraction of discrete culture traits, but as a potentially major transformation of behavior, values, and mode of adaptation" (Winthrop 1991:4).

By World War I, diffusionism was also being challenged by the newly emerging Functionalist school of thought lead by Bronislaw Malinowski and A. R. Radcliffe-Brown. They argued that even if one could produce evidence of imported aspects of culture in a society, the original culture trait might be so changed that it served a completely different function that the society from which it diffused (Kuklick 1996:161).

In the 1920s, Boas and other American anthropologists, such as Robert Lowie and Ralph Linton, argued that cultural change had been influenced by many different sources. They argued against "the grand reconstruction of both evolutionists . . . and diffusionists" (Winthrop 1991: 84).

James M. Blaut (1993) believed that extreme diffusionism was racist. However, he did believe that as a process, diffusionism was important. He criticized extreme diffusionism because he believed that it contributed to the prevalent belief that "European-style societies" were more innovative than non-European societies and that the proper form of development would progress according to whether or not these culture traits had diffused from European societies (Hugill 1996: 344).

Comments:

Diffusion, as an anthropological school of thought, was a viable part of the development of anthropological concepts about how societies change due to the spread of culture traits and independent inventions. However, it was suffused with ethnocentric ideas and, as a school of thought, was only a small part of what should be the total analysis of world cultures. A more holistic approach, stemming from the play of diffusionism against evolutionism, has provided a more adequate understanding of the overall picture.

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Franz Boas, the Columbia Encyclopedia entry: http://education.yahoo.com/reference/encyclopedia/entry/Boas-Fra

Franz Boas, a brief bio http://www.germanheritage.com/biographies/atol/boas.html

Franz Boas and Visual Anthropology http://astro.temple.edu/~ruby/ruby/boas.html

Franz Boas and the Rise of Modern Culture http://dwax.org/2007/05/25/franz_boas_and_the_rise_of_modern_culture/

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ANTHROPOLOGICAL THEORIES

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American Materialism

Elliot Knight and Karen Smith

(Note: authorship is arranged stratigraphically with the most recent author listed first)

Basic Premises:

Materialism, as an approach to understanding cultural systems, is defined by three key principles, cultural materialism, cultural evolution, and cultural ecology, and can be traced back at least to the early economists, Karl Marx and Frederick Engels (see Principal Concepts).

These basic premises, defined below, have in common attempts at explaining cultural similarities and differences and modes for culture change in a strictly scientific manner. In addition, these three concepts all share a materialistic view of culture change. That is to say, each approach holds that there are three levels within culture --- technological, sociological, and ideological --- and that the technological aspect of culture disproportionately molds and influences the other two aspects of culture.

Materialism is the "idea that technological and economic factors play the primary role in molding a society" (Carneiro 1981:218). There are many varieties of materialism including dialectical (Marx), historical (White), and cultural (Harris). Though materialism can be traced as far back as Hegel, an early philosopher, Marx was the first to apply materialistic ideas to human societies in a quasi-anthropological manner. Marx developed the concept of dialectical materialism borrowing his dialectics from Hegel and his materialism from others. To Marx, "the mode of production in material life determines the general character of the social, political, and spiritual processes of life. It is not the consciousness of men that determines their existence, but on the contrary, their social existence determines their consciousness" (Harris 1979:55). The dialectic element of

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and cultural diversity are to be found in this primary level (i.e., the infrastructure).

Marvin Harris, utilizing and modifying Marx's dialectical materialism, developed the concept of cultural materialism. Like Marx and White, Harris also views culture in three levels, the infrastructure, the structure, and the superstructure. The infrastructure is composed of the mode of production, or "the technology and the practices employed for expanding or limiting basic subsistence production," and the mode of reproduction, or "the technology and the practices employed for expanding, limiting, and maintaining population size" (Harris 1979:52). Unlike Marx, Harris believes that the mode of reproduction, that is demography, mating patterns, etc., should also be within the level of the infrastructure because "each society must behaviorally cope with the problem of reproduction (by) avoiding destructive increases or decreases in population size" (Harris 1979:51). The structure consists of both the domestic and political economy, and the superstructure consists of the recreational and aesthetic products and services. Given all of these cultural characteristics, Harris states that "the etic behavioral modes of production and reproduction probabilistically determine the etic behavioral domestic and political economy, which in turn probabilistically determine the behavioral and mental emic superstructures" (Harris 1979:55,56). The above concept is cultural materialism or, in Harris' terms, the principle of infrastructural determinism.

Cultural evolution, in a Marxian sense, is the idea that "cultural changes occur through the accumulation of small, quantitative increments that lead, once a certain point is reached, to a qualitative transformation" (Carneiro 1981:216). Leslie White is usually given credit for developing and refining the concept of general cultural evolution and was heavily influenced by Marxian economic theory as well as Darwinian evolutionary theory. To White, "culture evolves as the amount of energy harnessed per captia per year is increased, or as the efficiency of the instrumental means of putting the energy to work is increased" (Bohannan and Glazer 1988:340). Energy capture is accomplished through the technological aspect of culture so that a modification in technology could, in turn, lead to a greater amount of energy capture or a more efficient method of energy capture thus changing culture. In other words, "we find that progress and development are effected by the improvement of the mechanical means with which energy is harnessed and put to work as well as by increasing the amounts of energy employed" (Bohannan and Glazer 1988:344). Another premise that White adopts is that the technological system plays a primary role or is the primary determining factor within the cultural system. White's materialist approach is evident in the following quote: "man as an animal species, and consequently culture as a whole, is dependent upon the material, mechnaical means of adjustment to the natural environment" (Bohannan and Glazer 1988).

Julian Steward developed the principal of cultural ecology which holds that the environment is an additional, contributing factor in the shaping of cultures. Steward termed his approach multilinear evolution, and defined it as "a methodology concerned with regularity in social change, the goal of which is to develop cultural laws empirically" (Bohannan and Glazer 1988:321). In essence, Steward proposed that, methodologically, one must look for "parallel developments in limited aspects of the cultures of specifically identified societies" (Hoebel1958:90). Once parallels in development are identified, one must then look for similiar causal explanations. Steward also developed the idea of culture types that have "cross-cultural validity and show the following characteristics: (1) they are made up of selected cultural elements rather than cultures as wholes; (2) these cultural elements must be selected in relationship to a problem and to a frame of reference; and (3) the cultural elements that are selected must have the same functional relationships in every culture fitting the type" (Bohannan and Glazer 1988:321).

Points of Reaction:

Materialism, in anthropology, is methodologically and theoretically opposed to Idealism. Included in the latter are culture and personality or psychological anthropology, structuralism, ethnoscience, and symbolic anthropology. The many advocates of this idealistic approach "share an interest in psychological phenomena, and they tend to view culture in mental and symbolic terms" (Langness 1974:84). "Materialists, on the other hand, tend to define culture strictly in terms of overt, observable behavior patterns, and they share the belief that technoenvironmental factors are primary and causal" (Langness 1974:84). The contemporaneous

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Leading Figures:

- Karl Marx (1818-1883)
- Frederick Engels (1820-1895)
- Leslie White (1900-1975)
- Julian Steward (1902-1972)
- Marvin Harris (1927-2001)

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Principal Concepts:

Mode of Production: "a specific, historically constituted combination of resources, technology, and social and economic relationships, creating use or exchange value" (Winthrop 1991:189). This concept was initially defined and refined by Marx and Engels. For these economists, a "mode of production must not be considered simply as being the production of the physical existence of the individuals. Rather, it is a definite form of activity of these individuals, a definite form of expressing thier life, a definite mode of life on their part" (Winthrop 1991:190). With respect to specific, historical, precapitalist socities, the mode of production manifests as a combination or interplay between individuals, their material enviroment, and their mode of labor.

A similar definition proposed by Maurice Godelier, an anthropologist, states that the mode of production is "a combination -- which is capable of reproducing itself -- of production forces and specific social relations of production which determine the structure and form of the process of production and the circulation of material goods within a historically determined society" (Winthrop 1991:190). In addition, a particular society is not restricted to one particular mode of production; that is to say, "any given society at a particular historical juncture may involve multiple modes of production in a specified articulation" (Winthrop 1991:190).

Winthrop notes that this particular concept (i.e., as defined above), though discussed often, is not consistently applied. Particularly with respect to cultural evolution and cultural materialism, the application of the concept

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Law of Cultural Development: "culture advances as the amount of energy harnessed per captia per year increases, or as the efficiency or economy of the means of controlling enery is increased, or both" (White 1959:56).

Culturology: the field of science which studies and interprets the distinct order of phenomena termed culture (White 1959:28). This term was developed by Leslie White because he believed that cultures should be explained, not in terms of pyschology, biology, physiology, etc., but in terms of culturology (i.e., the study of culture). During this time in anthropology, the notion of society was being developed and becoming a key focus of study. White believed that the primary focus of study in anthropology should be culture and not society. In addition, explanations for cultural development and change should come from anthropology and methodological approach should be scientific.

General Cultural Evolution: "the successive emergence of new levels of all-round development" (Sahlins and Service 1988:28). To White and others, general evolution is based on the amount of energy capture and deals with "C"ulture, per se. Again, quoting White, "culture advances as the proportion of nonhuman energy to human energy increases" (1959:47). In addition, this concept is characterized by the progression from lower to higher orders of organization. In other words, changes in the complexity and organization of cultural forms is a result of changes in the amount of engergy capture. When general evolution is discussed, culture is viewed as a closed system. "That is, culture is taken out of particular and historic contexts" (Sahlins and Service 1959:46).

Specific Cultural Evolution: the historical sequence of particular cultures and their lines of development. Unlike general cultural evolution, specific evolution is based on the efficiency of energy capture with respect to specific cultures. That is to say, a particular culture in a given envirnoment maybe less complex, both technologically and socially, in the general evolutionary scheme; however, this particular culture may, at the same time, be the best adapted (i.e., most efficient at harnessing energy) to their environment. This concept is analogous to biological evoultion, in that, specific evolution can be viewed as historical, phylogentic lines of descent (Sahlins and Service 1959:16). General evolution, on the other hand, can be viewed as ordered complexity of living organisims.

Law of Cultural Growth: "culture develops as the efficiency or economy of the means of controlling energy increases, other factors remaining constant" (White 1959:55).

Culture Core: "the constellation of features which are most closely related to subsistence activities and economic arrangements" (Winthrop 1991:47). This concept was developed by Juliand Steward in his 1955 publication "Theory of Culture Change."

Cultural materialism considers that all socio-cultural systems consist of three levels: infrastructure, structure and superstructure:

Infrastructure
1. Production
2. Reproduction

Structure
1. Domestic economy
2. Political economy

Superstructure
1. Behavior
2. Mental

INFRASTRUCTURE

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population size.

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STRUCTURE

1. Domestic Economy: Consists of a small number of people who interact on an intimate basis. They perform many functions, such as regulating reproduction, basic production, socialization, education, and enforcing domestic discipline.

2. Political economy: These groups may be large or small, but their members tend to interact without any emotional commitment to one another. They perform many functions, such as regulating production, reproduction, socialization, and education, and enforcing social discipline.

SUPERSTRUCTURE

1. Behavior Superstructure

Art, music, dance, literature, advertising

Rituals

Sports, games, hobbies

Science

2. Mental superstructure

Values

Emotions

Traditions

(Harris 1979:52-53)

Methodologies:

The method of Cultural Ecology "has three aspects: (1)the analysis of the methods of production in the environment must be analyzed, and (2)the pattern of human behavior that is part of these methods must be analyzed in order to (3) understand the relationship of production techniques to the other elements of the culture" (Bohannan and Glazer 1988:322).

Accomplishments:

Criticisms:

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Relevant Web Links:

- The basics of Marxism *(http://www-formal.stanford.edu/jmc/progress/marxism.html)*.
- Historical Materialism overview (http://www.cscs.umich.edu/~crshalizi/notabene/historical-materialism.html).
- Anthropological materialism Research Syndicate (not primarily American) (http://anthropologicalmaterialism.hypotheses.org/).
- Frederick Engels overview (http://www.spartacus.schoolnet.co.uk/TUengels.htm).
- The basics Cultural Materialism (http://www.allaboutphilosophy.org/cultural-materialism.htm).
- Cultural Materialism Overview (http://www.indiana.edu/~wanthro/theory_pages/Materialism.htm).
- The Center for the study of Cultural Materialism on the Internet (http://www.cultural-materialism.org/).
- Cultural Evolution Overview (http://plato.stanford.edu/entries/evolution-cultural/).
- Cultural Ecology Theory overview (http://www.jrank.org/history/pages/6014/Cultural-Ecology-Theory.html).

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Cross-Cultural Analysis

Heath Kinzer and Judith L. Gillies

(Note: authorship is arranged stratigraphically with the most recent author listed first)

Basic Premises:

The basic premise of Cross-Cultural Analysis is that statistical cross-cultural comparisons can be used to discover traits shared between cultures and generate ideas about cultural universals. Cross-cultural analysts create hypotheses and consult data into order to draw statistical correlations about the relationships among certain cultural traits. The approach was developed by early cultural evolutionists (namely E. B. Tylor and Lewis Henry Morgan) and was later greatly advanced by George Peter Murdock, who compiled the work of many ethnographic studies into one database that came to be known as the Human Relation Area Files (HRAF). Today, the journal of *Cross-Cultural Research* is the premiere locale for published works using cross-cultural analysis.

Early approaches to cross-cultural analysis focused on the concept of cultural evolution , the notion that all societies progress through an identical series of distinct evolutionary stages. Among the cultural evolutionists, Edward Burnett Tylor proposed three basic stages of culture among humans: (1) savagery, (2) barbarism, and (3) civilization. Although this seems crude and ethnocentric, it offered an advance over the biological/theological belief that more primitive societies were at lower stages of development because they had fallen from grace(According to Comte Joseph de Maistre hunter-gatherers degenerated to their state, making them technologically as well as intellectually inferior to other cultures . On the other end, European society, especially Victorian England, was seen as the prime example of civilization.

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technologies. The stages of cultural development posed by Morgan in *Ancient Society* are shown below (Morgan 1877:12).

- lower savagery: began with earliest humanity- fruits and nuts subsistence
- middle savagery: began with discovery of fishing technology and the use of fire
- upper savagery: began with bow and arrow
- lower barbarism: began with pottery making
- middle barbarism: began in Old World with the domestication of plants and animals / in the New World with the development of irrigation cultivation
- upper barbarism: began with smelting iron and the use of iron tools
- civilization: began with the invention of a phonetic alphabet and writing

While Morgan's stages of cultural development postulated cultural universals, his greatest contribution to comparative studies (the basis of cross-cultural analysis) was his work *Systems of Consanguinity* (1877), which documented the kinship systems of Native Americans and other national groups in the United States. In this, Morgan highlighted universals in kinship terminology, and he noted that all societies he studied could fit into one of six basic patterns of kinship terminology (his list of six was later condensed to four). While the theories of Tylor and Morgan are now outdated, they laid the foundation for the use of cross-cultural comparison as a method for generating ideas about human cultural universals.

Cross-cultural survey is a comparative statistical study in which the "tribe", "society", or "culture" is taken as the unit and samples from across the globe are studied to test hypotheses about the nature of society or culture (Naroll 1961, 221). The most famous example of this method is Murdock's *Social Structure* (1949). The methodology of cross-cultural analysis, which involves the use of testable hypotheses to establish (or not) statistical correlations, was greatly facilitated by the work of George Peter Murdock. Murdock compiled data from over 300 cultures and and organized under 700 different cultural subject headings collected from ethnographies by Boas, Malinowski, their students, and many, many others into the *Cross Cultural Survey*, which later became known as the Human Relations Area Files (HRAF). The trait lists of cultural universals, in "The Common Denominator of Cultures" from *The Science of Man in the World Crisis,* (Murdock 1945:123) were based on the HRAF (Ferraro 1992:74).

Points of Reaction:

The comparative method was used by early cultural evolutionists such as Morgan and Tylor in reaction against the degenerationists, who placed hunter-gatherers and other less technologically advanced cultures in a class based on a supposed degeneration from perfection, which had made them less technologically and intellectually capable, inferior to the European societies of the 19th century. The development of the comparative method as used in Cross-Cultural Analysis was a reaction against the deductive reasoning of the Boasian tradition, which treated each culture as the unique product of its own historical and geographical conditions and rejected cultural theories as a whole. Franz Boas, founder of the four-field approach to anthropology, the preeminent figure in early 20th century American anthropology, and mentor to an entire generation of American anthropologists, argued that more data was needed before any sort of universal theories could be posited. Moreover, Boas discarded the prejudices implicated by theories of cultural evolution, which ranked cultures. Boas had reacted against the comparative method as presented by Tylor before the turn of the century, and essentially, the comparative method had lain dormant in anthropology for 40 years.

ADVANTAGES David Levinson argues that holocultural studies (the more modern term for studies done with cross-cultural analysis) have six major advantages in the realm of theory testing concerning human culture and behavior (Levionson, 1980:9):

- samples cover a much wider range of variation in cultural activities than do studies based on single societies.
- this variation allows the assumption that "irrelevant variables" do not affect the results ofsuch studies.

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- holocultural studies are objective because the person who collects the data (ethnographer) and the theory tester (comparativist) are not the same individual, which guards against the researcher's conscious or unconscious biases toward particular theories.
- even the most rigorous holocultural studies are cost effective.

DISADVANTAGES Levinson also points out four major disadvantages of holocultural studies, but he states that these are outweighed by the six advantages listed above. They disadvantages are as follows:

- Studies often ignore the variability within a single culture and the variation across cultures because neglecting these makes for easier, more uniform coding.
- Data is archival and therefore lacks the sensitivity seen in case study work.
- Since some topics are described poorly in the ethnographic literature, not all areas of interest can be studied easily and some perhaps not at all.
- Since the majority of samples are compiled from small-scale societies, large-scale societies are either under-represented or not represented at all (1980:9-10).

Leading Figures:

Sir Edward Burnett Tylor (1832-1917) may be considered the father of the modern statistical cross-cultural approach to the study of culture for his paper *On a Method of Investigating the Development of Institutions, Applied to Laws of Marriage and Descent* (1889). Tylor was born Oct. 2, 1832, into a well-to-do British Quaker family, and died. Jan. 2, 1917. He is considered the founder of social anthropology in Great Britain. He is most known for his research on culture, cultural evolution, and the origin and development of religion. Though Tylor never earned a university degree, he gained acclaim through his research and writing. In 1856, when he was 24, waning health led Tylor to America and later to Mexico. In 1861, he returned to Great Britain and published his first book, *Anahuac: Mexico and the Mexicans, Ancient and Modern* (Tylor's unilineal view of progressive cultural evolution included the concept that earlier stages of development were exhibited by what he termed "survivals," which were the remnants of a paired set of ancient cultural traits that lingered on in more advanced cultures. In 1883, Tylor became keeper of the University Museum at Oxford and he later served as a professor of anthropology at Oxford from 1896 to 1909. His other major works include *Primitive Culture* (1871) and *Anthropology* (1881) (Kowalewski 1995).

William Graham Sumner (1840-1910) was born in Paterson, N.J., Oct. 30, 1840, and died Apr. 12, 1910 before completing his major work- the four volume *Science of Society*, and the index for the volumes of comparative data. Sumner was a sociologist, economist, and Episcopal minister. As a Yale University professor (1872-1909), Sumner taught Albert Galloway Keller who in turn taught George Peter Murdock. Sumner introduced the classic concepts of Folkways and mores in Folkways (1906). He was also the foremost publicist of the theory of Social Darwinism in the United States. Social Darwinists asserted that societies evolved by a natural process, like organisms, and that among humans, as happens in other species, the most well adapted (often seen as the rich) should be allowed to flourish and the least well adapted (often seen as the poor) should be allowed to die out. This concept was roundly supported by political conservatism which argued that the most successful social classes also supposedly consisted of people who were obviously biologically superior (Hofstadter 1941). The importance of this concept is that the basis for cross-cultural analysis was rooted in the concept of cultural evolution, and this was Sumner's view of the process.

George P. Murdock (1897-1985) was born in Meriden, Conn., May 11, 1897, and died Mar. 29, 1985. Murdock, the most influential and important figure in 20th century cross-cultural analysis, was an American anthropologist known for his comparative studies of kinship systems and for his cross-cultural analyses of the regularities and differences among diverse peoples. During the time he was teaching at Yale (1928-1960), he developed the Cross Cultural Survey, in the 1930s-1940s, which is now known as the Human Relations Area Files (HRAF). The HRAF is an index of many of the world's ethnographically known societies. The HRAF is now available at over 250 institutional libraries worldwide. Murdock's publications include *Social Structure* (1949), *Africa: Its People and Their Culture History* (1959), and *Culture and Society* (1965) (Kowalewski 1995). Murdock descended from an anthropological ancestry opposed to the Boasian anthropological school

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original idea of Sumner's central index. Sumner had begun the work of several volumes, most influential to the eventual work of Murdock in compiling the HRAF was the index completed posthumously by Sumner's successor, A.G. Keller.

Alfred Louis Kroeber (1876-1960) was born in Hoboken, N.J., June 11, 1876, and died Oct. 5, 1960. Kroeber's comparative work emphasized similarities and differences between entire cultural groups. However, unlike Murdock, Kroeber did not focus on comparing cultural traits across a broad array of societies, and he actually opposed the style of Murdock. He is often considered the most influential American cultural anthropologist after Franz Boas, who was one of his professors. He held tenure (1901-46) at the University of California at Berkeley. He advanced the study of California Indians and developed important theories about the nature of culture. Kroeber believed that human culture could not be entirely explained by psychology, biology, or related sciences, but that it required a science of its own, and he was a major figure in the emergence of anthropology as an academic discipline. Kroeber published prolifically until the time of his death at the age of 85. His major works include *Anthropology* (1923; rev. ed. 1948); *Handbook of the Indians of California* (1925); *Configurations of Culture Growth* (1944); *Culture; a Critical Review of Concepts and Definitions* (1952), which he co-authored with Clyde Kluckhohn; and *Style and Civilizations* (1957) (Kowalewski 1995).

Harold E. Driver(1907-1992) was a Professor of Anthropology at Indiana University. His field research was concentrated in California and New Mexico. Comparative statistical methodology and culture area classifications were his areas of specialization. There is an excellent article by Driver in Readings in Cross-Cultural Methodology, entitled, "Introduction to Statistics for Comparative Research", which looks at such methods as chi-square and phi for the correlation between culture features. This article is written for the fairly unsophisticated statistician and is useful for comparative studies with other applications than just cross-cultural analysis.

Clellan Ford(1909-1972)- was a professor of Anthropology at Yale and President of the HRAF. He took over the Human Relations program from Murdock. His field research areas were in the Northwest Coast of the United States, and the Fiji Islands. Comparative studies and human sexual behavior were his focus areas.

David Levinson (1947-present), has been a prolific producer of anthropological encyclopedias as well as cross-cultural work. He has edited guide books for the use and understanding of the HRAF as well as books and articles that explain the studies that have been done utilizing the HRAF.

Other leading figures include many students of Murdock's at Yale such as John and Beatrice Whiting, who conducted The Six Cultures Project with Irvin L. Child and William Lambert, and Melvin Ember, who is co-editor with Levinson and a major contributor to the Encyclopedia of Cultural Anthropology (1996).

Key Works:

Berlin, Brent, and Paul Kay (1969). *Basic color terms: their universality and evolution*. Berkeley, University of California Press. This study of basic color terminology found that an increase in the complexity of color terminology accompanied increased socio-economic development. Also, the study showed that basic color terms are adopted in universal sequence. Findings of this sort involve implicational universals, which means that the presence of a particular trait/characteristic indicates the presence of another characteristic.

Ember, C. R., & Ember, M. 2009. *Cross-cultural research methods / Carol R. Ember and Melvin Ember*. Lanham : Altamira Press.

Levinson, David, and Martin J. Malone (1980). Toward Explaining Human Culture: A Critical Review of the Findings of Worldwide Cross-Cultural Research. New Haven, Connecticut: HRAF Press. Kinship, marriage, descent patterns, incest taboos, residence patterns, settlement patterns, religion, and aggression, among other cultural subjects, based on results obtained from holocultural studies. A bibliography and index are included.

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Introduction, New Haven, Connecticut, Human Relations Area Files. This is Guide Number One for the HRAF Theoretical Information Control System. In the Introduction to the Guide, Levinson states that it is a new kind of information retrieval tool, an analytical propositional inventory of theories of human behavior that have been developed or tested by means of worldwide cross-cultural studies (1977:2). There are five volumes of the Guide. This introductory volume contains a description of the Guide and tells one how to use it, including copies of the codebook that were used in the process of compiling the Guide.

Levinson, Stephen. C. (1996). Relativity in spatial conception and description. In J. Gumperz, S. C. Levinson, J. Gumperz, S. C. Levinson (Eds.) *Rethinking linguistic relativity* (pp. 177-202). New York, NY US: Cambridge University Press. Through the work of the Max Planck institute, this project demonstrated that languages code for space by one of three means: (1) egocentric, (2) cardinal direction, or (3) landmarks. This represents a particular perception of the world which is encoded in language through grammar or body language.

Morgan, Louis Henry (1871). Systems of Consanguinity. Washington, D.C.: Smithsonian Institution. Kinship research based on interviews and questionnaires distributed across America to Native Americans and people of European descent.

Morgan, Louis Henry (1963). Ancient Society. New York: World (orig. 1877). In this book Morgan detailed the seven stages of society. The text contains a system for classifying cultures to determine their position on the cultural evolutionary ladder.

Murdock, George Peter (1945). The Common Denominator of Cultures. In The Science of Man in the World Crisis, Ralph Linton, ed. P. 123. New York: Columbia University Press. This is a listing of common traits among cultures, what Murdock called “cultural universals”, which could be used to determine commonalities and variations in holocultural studies

Murdock, George Peter (1949). Social Structure. New York, Macmillan Co. In 1949 Murdock used the HRAF as the foundation for his book *Social Structure* in which he correlated information on family and kinship organizations around the world (Ferraro 1992:28-29).

Murdock, George Peter (1949/1968). Human Relations Area Files Microfilms International. Ann Arbor: University. The Cross Cultural System, which later became the Human Relations Area Files, was compiled by George Peter Murdock and colleagues at Yale in 1930s-1940s. It is a coded data retrieval system, which initially contained the ethnographies of over 300 cultures and 700 different cultural headings collected by the 1940s from ethnographies of Boas, Malinowski, and their students, among others, who were not always professionals (Ferraro 1992:74). The HRAF was originally produced on index cards, the HRAF Paper Files (1949), available on microfiche since 1968, and more recently available in a CD format. The entries to the HRAF increase annually and subscriptions are bought by institutions on a yearly basis. Murdock wrote The Common Denominator of Cultures (1945). The cultural headings in the HRAF are partially based on the Cultural Universals Murdock sets forth in this work.

Murdock, George Peter (1957). World Ethnographic Sample. In American Anthropologist 59:664-687.

Murdock, George Peter (1967). Ethnographic Atlas. Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press. Book. Classification of ethnographies.

Murdock, George Peter (1980). Atlas of World Cultures. Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press. Book. Includes an index.

Narrol, R. 1970. What have we learned from Cross-Cultural Surveys? *American Anthropologist*. 72(6)1227-1288. In this article, Naroll offers an extensive review and critique of more than 150 cross-cultural surveys, commenting on their “contributions to the theory of human behavior” (1227). Moreover, he notes the successes of these methods in realizing connections between things like kinship and residence rules, descent

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Stories and Their Implications. In R. Shweder, R. LeVine (Eds.) , *Culture Theory: Essays on Mind, Self, and Emotion* (pp. 276-320). Cambridge: Cambridge UP. This piece highlights child socialization in white middle-class American, Kululi, and Western Samoan societies. Of particular note, Ochs and Schieffelin found that baby talk is not universal.

Peregrine, Peter, Carol Ember, and Melvin Ember (2004). Universal Patterns in Cultural Evolution: An Empirical Analysis Using Guttman Scaling. *American Anthropologist*, *106*(1), 145-149. A modern day test of universal evolutionist theories, this study examined archaeological evidence in order to make inferences about cross-cultural trends in the development of technology. Overall, their results generally supported the universal evolutionary sequences like those developed by E. B. Tylor and Lewis Henry Morgan, although they did not describe such cultures as savage or barbarous.

Rohner, Ronald P. (1975). They Love Me, They Love Me Not: A Worldwide Study of the Effects of Parental Acceptance and Rejection. New Haven: HRAF Press. Levinson considers this book to be one of the important cross-cultural contributions of this century.

Sumner, William Graham, and Albert Galloway Keller (1927). The Science of Society. New Haven: Yale University Press; London, H. Milford, Oxford University Press. Three volumes of entries of societies catalogued by Sumner. Volume 4 is the index of the entries. The fourth volume index had a great influence upon Murdock.

Tylor, Edward (1889). On a Method of Investigating the Development of Institutions: Applied to Laws of Marriage and Descent. Journal of Royal Anthropological Institute 18:245-269. Tylor was the first to attempt a statistical cross-cultural analysis with this paper, delivered to the Royal Anthropological Institute.

Whiting, Beatrice, and John W. M. Whiting (1974). Children of Six Cultures Cambridge-, Mass.: Harvard University Press. This project was a far-reaching concept of the effect of child-rearing practices on adult behavior, which utilized cross-cultural analysis, but was based in the school of Culture and Personality. This project resulted in a book by the same name, but it really did not add to anthropological knowledge and exposed some problems concerning the use of inappropriate methodology for research that is not specific enough in its hypothesis.

Whiting, J. W. M., Child, I. L. 1953. *Child training and personality: a cross-cultural study*. New Haven, CT, US: Yale University Press. vi 353 pp. This piece represents a cross-cultural survey with a psychodynamicist approach to cultural anthropology. It examined 75 primitive societies to analyze links between childhood practices and adult behavior, focusing on oral and anal fixations, causes of guilt, and irrational fears.

Principal Concepts:

Regional comparison is an attempt to define classifications of cultures and then make inferences about processes of diffusion within a cultural region (Levinson and Ember 1996:263). It examines how cultures relate to each other as whole cultural units. This approach is well represented by the works of Kroeber and Driver, and it comes more from the Boasian tradition.

Holocultural analysis, the more recent term for cross-cultural analysis, has developed out of the ancestry from Tylor to Sumner and Keller and then to Murdock. Levinson says that a holocultural study "is designed to test or develop a proposition through the statistical analysis of data on a sample of ten or more non-literate societies from three or more geographical regions of the world" (1977:3). In this approach, cultural traits are taken out of the context of the whole culture and compared with cultural traits in widely diverse cultures in order to determine patterns of regularities and differences within the broad base of the study. Both of these approaches compare cultural units, but their unit of analysis differs from other approaches. The comparative method, as utilized in the worldwide approach, presents a basic problem to anthropology, and to anthropologists. Since the comparative method as applied by Murdock examines traits as separate from their cultural context, it conflicts with the holistic approach developed by Boas, in which each culture must be

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combination of the anthropological concepts of ethnology with structure and function, allowing the researcher to pose more specific questions on a broader range of subjects (1961, 125-127). Analysts are attempting to answer more specific questions in these research situations such as Spoehr's study which examined the changes in kinship systems among the Creek, Chickasaw, and Chocktaw, and other regional tribes of the Southeast after their removal to the Oklahoma reservations. Spoehr detailed these changes with an analysis of the historical factors responsible for them and the resulting processes (Eggan 1961:125-126). **Holonational** study is the study of universal traits within a national framework.

Coding refers to the process by which cross-cultural analysts obtain data from other sources. This can be done in two ways. Data can be coded directly from ethnographic sources, or it can be accessed from the ethnographic reports in the HRAF files. The first method requires reading and interpreting original sources, and the second entails using previously coded data from ethnographic sources or holocultural studies. Levinson and Malone suggest that dependent variables should be coded from the HRAF files or ethnographic sources and that independent variables should come from the compendia of coded data.

Methodologies:

Not all Cross-Cultural analysts agree on the same methodology, but there are two main concepts:

- comparison- is essential to anthropological research. To understand culture, societies must be compared.
- testing- all theories, despite fads or current trends require testing. Without comparison there is no way to evaluate if presumed cause and effect are related. This relates to the logical "if, then" inductive process. If cause is not present then the effect should not be present (Levinson and Ember 1996:262).

The comparative method is a search for comparable culture patterns in multiple societies, particularly the comparison of cultural traits taken out of cultural context (Winthrop 1991: 43). There are two main goals of cross-cultural analysis.

- The first goal is to describe the range and distribution of cultural variation existent in the ethnographies recorded.
- The second goal is to test the hypotheses and theories that are proposed to explain the variation recorded (Levinson and Ember 1996:261).

General requirements- that are stringently applied to the comparative method are:

- Scientific principles, method, and research design must be used.
- Explicit theory or hypothesis must be stated.
- Detail involved in study must be shown, allowing others to replicate study.
- Research must show measures are valid and reliable.
- Sampling procedure must be objective and clearly specified.
- Data must be made available to other researchers.
- Appropriate statistical tests must be employed.
- Results must be displayed for verification (Levinson and Ember 1996:261).

Methods that are specific to Cross-Cultural Analysis are:

- Cases must be chosen from different cultures.
- Research aims must represent the entire ethnographic record or geographic region.
- Research must compare cases that agree with hypothesis with and without the presumed causes to verify if the presumed effect is associated with causes. This is a Static-Group Comparison (Levinson and Ember 1996:261).

Accomplishments:

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William Graham Sumner compiled and wrote most of the massive four-volume *The Science of Society* (1927) which was completed after Sumner's death, including the index, by A.G. Keller (Harris 1968:607).

George Peter Murdock developed the Cross Cultural Survey in the 1930s-40s at Yale, as head of the Human Relations Program. This beginning grew into the Human Relations Area Files, which is now available in over 250 institutional libraries both here and abroad.

George P. Murdock combined the modern statistical method with modern ethnography, and statistical cross-cultural comparative method to create the HRAF. Murdock compiled the *Ethnographic Atlas*, published in *Ethnology*, a journal founded by Murdock in 1962. This is an atlas of the 600 societies described on the basis of several dozen coded features in Murdock's "World Ethnographic Sample".

Driver (1967) reanalyzed Murdock's *Ethnographic Atlas* using the two basic approaches of statistical analysis for anthropology: (1) the cultural traits as units of analysis, as proposed by Tylor and Murdock, and (2) using societies or tribes as the units of analysis, the approach suggested by Boas and Kroeber. Driver combined the concepts of these two approaches and came up with a more sophisticated method by inductively determining culture areas or "sets of strata" (Seymour-Smith 1986:61).

Criticisms:

"Galton's Problem"

When Tylor delivered his paper, "On a Method of Investigating the Development of Institutions, Applied to Laws of Marriage and Descent" (1889) to the Royal Anthropological Institute, Francis Galton, skilled in research design, was the presiding officer. Galton voiced what he saw as obvious flaws in the comparative methodology. This has ever since been known as "Galton's Problem."

- Galton observed that because societies could acquire customs by borrowing them, it is possible that the number of cultural adhesions could be fewer than assumed.
- Galton asserted that the circumstances in which the adhesion occurred, whether by diffusion or by independent emergence, would affect the interpretation of the cases.

Solutions to Galton's Problem

- Not using multiple cultures within the same geographic region for worldwide cross-cultural analysis.
- More recently, mathematical anthropologists have devised a set of tests for "spatial autocorrection" based on language and distance in multiple regression analysis (Levinson and Ember 1996:263).

Problems with the Comparative Method have been discussed by many anthropologists, including Murdock (1949), White (1973), Eggan (1954), Driver and Chaney (1973), and Hobhouse, Wheeler, and Ginsberg (1915). From these and other authors have emerged four major problem areas:

- identification and classification of the cultural items to be compared. What determines the scale of the items?
- the scope of the comparison temporally and spatially. What is the scope of the degree of expected difference between the pairs of social units compared?
- the aims of the comparison. Is the intent of the comparison the formulation of scientific "laws" of functional relationship, or is it the reconstruction of history from subsequent materials? Are the comparisons made for descriptive or analytic purposes? Is the style of argument inductive or deductive?
- the design of the comparison. How much control can be exercised over exogenous variation? How much attention is paid to sampling and statistical reliability? (Hammel 1980:147-148).

Additional criticisms of a more general nature were voiced by Marvin Harris.

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obtaining and emic view from an etic perspective is may be impossible, since outsiders may not comprehend what is actually happening in a given situation.Addressing the inconsistencies in the quality of data in the HRAF, Murdock is said to have commented that there was a “robustness” in Cross-Cultural method. He was unconcerned about errors occasionally occurring in data because he did not think that they would harm the validity of a study. Naroll was more concerned with this problem and thought that errors would threaten validity. He proposed a process of analyzing data quality of the ethnographies already in use. Naroll suggested that researchers should rate ethnographies for certain qualities, such as the author’s command of the native language and time spent in the field. This suggestion was carried through in an organized study, in which the data quality of the ethnographies was found to effect results obtained in cross-cultural analysis in only a very few cases (Levinson and Ember 1996:263).

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Relevant Journals

- *American Anthropologist*
- *Annual Review of Anthropology*
- *Cross-Cultural Research* (*CCR*)- This peer-reviewed journal has emerged as the primary venue for works involving cross-cultural analysis.
- *Ethnology*

Relevant Web Links:

- Human Relations Area Files
- Journal of Cross-Cultural Research
- World Cultures eJournal- An e eJournal founded by Dr. Douglas White, this is an excellent source for databases, articles, manuals and other resources for understanding and conducting cross-cultural research.
- World Cultural Comparsions- A web site accompanying a course offered by Dr. Douglas White at the University of California, Irvine. One of the most meticulous and resource-laden of any course web sites in anthropology, this page is particularly useful for those who have access to Jstor resources (available to UA faculty &students at http://www.lib.ua.edu/resources/databases/.)

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The University of Alabama

Department of Anthropology

ANTHROPOLOGICAL THEORIES

A GUIDE PREPARED BY STUDENTS FOR STUDENTS

The guides to anthropological theories and approaches listed below have been prepared by graduate students of the University of Alabama under the direction of Dr. Michael D. Murphy. As always, *!Caveat Retis Viator!* (Let the Net Traveller Beware!)

Select a Theory: Go

OR

Search the theory database

Ecological Anthropology

Maria Panakhyo and Stacy McGrath

(Note: authorship is arranged stratigraphically with the most recent author listed first)

Basic Premises:

https://anthropology.ua.edu/cultures/cultures.php?culture=Ecological%20An Go MAY FEB MAR 21 2016 2018 2019 8 captures 2 Feb 2018 About this capture

Ecological anthropology focuses upon the complex relations between people and their environment. Human populations have ongoing contact with the biotic, cultural, and physical species in their vicinities, and these elements of their environment have reciprocal impacts on human behavior (Salzman and Attwood 1996:169). Ecological anthropology investigates the ways that a population shapes its environment and subsequent manners in which these relations form the population's social, economic, and political life (Salzman and Attwood 1996:169). In a general sense, ecological anthropology attempts to provide a materialist explanation of human society and culture as products of adaptation to given environmental conditions (Seymour-Smith 1986:62).

In *The Origin of Species* (1859), Charles Darwin presented a synthetic theory of evolution based on the idea of descent with modification. In each generation, more individuals are produced than can survive (because of limited resources), and competition between individuals arises. Individuals with favorable characteristics, or variations, survive to reproduce. It is the environmental context that determines whether or not a trait is beneficial. Thomas R. Malthus (see Leading Figures) had an obvious influence on Darwin's formulations. Malthus pioneered demographic studies, arguing that human populations naturally tend to outstrip their food supply (Seymour-Smith 1986:87). This circumstance leads to disease and hunger which eventually put a limit on the growth of the population (Seymour-Smith 1986:87). The word "ecology" is derived from the Greek *oikos*, meaning habitation. Haekel coined our modern understanding of ecology in 1870, defining it as "the study of the economy, of the household, of animal organisms. This includes the relationships of animals with the inorganic and organic environments, above all the beneficial and inimical relations Darwin referred to as the conditions for the struggle of existence" (Netting 1977:1). Therefore, an ecosystem (see Principal Concepts) consists of organisms acting in a bounded environment.

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Boas, Malinowski, and others led to the realization that environmental determinism could not sufficiently account for observed realities, and a weaker form of determinism began to emerge (Milton 1997). At this time, Julian Steward coined the term "cultural ecology" (see Principal Concepts). He looked for the adaptive responses to similar environments that gave rise to cross-cultural similarities (Netting 1996:267). Steward's theory centered around a culture core, which he defined as "the constellation of features which are most closely related to subsistence activities and economic arrangements" (Steward 1955:37).

By the 1960s and 1970s, cultural ecology and environmental determinism lost favor within anthropology. Ecological anthropologists formed new schools of thought, including the ecosystem model, ethnoecology, and historical ecology (Barfield 1997:138). Researchers hoped that ecological anthropology and the study of adaptations would provide explanations of customs and institutions (Salzman and Attwood 1996:169). Ecological anthropologists believe that populations are not engaged with the total environment around them, but rather with a habitat consisting of certain selected aspects and local ecosystems (Kottak 1999:23-4). Furthermore, each population has its own adaptations institutionalized in the culture of the group, especially in their technologies (Salzman and Attwood 1996:169).

A field such as ecological anthropology is particularly relevant to contemporary concerns with the state of the general environment. Anthropological knowledge has the potential to inform and instruct humans about how to construct sustainable ways of life. Anthropology, especially when it has an environmental focus, also demonstrates the importance of preserving cultural diversity. Biological diversity is necessary for the adaptation and survival of all species; culture diversity may serve a similar role for the human species because it is clearly one of our most important mechanisms of adaptation.

Points of Reaction:

In the 1950s, dissatisfaction with existing vague and rigid theories of cultural change stimulated the adoption of an ecological perspective. This new perspective considers the role of the physical environment in cultural change in a more sophisticated manner than environmental determinism (see the work of Julian Steward and the Cultural Ecology web page at http://www.indiana.edu/~wanthro/eco.htm). Ecological anthropology is also a reaction to idealism, which is the idea that all objects in nature and experience are representations of the mind. Ecological anthropology inherently opposes the notion that ideas drive all human activities and existence. This particular field illustrates a turn toward the study of the material conditions of the environment, which have the potential to affect ideas. Furthermore, Steward was disillusioned with historical particularism and culture area approaches, and he subsequently emphasized environmental influences on culture and cultural evolution (Barfield 1997:448). Boas and his students (representing historical particularism) argued that cultures are unique and cannot be compared (Barfield 1997:491). In response, Steward's methodological approach to multilinear evolution called for a detailed comparison of a small number of cultures that were at the same level of sociocultural integration and in similar environments, yet vastly separated geographically (Barfield 1997:449).

During the 1960s, a shift in focus occurred in ecological anthropology because of changing trends and interactions within the global system. According to Kottak (1999), localized groups were no longer localized and isolated from global influences (Kottak 1999:23-4). With increases in exchange, communication, and migration, it became increasingly difficult to apply the terms and concepts once developed under the study of ecological anthropology (Kottak 1999:23-4). In the following decades there has been a gradual adaptation of the discipline to not only focusing on localized human/ecosystem interactions, but including global influences and how the global community is affecting how groups across the world interact with their ecosystems (Kottak 1999:25). Such global influences include aspects once associated with colonialism (i.e., the exploitation of foreign raw resources or misinterpretation of indigenous agricultural practices) (Kottak 1999:25-6). As a result of the changes occurring in the general outlook of ecological anthropology, subfields within the discipline have emerged. Researchers in the subfields are taking different approaches to studying the interaction of people and their ecosystems (see Ecological Anthropology Program). For example, the study of paleoecology examines human interaction with the environment from an archaeological perspective. Other topics addressed include problem solving environmental issues, creating better understandings of native perceptions of their own ecosystem, and sustaining on available resources (see Ecological Anthropology Program and Moran 2000). Interest in ecological anthropology and the various subfields can be further explored in the growing body of literature. For example, the University of South Florida provides the *Journal of Ecological Anthropology* which is an online publication with contemporary ecological research that is

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Leading Figures:

Malthus, Thomas R. (1766-1834)- Thomas R. Malthus is the author of *Essay on Population* (1798), which greatly influenced Charles Darwin. Malthus argued that populations grow exponentially, while resources only grow geometrically. Eventually, populations deplete their resources to such a degree that competition for survival becomes inevitable. This assumes that a struggle for existence will ensue, and only a certain number of individuals will survive. Malthus's ideas helped to form the ecological basis for Darwin's theory of natural selection.

Steward, Julian (1902-1972)- Steward developed the cultural ecology paradigm and introduced the idea of the culture core. He studied the Shoshone of the Great Basin in the 1930s and noted that they were hunter-gatherers heavily dependent on the pinon nut tree. Steward demonstrated that lower population densities exist in areas where the tree is sparsely distributed, thus illustrating the direct relationship between resource base and population density. He was also interested in the expression of this relationship in regards to water availability and management. His ideas on cultural ecology were also influenced by studies of South American indigenous groups. He edited a handbook on South American Indians, which was published after World War II. Steward's theories are presently regarded as examples of specific and multilinear evolution, where cross-cultural regularities exist due to the presence of similar environments. Steward specified three steps in the investigation of the cultural ecology of a society: (1) describing the natural resources and the technology used to extract and process them; (2) outlining the social organization of work for these subsistence and economic activities; (3) tracing the influence of these two phenomena on other aspects of culture (Barfield 1997:448). Julian Steward often fluctuated between determinism and possiblism (Balée 1996). He was interested in the comparative method in order to discover the laws of cultural phenomena (Barfield 1997:448).

White, Leslie (1900-1975)- White's principle preoccupation was with the process of general evolution, and he was best known for his strict materialist approach (Barfield 1997:491). He believed that the evolution of culture increases as does energy use per capita. Since the beginning of the hominid line, human beings have gradually increased their harnessing of energy from the environment. This results in cultural evolution. White described a process of universal evolution, in which all cultures evolve along a certain course (this course can be understood in measure of energy expenditure per capita). In comparison, Steward only claimed to see regularities cross-culturally. White described anthropology as "culturology" (Barfield 1997:491). He proposed to explain cultural evolution, C=E × T (where C=culture, E=energy, and T=technology). White also subscribed to a technological determinism, with technology ultimately determining the way people think (Balée 1996).

Harris, Marvin (1927-2001)- Marvin Harris completed fieldwork in Africa and Brazil, but he was best known for his development of cultural materialism. This school of thought centers on the notion that technological and economic features of a society have the primary role in shaping its particular characteristics. He assigned research priority to concepts of infrastructure over structure and superstructure (Barfield 1997:137). The infrastructure is composed of the mode of production, demography, and mating patterns. Structure refers to domestic and political economy, and superstructure consists of recreational and aesthetic products and services. Harris's purpose was to demonstrate the adaptive, materialist rationality of all cultural features by relating them to their particular environment (Milton 1997). Marvin Harris received his Ph.D. from Columbia University in1953, and he taught at Columbia University. During his later years, he conducted research and taught at the University of Florida (see American Materialism material and the Cultural Materialism material).

Rappaport, Roy A. (1926-1997)- Roy A. Rappaport was responsible for bringing ecology and structural functionalism together. Rappaport defined and was included in a paradigm called neofunctionalism (see Principal Concepts). He saw culture as a function of the ecosystem. The carrying capacity (see Principal Concepts) and energy expenditure are central themes in Rappaport's studies, conducted in New Guinea. He completed the first systematic study of ritual, religion, and ecology, and this study is characterized as synchronic (see Principal Concepts) and functionalist. The scientific revolution, functionalism in anthropology, and new ecology are the three main influences upon Rappaport. Furthermore, like Steward and Harris, he was more interested in the infrastructural aspects of society, similar to Steward. Rappaport was the first scientist to successfully reconcile ecological sciences and cybernetics with functionalism in anthropology (Balée 1996). Roy A. Rappaport was Professor of Anthropology at the University of Michigan and President of the American Anthropological Association (1987-89) (Moran 1990:xiii).

Vayda, Andrew P. is Professor Emeritus of Anthropology and Ecology at Rutgers University and a Senior Research Associate for the Center for International Forestry Research (CIFOR) in Bogor, Indonesia. He has taught at Columbia University, the University of Indonesia, and additional Indonesian universities. He specializes in

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Ecology and is a founding board member of the Association for Fire Ecology of the Tropics.

Netting, Robert McC. (1934-1995)- Robert McC. Netting wrote about agricultural practices, household organization, land tenure, warfare, historical demography, and cultural ecology (Netting 1977). He received his Ph.D. from the University of Chicago and was a Professor of Anthropology at the University of Arizona. He published *Hill Farmers of Nigeria: Cultural Ecology of the Kofyar of the Jos Plateau* (1973), *Cultural Ecology* (1986), and *Balancing on an Alp: Ecological Change and Continuity in a Swiss Mountain Community* (1981) (Moran 1984:xii).

Conklin, Harold (1926-)- Harold Conklin is most noted within ecological anthropology for showing that slash-and-burn cultivation under conditions of abundant land and sparse population is not environmentally destructive (Netting 1996:268). Furthermore, he gives complete descriptions of the wide and detailed knowledge of plant and animal species, climate, topography, and soils that makes up the ethnoscientific repertoire of indigenous food producers (Netting 1996:268). He sets the standards for ecological description with detailed maps of topography, land use, and village boundaries (Netting 1996:268). Conklin's work focuses on integrating the ethnoecology and cultural ecology of the agroecosystems of the Hanunoo and Ifugao in the Philippines (Barfield 1997:138).

Moran, Emilio F.- Emilio F. Moran is a specialist in ecological anthropology, resource management, and agricultural development (Moran 1984:ix). Moran studied the Brazilian Amazon extensively. His micro-level ecosystem analysis of soils in the Amazon revealed substantial areas of nutrient rich soils, which are completely overlooked in macro-level analyses (Balée 1996). Emilio F. Moran is a professor at Indiana University and has published *Human Adaptability* (1982), *Developing the Amazon* (1981), and *The Dilemma of Amazonian Development* (1983) (Moran 1984:ix).

Ellen, Roy F. (1947-)- Roy F. Ellen studies the ecology of subsistence behaviors, ethnobiology, classification, and the social organization of trade (Moran 1990:x). He is a Professor of Anthropology and Human Ecology at the University of Kent (Moran 1990:x). His work with the Nuaulu in West Java has led him to develop awareness concepts concerning indigenous peoples and their understandings of the environment (Ellen 1993). Ellen has published *Nuaulu Settlement and Ecology* (1981); *Environment, Subsistence and System: The Ecology of Small-Scale Social Formations* (1982); *Social and Ecological Systems; and Malinowski between Worlds* (1989).

Balée, William (1954-)- William Balée works within the historical ecology (see Principal Concepts) paradigm (Barfield 1997:138). Balée completed valuable ecological research among the Ka'apor in the Amazon of Brazil. Balée seeks to integrate aspects of ethnoecology, cultural ecology, biological ecology, political ecology, and regional ecology in a processual framework (Barfield 1997:138). Furthermore, Balée demonstrates an unconscious form of management among the Ka'apor with respect to one of their main resources- the yellow-footed tortoise. This indigenous group moves before the turtle becomes extinct in their immediate vicinity, and they also learn to exploit more of the area around the village in search of the tortoise (Balée 1996). He published *Footprints of the Forest: Ka'apor Ethnobotany—The Historical Ecology of Plant Utilization by an Amazonian People* (1993) and is the editor of *Advances in Historical Ecology*. William Balée received his Ph.D. from Columbia University, and he is a Professor of Anthropology at Tulane University.

Key Works:

Steward, Julian. 1955. Theory of Culture Change: The Methodology of Multilinear Evolution. Urbana: University of Illinois Press.

Julian Steward advocates multilinear evolution in this seminal book. Multilinear evolution "assumes that certain basic types of culture may develop in similar ways under similar conditions but that few concrete aspects of culture will appear among all groups of mankind in a regular sequence" (Steward 1955:4). Steward sought the causes of cultural changes and attempted to devise a method for recognizing the ways in which culture change is induced by adaptation to the environment (Steward 1955:4). This adaptation is called cultural ecology. According to Steward, "The cross-cultural regularities which arise from similar adaptive processes in similar environments are … synchronic in nature" (Steward 1955:4). The fundamental problem of cultural ecology is to determine whether the adjustments of human societies to their environments require particular modes of behavior or whether they permit latitude for a certain range of possible behaviors (Steward 1955:36). Steward also defines the culture core and discusses the method of cultural ecology, variation in ecological adaptation, development of complex societies, and

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This article is Harris's best example of the application of cultural materialism, specifically to the Hindu taboo against eating beef. He demonstrates that this taboo makes sense in terms of the local environment, because cattle are important in several ways (Milton 1997). Thus, the religious taboo is rational, in a materialist sense, because it ensures the conservation of resources provided by the cattle (Milton 1997). Harris comments upon the classification of numerous cattle as "useless" (Harris 1992:52). Ecologically, it is doubtful that any of the cattle are actually useless, especially when they are viewed as part of an ecosystem rather than as a sector of the price market (Harris 1992:52). For example, cows provide dung, milk, and labor, and Harris explores all of these instances thoroughly in this article. He notes that dung is used as an energy source and fertilizer. Nearly 46.7% of India's dairy products come from cow's milk (Harris 1966:53). Harris further states, "The principal positive ecological effect of India's bovine cattle is in their contribution to production of grain crops, from which about 80% of the human calorie ration comes" (Harris 1966:53). Cattle are the single most important means of traction for farmers. Furthermore, 25,000,000 cattle and buffalo die each year, and this provides the ecosystem with a substantial amount of protein (Harris 1966:54). By studying cattle of India with a holistic perspective, Harris provides a strong argument against the claim that these animals are useless and economically irrational.

Rappaport, Roy A. 1968. Pigs for the Ancestors: Ritual in the Ecology of a New Guinea People. New Haven: Yale University Press.

This book examines the Tsembaga Maring in New Guinea. The actual study group consists of approximately 200 people who live in two relatively isolated valleys. The Tsembaga Maring practices are a form of animal husbandry with pigs as their primary resource. Rappaport found that pigs consume the same food as humans in this environment, so the Tsembaga must produce a surplus in order to maintain their pig populations. Pigs are slaughtered for brideprice and at the end of war. So, the pigs must be kept at exactly the right numbers. This is accomplished through a cycle of war, pig slaughter for ritual purposes, and regrowth of the pig populations. Such a cycle takes ten to eleven years to complete. Rappaport illustrates that "indigenous beliefs in the sacrifice of pigs for the ancestors were a cognized model that produced operational changes in physical factors, such as the size and spatial spread of human and animal populations" (Netting 1996:269). Thus, religion and the *kaiko* ritual are cybernetic factors that act as a gauge to assist in maintaining equilibrium within the ecosystem (Netting 1996:269). The *kaiko* is a ritual of the Tsembaga during which they slaughter their pigs and partake in feasting. The *kaiko* can be understood easily as "ritual pig slaughter." The "biologization" of the ecological approach that this study represents within cultural anthropology led to the label ecological anthropology, replacing Steward's cultural ecology (Barfield 1997:137).

Netting, Robert McC. 1977. Cultural Ecology. Reading, Massachusetts: Cummings Publishing Company.

This book is a comprehensive review of ecological anthropology, highlighting its potential contributions to understanding humankind and its limitations. Netting uses his study of a Swiss alpine community to show relationships between land tenure and land use. He also discusses the future of shifting cultivation and the consequences of the Green Revolution (Netting 1997:Preface). Cultural Ecology contains chapters that focus on ecological perspectives, hunter-gatherers, Northwest coast fishermen, East African pastoralists, cultivators, field methods, and the limitations of ecology. This book provides numerous examples and applications of ecological anthropology and is an excellent outline and profile of the ecological movement in anthropology.

Principal Concepts:

Carrying Capacity- According to Moran (1979:326), carrying capacity is "[t]he number of individuals that a habitat can support" (Moran 1979:326). This idea is related to population pressure, referring to the demands of a population on the resources of its ecosystem (Moran 1979:334). If the technology of a group shifts, then the carrying capacity changes as well. An example of the application of carrying capacity within ecological anthropology is demonstrated in Rappaport's study of the Tsembaga Maring.

Cultural Ecology- Cultural ecology is the study of the adaptation of human societies or populations to their environments. Emphasis is on the arrangements of technique, economy, and social organization through which culture mediates the experience of the natural world (Winthrop 1991:47).

Culture Core- Julian Steward (1955:37) defined the cultural core as the features of a society that are the most closely related to subsistence activities and economic arrangements. Furthermore, the core includes political,

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Ecology- Ecology is the study of the interaction between living and nonliving components of the environment (Moran 1979:328). This pertains to the relationship between an organism and all aspects of its environment (see Basic Premises for further detail).

Ecosystem- An ecosystem is the structural and functional interrelationships among living organisms and the environment of which they are a part (Moran 1990:3). Ecosystems are complex and can be viewed on different scales or levels. Moran's study of soils in the Amazon is an example of micro-level ecosystem analysis (see Leading Figures).

Ecosystem Approach/Model- This is an approach used by some ecological anthropologists that focuses on physical (abiotic) components. Moran (1990:3) claims that this view uses the physical environment as the basis around which evolving species and adaptive responses are examined. The ecosystem approach had played a central role within ecological anthropology (see Methodologies for more details).

Environmental Determinism- A deterministic approach assigns one factor as the dominant influence in explanations. Environmental determinism is based on the assumption that cultural and natural areas are coterminous, because culture represents an adaptation to the particular environment (Steward 1955:35). Therefore, environmental factors determine human social and cultural behaviors (Milton 1997).

Ethnoecology- Ethnoecology is the paradigm that investigates native thought about environmental phenomena (Barfield 1997:138). Studies in ethnoecology often focus on indigenous classification hierarchies referring to particular aspects of the environment (for example, soil types, plants, and animals).

Ethnobotany- Ethnobotany is an ethnoscientific study of the relationship between human beings and plant life. During the 1960's ethnobotanical units were used in ecological comparisons (Kottak 1999:24).

Historical Ecology- Historical ecology examines how culture and environment mutually influence each other over time (Barfield 1997:138). These studies have diachronic dimensions. Historical ecology is holistic and affirms that life is not independent from culture. This is an ecological perspective adhering to the idea that the relationship between a human population and its physical environment can be examined holistically, rather than deterministically. Landscapes can be understood historically, as well as ecologically. Historical ecology attempts to study land as an artifact of human activity (Balée 1996).

Latent Function- A latent function of a behavior is not explicitly stated, recognized, or intended by the people involved. Thus, they are identified by observers. Latent functions are associated with etic and operational models. For example, in *Pigs for the Ancestors: Ritual in the Ecology of a New Guinea People* (2000), the latent function of the sacrifice is the presence of too many pigs, while its manifest function is the sacrifice of pigs to ancestors (Balée 1996).

Limiting Factor- In the 1960s cultural ecology focused on showing how resources could be limiting factors. A limiting factor is a variable in a region that, despite the limits or settings of any other variable, will limit the carrying capacity of that region to a certain number.

Manifest Function- A manifest function is explicitly stated and understood by the participants in the relevant action. The manifest function of a rain dance is to produce rain, and this outcome is intended and desired by people participating in the ritual. This could also be defined as emic with cognized models.

Neofunctionalism- This term represents a productive but short-lived 1960s revision of structural-functionalism. Neofunctionalism attends explicitly to the modeling of systems-level interactions, especially negative feedback, and assigns primary importance to techno-environmental forces, especially environment, ecology, and population (Bettinger 1996:851). Within neofunctionalism, culture is reduced to an adaptation, and functional behaviors are homeostatic and deviation counteracting, serving to maintain the system at large (Bettinger 1996:851). Neofunctional well being is measured in tangible currencies, such as population density, that relate to fitness (as in evolutionary biology) (Bettinger 1996:852).

Optimal forging theory- This theoretical perspective examines forging methods from the cost/benefit angle (Dove and Carpenter 2008:36). Analysis of this sort allows for researchers to determine the choices and logic behind changes in forging methods.

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Carpenter (2008), even though there is minimal ecological destruction and people are able to generate a high rate of food production, there are still many misconceptions about the practice (Dove and Carpenter 2008:27-8).

Synchronic Study- Rappaport conducted synchronic studies. These are short-term investigations that occur at one point in time and do not consider historical processes.

Methodologies:

Ecological anthropology has utilized several different methodologies during the course of its development. The methodology employed by cultural ecology, popular in the 1950s and early 1960s, involved the initial identification of the technology employed by populations in the use of environmental resources (Milton 1997). Patterns of behavior relevant to the use of that technology are then defined, and lastly, the extent to which these behaviors affect other cultural characteristics is examined (Milton 1997).

Marvin Harris's work led to the development of new methodologies in the 1960s. For Harris, cultural change begins at the infrastructural level (see Cultural Materialism). Harris's cultural materialism incorporates the ecological explanation and advances a more explicit and systematic scientific research strategy (Barfield 1997:137). The concept of adaptation was Harris's main explanatory mechanism (Milton 1997). His research, describe in *The Cultural Ecology of India's Sacred Cattle* (1966), indicated his methodology of extensive literary research and comparison. Marvin Harris's accomplishments and research indicated his desire to move anthropology in a Darwinian direction.

Rappaport and Vayda also contributed importantly to the application of new methodologies in the 1960s. They focus upon the ecosystem approach, systems functioning, and the flow of energy. These methods rely on the usage of measurements such as caloric expenditure and protein consumption. Careful attention was given to concepts derived from biological ecology, such as carrying capacity, limiting factors, homeostasis, and adaptation. This ecosystem approach remained popular among ecological anthropologists during the 1960s and the 1970s (Milton 1997). Ethnoecology was a prevalent approach throughout the same decades. The methodology of ethnoecology falls within cognitive anthropology (refer to the material on Cognitive Anthropology).

The 1970s and 1980s saw the emergence of radical cultural relativism. In the 1990s, ecological anthropologists rejected extreme cultural relativism and attacked modernist dichotomies (body and mind, action and thought, nature and culture) (Milton 1997). Recent ecological anthropology studies have included political ecology, uniting more traditional concerns for the environment–technology-social-organization nexus with the emphasis of political economy on power and inequality seen historically, the evaluation and critique of Third World development programs, and the analysis of environmental degradation (Netting 1996:270).

Accomplishments:

Anthropological knowledge has been advanced by ecological approaches. The application of biological ecology to cultural anthropology adds a new, scientific perspective to the discipline. Ecological anthropology contributes to the development of extended models of sustainability for humankind. Through research and study with indigenous peoples in an ecological framework, anthropologists learn more about intimate interactions between humans and their environments. In the 1990s, this field has enhanced our perceptions of the consequences of the development of the Amazon. The presence of ecology, an interdisciplinary undertaking, and the concept of the ecosystem in anthropology add new dimensions to theory and methodology. Thus, ecological investigations bring additional hybrid vigor to the field of anthropology.

Criticisms:

It has been argued that studied conducted within cultural ecology were limited to egalitarian societies. Furthermore, it is a theory and methodology used to explain how things stay the same, as opposed to how things can change (Balée 1996). There is an obvious lack of concern for the historical perspective, as well. By the 1960s, many anthropologists turned away from Steward's views and adopted the new idea that cultures could be involved in mutual activity with the environment. The term ecological anthropology was coined to label this new approach.

The cultural materialism of Marvin Harris has also been criticized. According to Milton (1997), "his presentation of cultural features as adaptive effectively makes his approach deterministic" (Milton 1997:480). In fact, some scholars

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biological organism, a tendency for models to ignore time and structural change, a tendency to neglect the role of individuals, and a tendency to overemphasize stability in ecosystems.

Comments:

The authors recommend Netting's *Cultural Ecology* (1977) to students who are interested in learning more about ecological anthropology.

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Relevant Web Links:

- Cultural Ecology at http://www.indiana.edu/~wanthro/eco.htm
- Roy Ellen's Environmental Anthropology Course Site at http://lucy.ukc.ac.uk/Maenv2.html
- Phil Porter and Connie Weil's Cultural Ecology Proseminar website at http://www.cwu.edu/~geograph/prosem1.htmll
- Ecology Communications at http://www.ecology.com/
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- Journal of Ecological Anthropology at the University of South Florida at http://shell.cas.usf.edu/jea/index.html
- Anthropology and the Environment, a subsection of the American Anthropological Association at http://www.eanth.org/
- Dr. Leslie E. Sponsel's "Contemporary Ecological Anthropology: A Survey, Analysis, and Commentary on it Academic Characteristics and Resources" publication at http://www.anthropology.hawaii.edu/Programs/Specializations/Ecological%20Anthropology/content/survey.pdf
- *Journal of Human Ecology* at http://www.krepublishers.com/02-Journals/JHE/JHE-00-0-000-000-1990-Web/JHE-00-0-000-000-1990-1-Cover.htm
- The University of Texas at San Antonio graduate program in ecological anthropology at http://colfa.utsa.edu/ant/doctoral.html
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ANTHROPOLOGICAL THEORIES

A GUIDE PREPARED BY STUDENTS FOR STUDENTS

The guides to anthropological theories and approaches listed below have been prepared by graduate students of the University of Alabama under the direction of Dr. Michael D. Murphy. As always, *!Caveat Retis Viator!* (Let the Net Traveller Beware!)

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Feminist Anthropology

Johnna Dominguez and Marsha Franks and James H Boschma, III

(Note: authorship is arranged stratigraphically with the most recent author listed first)

Basic Premises:

The subfield of Feminist Anthropology emerged as a reaction to a perceived androcentric bias within the discipline (Lamphere 1996: 488). Two related points should be made concerning this reaction. First of all, some of the prominent figures in early American anthropology (e.g. Margaret Mead and Ruth Benedict) were women, and the discipline has traditionally been more egalitarian, in terms of gender, than other social sciences (di Leonardo 1991: 5-6). Underlying that statement, however, is the fact that the discipline has been subject to prevailing modes of thought through time and has certainly exhibited the kind of androcentric thinking that early feminist anthropologists accused it of (Reiter 1975: 13-14).

There are three waves of feminist anthropology, just as there are multiple waves of feminism in general. However, these waves are not strictly chronological, with one ending as the other began. In fact, theories from second wave feminist anthropology are still relevant today despite theories from third wave anthropology. Yet it is useful to present the three waves in terms of their foci (Gellner and Stockett, 2006). The first wave, from 1850 to 1920, sought primarily to include women's voices in ethnography. What little ethnographic data concerning women that existed was often, in reality, the reports of male informants transmitted through male ethnographers (Pine 1996: 253). The second wave, from 1920 to 1980, moved into academic spheres and separated the notion of sex from that of gender, both of which previously had been used interchangeably. Gender was used to refer to both the male and the female, the cultural construction of these categories, and the relationship between them (Pine 1996:253). The definition of gender may vary from

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and production popular. Several of the scholars who follow this perspective focus on gender as it relates to class, the social relations of power, and changes in modes of production.

Contemporary feminist anthropologists constitute the theory's third wave, which began in the 1980s. Feminist anthropologists no longer focus solely on the issue of gender asymmetry, as this leads to neglect in fields of anthropology such as archaeology and physical anthropology (Geller and Stockett, 2006). Instead, feminist anthropologists now acknowledge differences through categories such as class, race, ethnicity, and so forth. Archaeology lags behind cultural anthropology, however, since the differences between sex and gender were not considered until the late 1980s and early 1990s (Conkey and Specter, 1984). The focus of contemporary scholars in third wave feminist anthropology is the differences existing among women rather than between males and females (McGee, Warms 1996: 392). However, this also encourages considerations of what categories such as age, occupation, religion, status, and so on mean and how they interact, moving away from the issue of male and female. Power is a critical component of feminist anthropology analysis, since it constructs and is constructed by identity. Studies include those that focus on production and work, reproduction and sexuality, and gender and the state (Lamphere 1997; Morgen 1989). This has resulted in a highly fragmented theoretical approach, which is necessary in its growth since it is based on a fragmented subject (Geller and Stockett, 2006).

Points of Reaction:

Feminist anthropologists first reacted against the fact that the discussion of women in the anthropological literature had been restricted to the areas of marriage, kinship, and family. Feminist anthropologists believe that the failure of past researchers to treat the issues of women and gender as significant has led to a deficient understanding of the human experience (McGee and Warms 1996:391, from Morgen 1989:1). One criticism made by feminist anthropologists is directed towards the language being used within the discipline. The use of the word "man" is ambiguous, sometimes referring to Homo sapiens as a whole, sometimes in reference to males only, and sometimes in reference to both simultaneously. Those making this criticism cited the Sapir-Whorf hypothesis, which stated that language shapes worldview.

Second wave feminist anthropologists were reacting against Durkheim's notion of a static system that can always too easily be broken down into inherent dichotomies. Instead, feminist anthropologists seek to show that the social system is dynamic. They base this dynamic theory on Marx's idea that social relations come down to praxis, or practice (Collier and Yanagisako 1989). Post-structuralist feminist anthropologists also criticized the theory of cultural feminism, opposed by women such as Mary Daly and Adrienne Rich. This was an essentialist view suggesting that there is a male and female essence that validates traditional roles of males and females: "the cultural feminist reappraisal construes woman's passivity as her peacefulness, her sentimentality as her proclivity to nurture, her subjectiveness as her advanced self-awareness" (Alcoff, 2006). Feminist anthropologists argue that cultural feminism ignores the oppressive powers under which traditional values were created.

A further point of reaction happened after the initial creation of the subfield. African-American anthropologists and members of other ethnic minorities were quick to point out deficiencies in the questions being asked by the early feminist anthropologists. One of those to do so was Audrey Lorde, who in a letter to Mary Daly wrote: "I feel you do celebrate differences between white women as a creative force towards change, rather than a reason for misunderstanding and separation. But you fail to recognize that, as women, those differences expose all women to various forms and degrees of patriarchal oppression, some of which we share, some of which we do not....The oppression of women knows no ethnic nor racial boundaries, true, but that does not mean it is identical within those boundaries" (Minh-ha 1989:101). Even today, graduate and undergraduate curricula still largely relies upon canonical works that are Eurocentric. For example, Zora Neale Hurston trained under Franz Boas, although she is excluded from anthropology because she never completed her PhD. The real reason for her exclusion may actually be her race and gender, and black anthropologists continue to be ignored and marginalized (McClaurin, 2001). In addition, early feminist anthropologists did indeed imply, in their search for universal explanations for female subordination and

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there is a focus on social categories such as age, occupation, religion, status, and so on. Power is an important component of analysis since the construction and enactment of identity occurs through discourses and actions that are structured by contexts of power (Gellner and Stockett, 2006). Queer theory is the most recent post-structuralist reaction against the notion of "normalcy" and focuses on gender and sexuality. Specifically, queer theory challenges heteronormativity, or the assumption that heterosexuality and the resulting social institutions are the normative sociosexual structures in all societies (Gellner and Stockett, 2006). Queer theory challenges the idea that gender is part of the essential self and that it is instead based upon the socially constructed nature of sexual acts and identities, which consist of many varied components (Warner, 1993; Barry, 2002).

Leading Figures:

Ruth Benedict (1887-1948): Benedict, a student of Franz Boas, was an early and influential female anthropologist, earning her doctorate from Columbia University in 1923 (Buckner 1997: 34) ?. Her fieldwork with Native Americans and other groups led her to develop the "configurational approach" to culture, seeing cultural systems as working to favor certain personality types among different societies (Buckner 1997: 34). Along with Margaret Mead she is one of the most prominent female anthropologists of the first half of this century.

Zora Neale Hurston (1891-1960): The first African American to chronicle African American folklore and voodou, Hurston studied anthropology at Barnard in the 1920s under Franz Boas, who encouraged her interests in African American folklore. Data for her scholarly work and creative writing came from her years growing up in all-black Eatonville, Florida, and she drew upon the keen insights and observations gained from her anthropological research in crafting her fictional work. The only black student at Barnard, and the only one known to have graduated from this institution, she received a B.A. degree in 1928. Two anthropological works are *Mules and Men* (1935) and *Tell My Horse* (1938). Hurston's contribution to anthropology was not merely in her superior ability to provide vivid imagery of Black culture, but also in her pioneering efforts toward theorizing the African diaspora, and her methodological innovations (McClaurin, 2001).

Phyllis Kaberry (1910-1977): She was a social anthropologist who worked with Bronislaw Malinowski while earning her PhD. Her work focused on women in many different societies, especially in Australia and Africa, although she placed great emphasis on religion. She also examined relationships between men and women.

Margaret Mead (1901-1978):She was a key figure in the second wave anthropology, for her work distinguished between sex and gender. Her theories were influenced by ideas borrowed from Gestalt psychology, that subfield of psychology which analyzed personality as an interrelated psychological pattern rather than a collection of separate elements (McGee, Warms 1996:202) Her work separated the biological factors from the cultural factors that control human behavior and personality development. Her work influenced Rosaldo's and Lamphere's attempts to build a framework for the emerging discipline. Mead's work contained an analysis of pervasive sexual asymmetry that fit with their reading of the ethnographic literature (Levinson, Ember 1996:488).

Eleanor Leacock (1922-1987): She uses a Marxist approach in her ethnographies, since she argues that capitalism is the reason for female subordination. She also challenged Julian Steward's work on hunting and trapping. Leacock talked to English speaking informants to find out their pattern of hunting, subsequently mapped out the hunting pattern herself to avoid informant's overgeneralization (Gacs, Khan, McIntyre, & Weinberg 1989).

Louise Lamphere (1940-): She worked along with Michelle Rosaldo to edit *Woman, Culture, and Society*. This was the first volume to address the anthropological study of gender and women's status.

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have always been symbolically associated with nature. Since nature is subordinate to men, women are subordinate to men. She suggests that women's role as childbearer makes them natural creators, while men are cultural creators (Ortner 1974: 77-78)). Ortner points out that men without high rank are excluded from things in the same way women are excluded from them.

Margaret Conkey (1943-): Conkey was one of the first archaeologists to introduce feminist theory into archaeology, and is thus a pioneering figure in the subfields of gender archaeology and feminist anthropology. She is a professor of Anthropology at the University of California, Berkeley.

Michelle Rosaldo (1944-1981): Together with Ortner, she offered an integrated set of explanations, each at a different level, for the universal subordination of women. These focused on social structure, culture, and socialization. She argued that in every society women bear and raise children and that women's socially and culturally defined role as mother provided the basis for subordination. Rosaldo argued that because women frequently participate in behaviors that limit them, one must perform an analysis of the larger system in order to understand gender inequality.

Nancy Scheper-Hughes (1944-): She is a feminist ethnographer whose work questions the idea of a universal definition for "man" and "woman." Her book, *Death Without Weeping: The Violence of Everyday Life in Brazil*, criticized the concept of innate maternal bonding, as women were forced to favor infants who would survive due to harsh living conditions. This books is now a classic in medical anthropology.

Gayle Rubin (1949-): An activist and influential theorist of sex and gender politics. She introduced the "sex/gender system," which distinguished biology from behavior in the same way Mead did with her work (Rubin, 1975). She shaped her ideas from works by Marx, Engels, Levi-Strauss and Freud.

Lila Abu-Lughod: She seeks to demonstrate that culture is boundless. In *Writing Women's Worlds*, she shared Bedouin women's stories and shows that they find advantages in a society which separates gender. Her works, like many others, dispel the misunderstandings many western feminists have about Islam and Hinduism.

Key Works:

- Abu-Lughod, Lila. 1993. Writing Women's Worlds: Bedouin Stories. University of California Press. This book draws on anthropological and feminist insights to construct a critical ethnography. She challenges the power of anthropological theory to render adequately the lives of others and the way feminist theory appropriates Third World women.

- Conkey, Margaret and Janet Spector. 1984. Archaeology and the Study of Gender. Advances in Archaeological Method and Theory, 7: 1-38. This article critiqued archaeologists for overlaying modern-day, Western gender norms onto past societies, such as in the sexual division of labor. It also critiqued that contexts and artifacts attributed to the activities of men were prioritized in research time and funding, and that the very character of the discipline was constructed around masculine values and norms.

- Conkey, Margaret and Joan Gero, eds. 1991. Engendering Archaeology: Women and Prehistory. Wiley-Blackwell. This book brings gender issues to archaeology for the first time in an explicit and theoretically informed way. Leading archaeologists from around the world contribute original analyses of prehistoric data to discover how gender systems operated in the past.

- Engels, Frederick. 1973. The Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State. Moscow: Progress Publishers. The theories developed by both Engels and Marx influenced many of the first feminist anthropologists. The quest for a universal understanding of female subordination, as well as the reliance upon dichotomies both had their roots in the ideas of these two men, and in the theories posited in this text.

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heteronormativity, difference, and identity.

- McClaurin, Irma. 2001. Black Feminist Anthropology: Theory, Politics, Praxis, and Poetics. Rutgers University Press. Unfortunately, the works of black and non-Western feminist anthropologists are rarely cited in major works, which means that they have yet to be respected as significant shapers of the direction and transformation of feminist anthropology. In this collection, Irma McClaurin has collected essays that explore the contributions of black feminist anthropologists.

- Mead, Margaret. 1935. Sex and Temperament in Three Primitive Societies. New York: William Morrow. In this text Mead explores the relationship between culture and human nature. Culture is considered to be a primary factor in determining masculine and feminine social characteristics and behavior. One of the purposes of this text was to inform Americans about the nature of human cultural diversity (McGee and Warms 1996:202-3).

- Mead, Margaret. 1949. Male and Female: A study of the sexes in a changing world. New York: Morrow Quill Paperbacks. By her own declaration, Mead attempts to do three things in this text. First, to bring a greater awareness of the way in which the differences and similarities in the bodies of human beings are the basis on which all our learning about our sex, and our relationship to the other sex, are built. Secondly, she draws on some of the knowledge we have of all human societies, to see what has been attempted in what situations, and what the results were. This is done in the hope that we might learn or be exposed to an idea that will leave us the better for it. Finally, she tries to suggest ways in which our civilization may make full use of both a man's and a woman's special talents (Mead 1949:5-6). Her analyses concerning the differences between males and females influenced many of the discussions that were to follow.

- Ortner, Sherry. 1974. Is Female to Male as Nature is to Culture? Anthropological Theory, pp. 402-413. Ortner offers an explanation to why women have been universally considered to be second-rate to men throughout history. She argues that women's body and psychology are perceived as symbolically identifiable with nature, while men are more associated with culture, thus resulting in the women being considered inferior to men.

- Ortner, Sherry. 1996. Making Gender: The Politics and Erotics of Culture. Boston: Beacon Press Books. In this book, Ortner draws on her more than two decades of work in feminist anthropology to offer a major reconsideration of culture and gender.

- Rosaldo, Michelle and Louise Lamphere, eds. 1974. Women, Culture, and Society. Stanford: Stanford University Press. This collection of essays emerged from a course at Stanford University, as well as from papers delivered at the 1971 American Anthropological Association meetings. These essays deal with the issue of universal sexual asymmetry, or female subordination.

- Reiter, Rayna, ed. 1975. Toward an Anthropology of Women. New York: Monthly Review Press. This anthology is considered one of the groundbreaking collections of feminist essays published in the 1970's, and includes works by authors such as Sally Slocum. The ideas expressed in this collection are heavily focused towards the development of universal explanations and helpful dichotomies.

- Rubin, Gayle. 1975. The Traffic of Women: Notes on the "Political Economy of Sex." In Toward an Anthropology of Women. Rubin attempts to discover historical social mechanisms by which gender and heterosexuality are produced, and women are consigned to a secondary position in human relations. In this essay, Rubin coined the phrase "sex/gender system."

- Scheper-Hughes, Nancy. 1993. Death Without Weeping: The Violence of Everyday Life in Brazil. Berkeley: University of California Press. Set in the lands of Northeast Brazil, this is an account which finds that mother love as conventionally understood is something of a bourgeois myth, a luxury for those who can reasonably expect that their infants will live.

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explain the subordination of women, which seemed to be universal and cross-cultural. Several theories were developed to understand this idea, including Marxism and binary oppositions.

Marxism: Marxist theory appealed to feminist anthropologists in the 1970s because "there is no theory which accounts for the oppression of women in its endless variety and monotonous similarity, cross-culturally and throughout history with anything like the explanatory power of the Marxist theory of class oppression" (Rubin 1975: 160). The Marxist model explains that the subordination of women in capitalist societies, both in terms of their reproductive role, "the reproduction of labor," as well as their value as unpaid or underpaid labor, arises from historical trends predating capitalism itself (Rubin 1975: 160-164) Engels, in The Origin of the Family, Private Property, and the State, attempted to explain the origin of these historical trends (Rubin 1975: 164-5). Like Marx, he attributed the oppression of women to shifts in the modes of production at the time of the Neolithic revolution (Rubin 1975: 169). According to Engels, once men had property (land or herds), they desired to transmit them to their offspring via patrilineal inheritance. This was accomplished by the overthrow of matrilineal inheritance and descent systems, leading to the "world historical defeat of the female sex" (Engels 1972: 120-121).

Universal binary opposition: Anthropologists such as Rosaldo, Edholm, and Ortner used dichotomies such as public/domestic, production/reproduction, and nature/culture (respectively) to explain universal female subordination. Ortner's use of the dichotomy to explain the universal subordination of women is built upon Levi-Strauss's conclusion that there is a universal binary opposition between nature and culture. He also argued that cross-culturally women were represented as closer to nature because of their role in reproduction (Pine 1996:254).

In the late 1970's many feminist anthropologists were beginning to question the concept of universal female subordination and the usefulness of models based on dichotomies. Some anthropologists argued that there existed societies where males and females held roles that were complementary but equal. The work done by A. Schlegal and J. Briggs in foraging and tribal societies is an example of this. K. Sacks used a modes-of-production analysis to show that "hunter-gatherers possessed a communal political economy in which sisters, wives, brothers, and husbands all had the same relation to productive means and resources". Another criticism made against the use of dichotomies was that these dichotomies were Western categories. They, therefore, are not applicable to cross-cultural studies and analyses (Lamphere 1996:489).

Domestic power of women: E. Friedl and L. Lamphere believe that, although females are subjected to universal subordination, they are not without individual power. These two anthropologists emphasize the domestic power of women. This power, according to this theoretical framework, is "manifested in individually negotiated relations based in the domestic sphere but influencing and even determining male activity in the public sphere" (Pine 1996:254).

Sex/Gender system: The use and development of the concept “gender” has helped to further separate feminist anthropology from the use of dichotomies and the search for universals. Gender, as it came to replace the term woman in the anthropological discussions, helped to free the issue of inequality from biological connotations. These new discussions of gender brought with them more complex issues of cross-cultural translation, universality, the relationship between thought systems and individual action, and between ideology and material conditions (Pine 1996: 255). I. Illich defines sex as the "duality that stretches toward the illusory goal of economic, political, legal, or social equality between women and men." He defines gender as the "eminently local and time bound duality that sets off men and women under circumstances and conditions that prevent them from saying, doing, desiring, or perceiving 'the same thing'" (Minh-ha 1989:105).

Identity: Focus on identity and difference has become the merging focus of feminist anthropology. This means that there is a focus on social categories such as age, occupation, religion, status, and so on. Power is an important component of analysis since the construction and enactment of identity occurs through discourses and actions that are structured by contexts of power (Gellner and Stockett, 2006).

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the essential self and that it is instead based upon the socially constructed nature of sexual acts and identities, which consist of many varied components (Warner, 1993; Barry, 2002).

Methodologies:

The unifying aspect of feminist anthropology is that it focuses on the role, status, and contributions of women to their societies. Within this framework, individual anthropologists explore a wide range of interests and employ a wide range of theoretical models to interpret data. It would, consequently, be problematic to characterize any one approach or model as predominant within the field at present. That observation aside, however, one should note that the field was more unified during its early development in the 1970s, when the interest was on developing models to explain the universal subordination of women.

Marxist analysis: Apparently, the preferred theoretical framework to analyze this state of affairs was Marxist. This preference stemmed both from the utility of the Marxist model for the analysis of gender asymmetry, as well as from the early foundational writings of Marx and Engels concerning the status of women in capitalist economic systems.Within the Marxist framework, the oppression of women is carried out by men in support of the capitalist system (Rubin 1975: 164-5). They maintain that the oppression of women supports capitalism on two levels: first of all, women serve as the means of reproducing the labor force. Additionally, however, women's unpaid or underpaid labor serves to help defray and conceal the overall cost of operating a capitalist economy, thereby elevating profit margins for the bourgeoisie (Rubin 1975: 164-5)

Structuralist approach: Initial explanatory models to account for female oppression also took a structuralist approach. Within these models, the roles of men and women were seen as being culturally constructed. The reproductive functions of women and men historically led to the association of women with lower-status, but relatively safer, activities within the domestic sphere, the village, or other setting. At the same time, men's role in reproduction allowed them (or forced them) to operate outside of "safe" spatial areas. These dichotomous orientations managed to outlive the environmental pressures which originally prompted their adoption.

Both the Marxist model and the structuralist model reject the notion that the oppression of women is associated with something innate and biological about the human species. Sexual dimorphism in humans is a biological feature of the species but serves only to facilitate the possible oppression of women, not to mandate it or program such behavior into humans (Leibowitz 1975: 20-1). Mead's ethnographic research examined cultures where male and female behavior was inconsistent with the western conception of rational males and emotional females, for instance (Leibowitz 1975: 20-1). Likewise, primate studies demonstrate widely varying forms of interaction between male and female apes (Leibowitz 1975: 25-31).

Accomplishments:

The most obvious contribution of feminist anthropology has been the increased awareness of women within anthropology, both in terms of ethnographic accounts and theory. This emphasis has challenged a number of enshrined beliefs, for instance concerning models of human origins wherein the "man the hunter" model was seen as being the driving force in human evolution, ignoring the role that women's productive and reproductive roles in the evolution of Homo sapiens sapiens (Conkey and Williams 1991: 116-7)

Feminist anthropology has been intimately tied to the study of gender and its construction by various societies, an interest that examines both women and men (di Leonardo 1991: 1).

Criticisms:

Feminist anthropology has been criticized for a number of issues since its emergence in the 1970s. Gellner and Stockett (2006) assert that many criticisms have been a vital part of feminist anthropology, since it has a

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criticism was that white, middle class female anthropologists were focusing too intensely on issues of gender. Consequently, the subfield was ignoring social inequalities arising from issues such as racism and the unequal distribution of wealth. This criticism has been redressed both by a heightened awareness of such issues by the aforementioned white, middle class feminist anthropologists, as well as the entry of large numbers of minority anthropologists into the field.

Additionally, feminist anthropology has been accused of mirroring the situation they originally criticized. The field began as a critique of the androcentric bias deriving from men (male ethnographers) studying men (male informants). However, it has often been the case that feminist anthropology consists of women studying women in the same arrangement. The field has attempted to address this issue by focusing more broadly on the issue of gender and moving away from the "Anthropology of Women" (di Leonardo 1991: 1).

Finally, the field has always been intimately associated with the Feminist Movement and has often been politicized. This practice is problematic on a number of levels. For one, it alienates many from the field by projecting an aura of radicalism. For another, putting politics before attempts at impartial inquiry tends to lead to research of questionable merit.

Comments:

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ANTHROPOLOGICAL THEORIES

A GUIDE PREPARED BY STUDENTS FOR STUDENTS

The guides to anthropological theories and approaches listed below have been prepared by graduate students of the University of Alabama under the direction of Dr. Michael D. Murphy. As always, *!Caveat Retis Viator!* (Let the Net Traveller Beware!)

Select a Theory: Go

OR

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Functionalism

Eric Porth and Kimberley Neutzling and Jessica Edwards

(Note: authorship is arranged stratigraphically with the most recent author listed first)

Basic Premises:

Functionalists seek to describe the different parts of a society and their relationship through the organic analogy. The organic analogy compared the different parts of a society to the organs of a living organism. The organism was able to live, reproduce and function through the organized system of its several parts and organs. Like a biological organism, a society was able to maintain its essential processes through the way that the different parts interacted together. Institutions such as religion, kinship and the economy were the organs and individuals were the cells in this social organism. Functionalist analyses examine the social significance of phenomena, that is, the *function* they serve a particular society in maintaining the whole (Jarvie 1973).

Functionalism, as a school of thought in anthropology, emerged in the early twentieth century. Bronislaw Malinowski and A.R. Radcliffe-Brown had the greatest influence on the development of functionalism from their posts in Great Britain. Functionalism was a reaction to the excesses of the evolutionary and diffusionist theories of the nineteenth century and the historicism of the early twentieth (Goldschmidt 1996:510). Two versions of functionalism developed between 1910 and 1930: Malinowski's biocultural (or psychological) functionalism; and structural-functionalism, the approach advanced by Radcliffe-Brown.

Malinowski suggested that individuals have physiological needs (reproduction, food, shelter) and that social institutions exist to meet these needs. There are also culturally derived needs and four basic "instrumental needs" (economics, social control, education, and political organization), that require institutional devices.

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Radcliffe-Brown focused on social structure rather than biological needs. He suggested that a society is a system of relationships maintaining itself through cybernetic feedback, while institutions are orderly sets of relationships whose function is to maintain the society as a system. Radcliffe-Brown, inspired by Augustus Comte, stated that the social constituted a separate "level" of reality distinct from those of biological forms and inorganic matter. Radcliffe-Brown argued that explanations of social phenomena had to be constructed within the social level. Thus, individuals were replaceable, transient occupants of social roles. Unlike Malinowski's emphasis on individuals, Radcliffe-Brown considered individuals irrelevant (Goldschmidt 1996:510).

Points of Reaction:

As a new paradigm, functionalism was presented as a reaction against what was believed to be outdated ideologies. It was an attempt to move away from the evolutionism and diffusionism that dominated American and British anthropology at the turn of the century (Lesser 1935, Langness 1987). There was a shift in focus from the speculatively historical or diachronic study of customs and cultural traits as "survivals" to the ahistorical, synchronic study of social "institutions" within bounded, functioning societies (Young 1991:445).

Functionalists presented their theoretical and methodological approaches as an attempt to expand sociocultural inquiry beyond the bounds of the evolutionary conception of social history. The evolutionary approach viewed customs or cultural traits as residual artifacts of cultural history. That is, the evolutionist school postulated that "an observed cultural fact was seen not in terms of what it was at the time of observation but in terms of what it must stand for in reference to what had formerly been the case" (Lesser 1935:55).

From the functionalist standpoint these earlier approaches privileged speculative theorizing over the discovery of facts. Functionalists believed the reality of events was to be found in their manifestations in the present. Hence, if events were to be understood it was their contemporary functioning that should be observed and recorded (Lesser 1935:55-56).

Consequently, this led some to interpret functionalism as being opposed to the study of history altogether. Radcliffe-Brown responded to this critique by stating that functionalists did not believe that useful historical information could be obtained with respect to primitive societies; it was not history, but "pseudo-history" to which functionalists objected (Harris 1968:524).

In the “primitive” societies that are studied by social anthropology, there are few written historic records. For example, we have no record of the development of social institutions among the Native Australians. Anthropologists, thinking of their study as a kind of historical study, fall back on conjecture and imagination; they invent "pseudo-historical" or "pseudo-casual" explanations. We have had innumerable and sometimes conflicting pseudo-historical accounts of the origin and development of the totemic institutions of the Native Australians. Such speculations have little place in serious anthropological discussion about institutions. This does not imply the rejection of historical explanation, but quite the contrary (Radcliffe-Brown 1952:3).

However, it is equally important to point out the criticisms of this "pseudo-history" reasoning for synchronic analysis. In light of readily available and abundant historical sources encountered in subsequent studies, it was suggested that this reasoning was a rationalization for avoiding a confrontation with the past. Such criticism may have led to efforts to combine diachronic and synchronic interests among later functionalist studies.

Leading Figures:

E.E. Evans-Pritchard (1902-1973) studied history at Oxford and anthropology at the University of London. He was considered one of the most notable British anthropologists after the Second World War. While Evans-Pritchard’s research includes numerous ethnic groups, he is best remembered for his work with the Nuer,

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aided in the shaping political theory. Later in his career, Evans-Pritchard emphasized the need for the inclusion of history in the study of social anthropology. In opposition to Radcliffe-Brown, Evans-Pritchard rejected the idea of social anthropology as a science and viewed it, rather, as a comparative history. Though he contributed greatly to the study of African societies, his work neglects to treat women as a significant part of the social whole. Although he began as a functionalist, Evans-Pritchard later shifted to a humanist approach (Beidelman 1991).

Sir Raymond Firth (1901-2002) was a social and economic anthropologist. He became interested in anthropology while doing his post-graduate work at the London School of Economics. Firth conducted research in most areas of social anthropology, in addition to intensive fieldwork in Tikopia. Perhaps his greatest contribution to the functionalist paradigm is his distinction between social structure and social organization (see Principal Concepts for a definition of the distinction between the two) (Silverman 1981, Watson-Gegeo 1991:198). "Firth's most significant contribution to anthropology is his development of a theoretical framework emphasizing choice, decision, organization and process in social and institutional behavior" (Watson-Gegeo 1991:198).

Meyer Fortes (1906-1983) was originally trained in psychology and was working in London as a clinical psychologist when he met Seligman and Malinowski at the London School of Economics in 1933. They persuaded him to undertake psychological and anthropological fieldwork in West Africa. His writing is heavy with theoretical assertions as he argued that empirical observation and analysis must be linked if social anthropology was to call itself a science (Barnes 1991).

Sir Edmund Leach (1910-1989) was very influential in social anthropology. He demonstrated the complex interrelationship of ideal models and political action within a historical context. His most influential ethnographic works were based on fieldwork in Burma, Sarawak and North Borneo (Sabah), and Sri Lanka. Although his initial theoretical approach was functionalist, Leach then shifted to processual analysis. Leach was later influenced by Claude Levi-Strass and adopted a structuralist approach. His 1962 publication *Rethinking Anthropology* offered a challenge to structural-functionalism (Seymour-Smith 1986:165).

Lucy Mair (1901-1986) received her degree in Classics in 1923. In 1927 she joined the London School of Economics in the Department of International Relations. Mair's fieldwork was in Uganda and her first studies focused on social change. She was an advocate of applied anthropology and argued that it was not a separate branch of the anthropological discipline. Mair was very concerned with public affairs, including the contemporary processes of colonization and land tenure (Davis 1991).

Bronislaw Malinowski (1884-1942) was one of the founding fathers of British social anthropology. He received his doctorate with highest honors in mathematics, physics and philosophy from the Jagiellonian University in Krakow. However, Malinowski's interests turned to anthropology after reading Frazier's *The Golden Bough*. In 1910 he enrolled in the London School of Economics to study anthropology.

With Radcliffe-Brown, Malinowski pushed for a paradigm shift in British anthropology; a change from the speculative and historical to the ahistorical study of social institutions. This theoretical shift gave rise to functionalism and established fieldwork as the constitutive experience of social anthropology (Kuper 1973, Young 1991). Malinowski's functionalism was highly influential in the 1920s and 1930s. As applied methodology, this approach worked, except for situations of social or cultural change. While elements of Malinowski's theory remain intact in current anthropological theory, it has changed from its original form with new and shifting paradigms (Young 1991:445).

However, Malinowski made his greatest contribution as an ethnographer. He emphasized the importance of studying social behavior and social relations in their concrete cultural contexts through participant-observation. He considered it crucial to consider the observable differences between norms and action; between what people say they do and what they actually do. His detailed descriptions of Trobriand social life and thought are among the most comprehensive in world ethnography and his *Argonauts of the Western Pacific* (1922) is one of the most widely read works of anthropology. Malinowski's enduring conceptual contributions lay in the areas of: kinship and marriage (e.g., the concept of "sociological paternity"); in

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manifest functions. Latent functions are those objective consequences of a cultural item which are neither intended nor recognized by the members of a society. Manifest functions are those objective consequences contributing to the adjustment or adaptation of the system which are intended and recognized by participants in the system (Kaplan and Manners 1972:58).

Talcott Parsons (1902-1979), a sociologist who contributed to the structural-functionalist school conceptualized the social universe in terms of four types and levels of "action systems," (culture, society, personality, and organismic/behavioral) with each system having to meet four functional needs (adaptation, goal attainment, integration, and latency). He analyzed the operation and interchanges of structures and processes within and between system levels taking into consideration these basic requisites (Turner and Maryanski 1991).

A.R. Radcliffe-Brown (1881-1955) was a founding father of functionalism associated with the branch known as structural-functionalism. He attended Cambridge where he studied moral science, which incorporated philosophy, economics and psychology. It was during this time that he earned the nick-name "Anarchy Brown" because of his political interests and affiliations. After completing his degree in 1904, he conducted fieldwork in the Andaman Islands and Western Australia. Radcliffe-Brown's emphasis on examining the contribution of phenomena to the maintenance of the social structure reflects the influence of French sociologist Emile Durkheim (Winthrop 1991:129). He particularly focused on the institutions of kinship and descent and suggested that, at least in tribal societies, they determined the character of family organization, politics, economy, and inter-group relations (Winthrop 1991:130).

Audrey Richards (1899-1984) conducted her ethnographic research among the Bemba and in Northern Rhodesia. Her major theoretical interests included economic and political systems, the study of colonial rule, and anthropological participation, social change and the study of ritual (Seymour-Smith 1986:248).

Key Works:

- Evans-Pritchard, E. E. 1940. The Nuer. Oxford. One of the first ethnographic works written by a professional anthropologist. Describes the livelihood of a pastoral people and examines the organization of a society without government and legal institutions
- Evans-Pritchard, E. E. 1950. Social Anthropology and Other Essays. London. Contains a critique of Radcliffe-Brown's functionalism from the perspective of historicism
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Principal Concepts:

The primary starting points of Malinowski's theorizing included: 1) understanding behavior in terms of the motivation of individuals, including both rational, 'scientifically' validated behavior and 'irrational', ritual, magical, or religious behavior; 2) recognizing the interconnectedness of the different items which constituted a 'culture' to form some kind of system; and 3) understanding a particular item by identifying its function in the current contemporary operation of that culture (Firth 1957:55).

The inclusiveness of Malinowski's concept of culture is apparent in his statement:

"It obviously is the integral whole consisting of implements and consumers' goods, of constitutional charters for the various social groupings, of human ideas and crafts, beliefs and customs. Whether we consider a very simple or primitive culture or an extremely complex and developed one, we are confronted by a vast apparatus, partly material, partly human and partly spiritual by which man is able to cope with the concrete specific problems that face him" (Malinowski 1944:36).

Essentially, he treated culture as everything pertaining to human life and action which cannot be regarded as a property of the human organism as a physiological system. In other words, he treated it as a direct manifestation of biologically inherited patterns of behavior. Culture is that aspect of behavior that is learned by the individual and which may be shared by pluralities of individuals. It is transmitted to other individuals along with the physical objects associated with learned patterns and activities (Firth 1957:58).

As stated in Malinowski's text *The Scientific Theory of Culture and Other Essays*:

1. Culture is essentially an instrumental apparatus by which man is put in a position to better cope with the concrete, specific problems that face him in his environment in the course of the satisfaction of his needs.
2. It is a system of objects, activities, and attitudes in which every part exists as a means to an end.
3. It is an integral in which the various elements are interdependent.
4. Such activities, attitudes and objects are organized around important and vital tasks into institutions such as family, the clan, the local community, the tribe, and the organized teams of economic cooperation, political, legal, and educational activity.
5. From the dynamic point of view, that is, as regards the type of activity, culture can be analyzed into a number of aspects such as education, social control, economics, systems of knowledge, belief, and morality, and also modes of creative and artistic expression" (1944:150).

Malinowski considered institutions to be examples of isolated organized behaviors. Since such behavior always involves a plurality of persons, an institution in this sense is therefore a social system, which is a subsystem of society. Though functionally differentiated from other institutions, an institution is a segmentary cross-section of culture that involves all the components included in Malinowski's definition of culture (Firth 1957:59). Malinowski believed that the central feature of the charter of an institution is "the system of values for the pursuit of which human beings organize, or enter organizations already existing" (Malinowski 1944:52). As for the concept of function, Malinowski believed it is the primary basis of differentiation of institutions within the same culture. In other words, institutions differ because they are organized to serve

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"It is clear, I think, that any theory of culture has to start from the organic needs of man, and if it succeeds in relating (to them) the more complex, indirect, but perhaps fully imperative needs of the type which we call spiritual or economic or social, it will supply us with a set of general laws such as we need in sound scientific theory" (Malinowski 1944:72-73).

Malinowski's basic theoretical attempt was to derive the main characteristics of the society and its social systems from a theory of the causally pre-cultural needs of the organism. He believed that culture is always instrumental to the satisfaction of organic needs. Therefore, he had to bridge the gap between the concept of biologically basic needs of the organism and the facts of culturally organized behavior. His first major step was to set up the classification of basic needs which could be directly related to a classification of cultural responses which could then in turn be brought into relation to institutions. Next, he developed a second category of needs (derived needs) which he inserted between his basic needs and the institutional integrates of collective behavior (Firth 1957:63).

SYNOPTIC SURVEY OF BIOLOGICAL AND DERIVED NEEDS AND THEIR SATISFACTION IN CULTURE

Basic Needs (Individual)	Direct Responses (Organized, i.e., Collective)	Instrumental Needs	Responses to Instrumental Needs	Symbolic and Integrative Needs	Systems of Thought and Faith
Nutrition (metabolism)	Commissariat	Renewal of cultural apparatus	Economics	Transmission of experience by means of precise, consistent principles	Knowledge
Reproduction	Marriage and family				
Bodily comforts	Domicile and dress	Characters of behavior and their sanctions	Social control		
Safety	Protection and defense			Means of intellectual, emotional, and pragmatic control of destiny and chance	Magic Religion
Relaxation	Systems of play and repose	Renewal of personnel	Education		
Movement	Set activities and systems of communication				

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(SOURCE: Malinowski's Basic Human Needs as presented in Langness 1987:80)

Radcliffe-Brown's emphasis on social function is derived from the influence of the French sociological school. This school developed in the 1890s around the work of Emile Durkheim who argued that "social phenomena constitute a domain, or order, of reality that is independent of psychological and biological facts. Social phenomena, therefore, must be explained in terms of other social phenomena, and not by reference to psychobiological needs, drives, impulses, and so forth" (Broce 1973:39-40).

Emile Durkheim argued that ethnographers should study the function of social institutions and how they function together to maintain the social whole (Broce 1973:39-40). Radcliffe-Brown shared this emphasis of studying the conditions under which social structures are maintained. He also believed that the functioning of societies, like that of other natural systems, is governed by laws that can be discovered though systematic comparison (Broce 1873:40). It is important to note here that Firth postulated the necessity of distinguishing between social structure and social organization. Social structure "is the principle(s) on which the forms of social relations depend. Social organization refers to the directional activity, to the working out of social relations in everyday life" (Watson-Gegeo 1991:198).

Radcliffe-Brown established an analogy between social life and organic life to explain the concept of function. He emphasized the contribution of phenomena to maintaining social order. However, Radcliffe-Brown's disregard for individual needs was apparent in this analogy. He argued that as long as a biological organism lives, it preserves the continuity of structure, but not preserve the unity of its constituent parts. That is, over a period of time, while the constituent cells do not remain the same, the structural arrangement of the constituent units remains similar. He suggested that human beings, as essential units, are connected by a set of social relations into an integrated whole. Like the biological organism, the continuity of the social structure is not destroyed by changes in the units. Although individuals may leave the society by death or other means, other individuals may enter it. Therefore, the continuity is maintained by the process of social life, which consists of the activities and interactions of individual human beings and of organized groups into which they are united. The social life of a community is the functioning of the social structure. The function of any recurrent activity is the part it plays in the social life as a whole and thereby, the contribution it makes to structural continuity (Radcliffe-Brown 1952:178).

Methodologies:

Radcliffe-Brown and Malinowski formulated distinct versions of functionalism, yet the emphasis on the differences between them obscures their fundamental similarities and complementarily. Both viewed society as structured into a working unity in which the parts accommodate one another in a way that maintains the whole. Thus, the function of a custom or institution is the contribution it makes to the maintenance of the entire system of which it is a part. On the whole, sociocultural systems function to provide their members with adaptations to environmental circumstances and to connect them in a network of stable social relationships. This is not to say that functionalists failed to recognize internal social conflict or other forms of disequilibrium. However, they did believe that societies strongly tend to maintain their stability and internal cohesion as if societies had homeostatic qualities (Broce 1973:38-39).

The functionalists also shared an emphasis on intensive fieldwork, involving participant-observation. This methodological emphasis has resulted in a series of excellent monographs on native societies. In large part, the quality of these monographs may be attributed to their theoretical framework, since the investigation of functional interrelationships of customs and institutions provides an especially fruitful perspective for the collection of information.

In their analysis, the functionalists attempted to interpret societies as they operated at a single point in time, or as they operate over a relatively short period of time. This was not because the functionalists opposed, in principle, the study of history. Instead, it was a consequence of their belief that very little reliable information

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Accomplishments:

By the 1970's functionalism was declining, but its contributions continue to influence anthropologists today. Functional analysis gave value to social institutions by considering them not as mere custom (as proposed by American ethnologists), but as active and integrated parts of a social system (Langness 1987). Though Malinowski and Radcliffe-Brown differed in their approaches to functional interpretation, they both contributed to the push for a "shift in the assumptions of ethnology, from a concern with isolated traits to the interpretation of social life" (Winthrop 1991:130).

This school of thought has contributed to the concept of culture that traditional usages, whatever their origin, have been shaped by the requirement that human beings must live together in harmony. Therefore the demands of interpersonal relationships are a causative force in culture (Goldschmidt 1967:17-18).

Despite its theoretical limitations, functionalism has made important methodological contributions. With its emphasis on intensive fieldwork, functionalism has provided in-depth studies of societies. Additionally, the investigation of functional interrelationships of customs and institutions provides a ready-made framework for the collection of information.

Its theoretical difficulties notwithstanding, functionalism can yet be fruitful. Such statements as, "all societies are functionally cohesive," are too vague to be refuted easily. However, these statements can be refuted if they suggest that societies do not change or disintegrate. Therefore, such theories can be considered uncontroversial tautologies. It could be said that functionalism is the integration of false theory and trivially true tautology into a blueprint for fieldwork. Accordingly, such fieldwork can be thought of as empirical attempts to refute such ideas that savages are simple-minded, that savage customs are superstitious, and that savage societies are chaotic, in essence, that savage societies are "savage."

Criticisms:

Functionalism became dominant in American theory in the 1950s and 1960s. With time, criticism of this approach has escalated, resulting in its decline in the early 1970s. Interactionist theorists criticized functionalism for failing to conceptualize adequately the complex nature of actors and the process of interaction. Marxist theory argued against functionalism's conservativism and the static nature of analysis that emphasized the contribution of social phenomena to the maintenance of the status-quo. Advocates of theory construction questioned the utility of excessively classificatory or typological theories that pigeonholed phenomena in terms of their functions (Turner and Maryanski 1991). Functional theory also has been criticized for its disregard of the historical process and for its presupposition that societies are in a state of equilibrium (Goldschmidt 1996:511).

Logical problems of functional explanations also have been pointed out, namely that they are teleological and tautological. It has been argued that the presence of an institution cannot precede the institution's existence. Otherwise, such a teleological argument would suggest that the institution's development anticipated its function. This criticism can be countered by recognizing an evolutionary or a historical process at work; however, functionalism specifically rejected such ideas. Functional analysis has also been criticized for being circular: needs are postulated on the basis of existing institutions which are, in turn, used to explain their existence. This criticism can be countered by establishing a set of universal requisite needs, or functional prerequisites. It has been argued that to account for phenomena by showing what social needs they satisfy does not explain how it originated or why it is what it is (Kucklick 1996:250). Furthermore, functionalism's antihistoric approach made it impossible to examine social processes, rejection of psychology made it impossible to understand attitudes and sentiments and the rejection of culture led to a lack of recognition of the ecological context (Goldschmidt 1996:511).

In light of such criticisms, some anthropologists attempted functional explanations that were not constrained by such narrow approaches. In Clyde Kluckhohn's functional explanation of Navaho witchcraft, he avoided tautology by positing a social need (to manage hostility), thereby bringing a psychological assumption into

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be understood in its own terms; every institution be seen as a product of the culture within which it developed. Following this, a cross-cultural comparison of institutions is a false enterprise in that it would be comparing phenomena that could not be compared. This is problematic since the internal mode of analysis cannot provide either a basis for true generalization or a means of extrapolation beyond the local time and place (Goldschmidt 1966:8). Recognizing this "Malinowskian dilemma," Walter Goldschmidt argued for a "comparative functionalism." This approach recognizes the universality of functions to which institutions are a response. Goldschmidt suggested that problems are consistent from culture to culture, but institutional solutions vary. He suggested starting with what is problematical in order to discover how institutional devices provide solutions. In this way, he too sought to situate his explanations in a broader theoretical framework (Goldschmidt 1996:511-512).

Neofunctionalism is a 1960s revision of British structural-functionalism that experienced renewed activity during the 1980s. Some neo-functionalists, influenced by Parsons, analyze phenomena in terms of specific functional requisites. Others, although they place less emphasis on functional requisites and examine a variety of phenomena, also share similarities with functionalism by focusing on issues of social differentiation, integration, and social evolution. Finally, some neo-functionalists examine how cultural processes (including ritual, ideology, and values) integrate social structures. Generally, there is little emphasis on how phenomena meet or fail to meet system needs (Turner and Maryanski 1991).

Neofunctionalism differs from structural-functionalism by focusing on the modeling of systems-level interactions, particularly negative feedback. It also emphasizes techno-environmental forces, especially environment, ecology, and population, thereby reducing culture to adaptation (Bettinger 1996:851). Both neofunctionalism and structural-functionalism explain phenomena with reference to the needs they fulfill. They consider problematic cultural behaviors to result largely from benefits they generate that are essential to sustaining or improving the well-being of larger systems in which they are embedded, these systems being cultures in the case of structural-functionalism and ecosystems in the case of neo-functionalism (Bettinger 1996:851).

Structural-functionalists believe these benefits are generated by behaviors that reinforce group cohesion, particularly ritual, or that provide the individual with effective mechanisms for coping with psychological threatening situations by means such as religion or magic. Neofunctionalists, on the other hand, are concerned with issues that relate directly to fitness similar to that in evolutionary biology (Bettinger 1996:852).

These emphases correspond to the kinds of groups that preoccupy structural-functional and neofunctional explanation. Structural-functional groups are culturally constituted, as cultures, by group-reinforcing cultural behaviors. Rather than separating humans from other animals, neofunctionalists focus on groups as biologically constituted populations aggregated in cooperative social alliances, by which self-interested individuals obtain fitness benefits as a consequence of group membership (Bettinger 1996:852).

Since obviously rational, beneficial behaviors require no special explanation, structural-functionalism and neofunctionalism focus on finding rationality in seemingly irrational behaviors. Neofunctionalism, with economic rationality as its basic frame of reference, believes that what is irrational for the individual in the short run may be rational for the group in the long run. Therefore, neofunctionalist explanation seemed to provide a bridge between human behavior, which frequently involves cooperation, and natural selection, where individual interaction involves competition more than cooperation. Additionally, this type of argument was traditional in that it emphasized cultural behaviors whose stated purpose (manifest function) concealed a more important latent function. However, evolutionary theorists suggest that group selection occurs only under rare circumstances, thereby revealing the insufficiency of fitness-related self-interest to sustain among groups of unrelated individuals over any extended period (Bettinger 1996:853).

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- Malinowski
- Selected Bibliography of Bronislaw Malinowski
- Radcliffe-Brown
- Raymond Firth
- Meyer Fortes
- The Durkheim Pages
- Sociological Theorists: Dead and Alive

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The University of Alabama

Department of Anthropology

ANTHROPOLOGICAL THEORIES

A GUIDE PREPARED BY STUDENTS FOR STUDENTS

The guides to anthropological theories and approaches listed below have been prepared by graduate students of the University of Alabama under the direction of Dr. Michael D. Murphy. As always, *!Caveat Retis Viator!* (Let the Net Traveller Beware!)

Select a Theory: Go

OR

Search the theory database

Historicism

Deanna Smith and Joseph Scruggs and Jonathan Berry and C. Thomas Lewis, III

(Note: authorship is arranged stratigraphically with the most recent author listed first)

Basic Premises:

Historicism is an approach to the study of anthropology and culture that dates back to the mid-nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. It encompasses two distinct forms of historicism: diffusionism and historical particularism. This approach is most often associated with Franz Boas and his many students, but it was actually developed much earlier by diffusionists who sought to offer alternative explanations of culture change to those argued for by social evolutionists. The evolutionists posited that humans share a set of characteristics and modes of thinking that transcend individual cultures (psychic unity of mankind) and therefore, the cultural development of individual societies will reflect this transcendent commonality through a similar series of developmental stages. This implied that the development of individual societies could be plotted with regard to the developments of other societies and their level of development "measured". Low levels of development were attributed to relatively lower mental developments than in more developed societies. Historicism assigned particular significance to the specific context of culture, such as to historical period or geographical location. It placed great importance on cautious and contextualized interpretation of data, as well as a relativistic point of view, and rejected the universal, immutable interpretations of the social evolutionists.

While socio-cultural evolution offered an explanation of what happened and where, it was unable to describe the particular influences on and processes of cultural change and development. To accomplish this end, an historical approach was needed for the study of culture change and development in order to explain not only

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The British school of diffusionism was led by G. E. Smith and included other figures such as W. J. Perry and, for a while, W. H. R. Rivers. These individuals argued that all of culture and civilization was developed only once in ancient Egypt and diffused throughout the rest of the world through migration and colonization. Therefore, all cultures were tied together by this thread of common origin (inferring the psychic unity of mankind) and, as a result, worldwide cultural development could be viewed as a reaction of native cultures to this diffusion of culture from Egypt and could only be understood as such. This school of thought did not hold up long due to its inability to account for independent invention.

The German school, led by Fritz Graebner, developed a more sophisticated historical approach to socio-cultural development. To account for the independent invention of culture elements, the theory of culture circles was utilized. This theory argued that culture traits developed in a few areas of the world and diffused in concentric circles, or culture circles. Thus, worldwide socio-cultural development could be viewed as a function of the interaction of expanding culture circles with native cultures and other culture circles.

Historical particularism was an approach popularized by Franz Boas as an alternative to the worldwide theories of socio-cultural development as promoted by both evolutionists and extreme diffusionists, which he believed were simply improvable. Boas argued that in order to overcome this, one had to carry out detailed regional studies of individual cultures to discover the distribution of culture traits and to understand the individual processes of culture change at work. In short, Boas sought to reconstruct the histories of cultures. He stressed the meticulous collection and organization of ethnographic data on all aspects of many different human societies. Only after information on the particulars of many different cultures had been gathered could generalizations about cultural development be made with any expectation of accuracy.

Boas's theories were carried on and further developed by scholars who were contemporaries with or studied under him at Columbia University. The more influential of these students include Alfred L. Kroeber, Ruth Benedict, Robert Lowie, Paul Radin and Edward Sapir. The contributions of these and others are detailed in the *Leading Figures* section below.

Points of Reaction:

Historicism developed out of dissatisfaction with the theories of unilineal socio-cultural evolution. Proponents of these theories included Charles Darwin, E. B. Tylor, J. McLennan, and Sir John Lubbock. Later writers such as Lewis Henry Morgan, Herbert Spencer, Daniel Brinton and J. W. Powell took the concept of socio-cultural evolution and added racial overtones to previously developed theories as a way of explaining different rates of social and cultural development. Their theories concerning the development of human societies were rooted in the still earlier works of the late eighteenth century, which claimed humanity rose to civilization through a series of gradually developing lineal stages towards the alleged perfection (or 'near' perfection) of civilized society. These thinkers posited that each move up the evolutionary ladder was accompanied by an increase in mental ability and capacity. Each level of development was preceded by an increase in mental capacity. This mode of thinking depicted primitive man as operating on a base level of mental functioning, which was akin to instinct. If a society was found to be in a state of savagery or barbarism, it was because its members had not yet developed the mental functions needed to develop into a civilized society. A further problem with these unilineal models of cultural development was their inherent assumption that Western European society was the end of the sequence and highest attainable level of development. This posed a major problem for historicists, and particularly for Boas, who did not believe one could understand and interpret cultural change, and therefore reconstruct the history of a particular society, unless the investigator conducted observations based on the perspective of those they are studying. Therefore, Boas held that it was necessary for the investigator to examine all available evidence for a society before an investigation began. Boas's belief in the importance of intensive fieldwork was passed on to his many students and is evident in their works and methodologies.

Diffusionist historicism developed into two related but different schools of thought: the British diffusionists and the German diffusionists. The British school, led by G. Elliot Smith and W. H. R. Rivers, argued that components of civilization developed in a few areas of the world. When transportation reached a level of

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civilization and that migrations from these centers were responsible for carrying civilization to remote parts of the world.

The German diffusionists argued that civilization was developed in only a few isolated regions and that independent invention of cultural elements and complexes was not a common event. However, people did move around and develop contacts with their neighbors and civilization was passed on through these contacts. Over time, these few isolated regions would have passed on their civilization to their neighbors and developed culture areas that diffused in concentric circles called culture circles. The German diffusionists worked to identify the centers of culture circles and trace the spread of ideas and technology from the centers through contact with surrounding cultures. These culture circles would spread through additional contacts with neighboring culture areas. As a result, the aspects of civilization that formerly characterized only a few isolated regions would be diffused to all parts of the world and the originality of these isolated regions of independent invention would be lost to history. This school of thought focused on the localized tracing of traits over time and space.

Boas and his contemporaries disagreed with the universal models and theories of cultural development that were advocated by evolutionists as well as by British and German diffusionists. The Boasians believed that so many different stimuli acted on the development of a culture that this development could only be understood by first examining the particulars of a specific culture so that the sources of stimuli could be identified. Only then may theories of cultural development be constructed which are themselves based on a multitude of synchronic studies pieced together to form a pattern of development. Theories derived from this type of historically grounded investigation were more accurate and exhaustive than the older models of evolutionism and diffusionist historicism, but they did not identify cross-cultural patterns.

Leading Figures:

Grafton Elliot Smith (1871-1937) – Smith is credited with founding and leading the British school of diffusionism. Through a comparative study of different peoples from around the world that have practiced mummification, Smith formulated a theory that all of the people he studied originally derived their mummification practices from Egypt. He concluded that civilization was created only once in Egypt and spread throughout the world, just as mummification had, through colonization, migration, and diffusion. Other proponents of the British school of diffusionism included W.J. Perry and, for a while, W. H. R. Rivers. Smith's important works include *The Migrations of Early Culture* (1915) and *The Ancient Egyptians and the Origin of Civilization* (1923) (Lupton 1991:644-5).

R. Fritz Graebner (1877-1934) – Graebner is remembered for being the founder of the German School of diffusionism. Graebner borrowed the idea of culture area and the psychic unity of mankind as developed by Adolf Bastian and used it to develop his theory of Kulturekreistehere (culture circles), which was primarily concerned with the description of patterns of culture distribution (Winthrop 1991:222). His theory of culture circles posits that culture traits are invented once and combine with other culture traits to create culture patterns, both of which radiate outwards in concentric circles. By examining these various culture traits, one can create a world culture history (Winthrop 1991:61-62). Graebner insisted on a critical examination of sources and emphasized the relevance of historical and cultural connections to the development of sequences and data analysis. The most complete exposition of his views is contained in his major work, *Die Methode der Ethnologie* (Putzstuck 1991:247-8).

Franz Boas (1858-1942) – Boas was born in Minden, Westphalia (now part of Germany) and grew up in Germany. At the age of twenty he enrolled in college at Heidelberg. He studied physics and geography both in Heidelberg and in Bonn. He received his Ph.D. in 1881 from the University of Kiel. His dissertation was entitled "Contributions to the Understanding of the Color of Water." After a brief teaching position at the University of Berlin, Boas moved to North America where he conducted fieldwork in 1886 among the Kwakiutl, which aroused within him an interest in "primitive" culture. This interest was to be demonstrated through his first extensive work with the Eskimo of Baffin Island. He became an American citizen the following year and took a position as Instructor at Clark University. In 1896, he left Clark and became

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American Archaeology and Ethnology, and was the resident director during the 1911-1912 season (Tax 1991:68, see also Bohannan 1973:81).

Boas is the name most often associated with the historicist approach to anthropology. He did not believe that the grand theories of socio-political evolution or diffusion were provable. To him, the view that all societies are part of one single human culture evolving towards a cultural pinnacle is flawed, especially when proposing a western model of civilization as the cultural pinnacle. Boas also depicted the theories regarding independent invention within human culture as inherently incorrect. He argued that *many* cultures developed independently, each based on its own particular set of circumstances such as geography, climate, resources and particular cultural borrowing. Based on this argument, reconstructing the history of individual cultures requires an in-depth investigation that compares groups of culture traits in specific geographical areas. Then the distribution of these culture traits must be plotted. Once the distribution of many sets of culture traits is plotted for a general geographic area, patterns of cultural borrowing may be determined. This allows the reconstruction of individual histories of specific cultures by informing the investigator which of the cultural elements were borrowed and which were developed individually (Bock 1996:299).

Perhaps the most important and lasting of Boas' contributions to the field of anthropology is his influence on the generation of anthropologists that followed him and developed and improved on his own work. He was an important figure in encouraging women to enter and thrive in the field. The better known of his students include Kroeber, Mead, Benedict, Lowie, Radin, Wissler, Spier, Bunzel, Hallowell and Montagu (Barfield 1997:44).

Alfred Louis Kroeber (1876-1960) – In 1901, Kroeber received the first Ph.D. awarded by Columbia University in the field of Anthropology. At Columbia he studied under Boas where he developed his interest in ethnology and linguistics. He had a great impact on these two sub-fields through a series of highly influential articles published throughout his career. Influenced heavily by Boas, Kroeber was concerned with reconstructing history through a descriptive analysis of concrete cultural phenomena that were grouped into complexes, configurations, and patterns which were themselves grouped into culture types whose comparative relationships could be analyzed to reveal their histories. Kroeber is further noted for his use and development of the idea of culture as a superorganic entity that must be analyzed by methods specific to its nature. In other words, one cannot examine and analyze a culture in the same manner that one would analyze the individual; the two are entirely different phenomena and must be treated as such (Willey 1988:171-92).

Though he was influenced heavily by Boas, Kroeber disagreed with his mentor in several areas. Kroeber grew to believe that Boas placed too much emphasis on the gathering and organizing of data and was too concerned with causal processes (abstract phenomena) and their description. Kroeber was concerned with concrete phenomena and their development over time and concluded that Boas did not emphasize these aspects enough in his own investigations (Buckley 1991:364-6).

Ruth Benedict (1887-1948) – Benedict studied under Boas at Columbia and received her Ph.D. in 1923. She stayed in New York, the city of her birth, and worked at Columbia for the rest of her life. She began at the University as a part-time teacher in the 1920s and, in 1948, she was appointed the first female full professor in the Anthropology department at Columbia University. Throughout her career she conducted extensive fieldwork, gathering data on such groups as the Serrano in California, the Zuni, Cochitii and Pima in the Southwest, the Mescalero Apache in Arizona and the Blackfoot and Blood of the Northwest Plains (Caffrey 1991:44).

Benedict is most noted for her development of the concepts of culture configurations and culture and personality, both developed in *Patterns of Culture* (1934). Benedict elaborated the concept of culture configuration as a way of characterizing individual cultures as an historical elaboration of those cultures' personalities or temperaments (Voget 1996:575). Culture and Personality is used to study the relationships between culture and personality. Cultural configurations such as Apollonian and Dionysian are products of this relationship and are psychological types that can characterize both individuals and cultures (Seymour-Smith 1986:66).

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heavily on historical documents in his studies of the Plains Indians. His most lasting contribution to Anthropology was his 1920 publication of *Primitive Society*, which examined and critiqued Lewis Henry Morgan's theories about social evolution. The ideas Lowie developed from this critique held sway over the field until the late 1940s with the work of Murdock and Levi-Strauss (Matthey 1991:426-7).

Edward Sapir (1884-1939) – Sapir was born in Laurenberg, Germany, but grew up in New York City and eventually entered Columbia University, where he was attracted to Boas' work in Indian linguistics. His study under Boas led to fieldwork among the Chinook, Takelma, and Yana Indians of the Northwest. He received his Ph.D. in 1909, writing his dissertation on Takelma grammar. Though he joined Boas, Kroeber, Benedict and others in defining goals in theoretical terms, he disagreed with Boas and Kroeber's reconciliation of the individual within society. He specifically disagreed with Kroeber's idea that culture was separate from the individual, His ideas on this subject more closely resemble those of Benedict (Golla 1991:603-5).

Paul Radin (1883-1959) – Radin was born in the city of Lodz (then part of Poland) but moved to the United States with his family when he was only one year old. Though he was interested in history, he worked with Boas at Columbia, receiving a Ph.D. in anthropology in 1910. Radin proved to be a critic of Boas' methods and concept of culture as well as a critic of two of his other friends, Sapir and Leslie Spier. Radin argued for a less quantitative, more historical approach to ethnology similar to Lowie's work in the Plains. Radin criticized of Kroeber's superorganic concept of culture. Radin argued that it is the individual who introduces change or innovation into a culture, and therefore it is the individual who shapes culture and not, as Kroeber argued, culture that shapes the individual (Sacharoff-Fast Wolf 1991:565).

Clark Wissler (1870-1947) – Wissler grew up in Indiana and attended the University of Indiana, earning his A.B and A.M. in psychology. He continued his education at Columbia to work on his Ph.D. in psychology but, because the Anthropology and Psychology departments were merged, he did limited work with Boas. Wissler, unlike Boas and most of his other students, was concerned with broad theoretical statements about culture and anthropology. He paid particular attention to the timing of the diffusion of specific ideas or technologies. He was noted for his use of culture areas in cross-cultural analysis and in building theories. Wissler helped to push anthropology far beyond evolutionism, in addition to pulling it away from Boas's particularistic style of anthropology (Freed and Freed 1991:763-4).

Arjun Appadurai (born 1949) – Appadurai was born in Mumbai (Bombay), India. He was educated in India, receiving his Intermediate Arts degree from Elphinstone College, before moving to the United States to further his education. He earned his B.A. from Brandeis University (1970). He received his M.A. (1973) and PhD (1976) from the University of Chicago, where he became a professor shortly after. Appadurai advocated a view of cultural activity known as social imaginary. The imaginary in this point of view is composed of five different scapes (ethnoscapes, mediascapes, technoscapes, finanscapes, and ideoscapes) and was deemed a social practice. This moved the imagination into the realm of global cultural processes, and it soon became central to all forms of agency.

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Principal Concepts:

Evolutionist School

Evolution and Social Evolution: Evolution is a theory most closely identified with Charles Darwin. This concept was applied to the problem of cultural development and used to develop stage theories of socio-cultural development. These theories tended to argue that all cultures develop at different speeds along a set of predetermined tracks. Therefore, the level of development can be determined according to the place a particular culture occupies on this scale. Once a society has been placed on the scale, its past development could be reconstructed and its possible future determined. Some advocates of the Evolutionist School extended this argument to include the idea that the reason some societies have developed more quickly than others is that the mental capacities of its members are more developed than those whose progress along this scale has been slower.

This approach has been greatly criticized for oversimplifying and overgeneralizing culture change, along with promoting ethnocentric, and sometimes racist, beliefs in explicit favor of Western Europeans. Historicism rose largely out of dissatisfaction with the problems of the evolutionist school.

Diffusionist School

Diffusion: Diffusion is a concept that refers to the spread of a cultural trait from one geographical area to another through such processes as migration, colonization, trade, and cultural borrowings. The concept of diffusion has been used to create two different diffusionist schools: the British and German. The British school, led by G. E. Smith, held that all aspects of culture and civilization were invented once and *diffused* outwards to spread throughout the world. The German school, led by Graebner, used the principles of culture areas and culture circles to account for independent invention. This theory argued that different aspects of culture and civilization were invented in several different areas and diffused outwards in radiating circles, culture circles.

Independent Invention: The principle of independent invention was developed to account for the fact that similar aspects of civilization developed by different peoples in different areas at different times. Most diffusionists did not emphasize the concept of independent invention. While some used the “psychic unity of

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scholars from a number of different theoretical schools and used as a tool for cross-cultural analysis as a means of determining the spread of culture traits. The term is used to characterize any region of relative cultural and environmental uniformity, a region containing a common pattern of culture traits (Winthrop 1991:61).

The German diffusionists used culture areas to identify where particular cultural elements developed. The spread of a particular cultural element occurs in concentric circles from the point of origin. By identifying culture circles and tracing their spread, the German diffusionists argued that one could reconstruct the entire history of world cultural development (Barfield 1997:103).

Culture Circle: *Culture Circle* is a term created by the German diffusionists to serve as a methodological tool for tracing the spread of cultural elements from a culture area in an attempt to reconstruct the history of culture development.

Psychic Unity of Mankind: The concept of psychic unity is used to refer to a common set of modes of thinking and characteristics that transcend individuals or cultures. Evolutionists depended heavily upon the concept. It was in fact the foundation of their comparative method because it made it possible to determine a society's particular state of development relative to the rest of the world.

The British diffusionists used the concept to confirm their belief that civilization developed once in ancient Egypt and then spread through migration and colonization. That all humans share this common set of characteristics and modes of thinking was used as evidence for a single origin of civilization and human culture.

The German diffusionists used the term to refer to sets of folk ideals and elementary ideals. For example, the elementary ideal of deity is represented as a set of different folk ideals in individual cultures such as the Christian God, Allah, Buddha, Ra, Odin, etc. (Winthrop 1991:222-3).

Historical Particularist Approach

Culture: There is no adequate definition of culture and more than likely never will be. Rather than defining the term listed below are interpretations from various individuals most often associated with the historicist approach.

Boas: Franz Boas viewed culture as a set of customs, social institutions and beliefs that characterize any particular society. He argued that cultural differences were not due to race, but rather to differing environmental conditions and other 'accidents of history' (Goodenough 1996:292). Further, cultures had to be viewed as fusions of differing culture traits that developed in different space and time (Durrenberger 1996:417)

Kroeber: Kroeber's view of culture is best described by the term superorganic, that is, culture is sui generis and as such can only be explained in terms of itself. Culture is an entity that exists separate from the psychology and biology of the individual and obeys its own set of laws (Winthrop 1991:280-281).

Benedict: Ruth Benedict defined culture as basic ways of living and defined a particular culture in terms of a unique culture configuration or psychological type. The collective psychologies of a certain people make up their particular culture configuration, which is determined by the collective relationship, and nature of a culture's parts (Goodenough 1996:139).

Lowie: Lowie's view of culture is very much like that of Boas. He considered culture to be disparate histories, Boas' the product of combination of geographical conditions, resources, and accidents of history (Bernard and Spencer 1996: 139).

Sapir: Sapir placed more emphasis on the individual that either Boas of Kroeber. He argued that culture is not contained within a society itself. Culture consists of the many interactions between the individuals of the

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contrast to Kroeber who claimed culture was an entity of its own and shaped the individual, Radin argued that the individual molds culture through innovation of new techniques and beliefs Sacharoff-Fast Wolf 1991:565).

Wissler: Wissler defined culture in his writings as a learned behavior or a complex of ideas (Freed and Freed 1991:763). He argued that individual elements of culture are expressed as many culture traits that may be grouped into culture complexes. The whole of culture complexes was the expression of culture (Barnard and Spencer 1996:139).

Superorganic: This is a term coined by Herbert Spencer in 1867 and utilized by Kroeber to help explain his view of culture and culture change. He saw culture as an entity of itself and separate from the individual. He explained that culture, indeed ends where the individual ends. To accurately understand culture, a separate body of theory and methodology specific to culture must be utilized (Winthrop 1991:280).

Cultural Relativism: This tenant holds that the beliefs, customs, practices and rituals of an individual culture must be observed and evaluated from the perspective in which they originate and are manifested. This is the only way to truly understand the meaning of observations and place them in historical context (Barfield 1997:98).

Culture and Personality: This concept is associated with Ruth Benedict. The basic tenants of it are explained in *Patterns of Culture* (1934). The argument holds that culture is like an individual in that it is a more-or-less consistent pattern of thoughts and behavior. These consistent patterns take on the emotional and intellectual characteristics of the individuals within the society. These characteristics may be studied to gain in[http://anthropology.ua.edu:80/cultures/cultures.php?culture=Histori] Go [AUG MAR APR] [30] [2016 2017 2018] [About this capture] [14 captures 20 Jul 2011 - 30 Mar 2017] eing ps logical reductionism (Seymore-Smith 1986:66).

Culture Configuration: This is a concept developed by Ruth Benedict to assist in explaining the nature of culture. A culture configuration is the expression of the personality of a particular society. A culture configuration is the sum of all the individual personalities of the society, a sort of societal psychological average. Differences in cultural configurations are not representative of a higher or lower capacity for cultural development but are instead simply alternative means of organizing society and experience (Caffrey 1991:44).

Neo-Boasianism

Neo-Boasianism is a return to the notions of historical particularism and structural realism that had pervaded the ideas of Franz Boas and the original Historical Particularist School. It was a broad interest approach to anthropological research. It was the analysis of the relations between the mind and observable social structures. Neo-Boasianism is a return to realism and the critical science within an anthropological framework. It is not particularly entrenched in structural analysis, yet anthropologists that subscribe to this mode of thinking are concerned with the connections between cultural social structures and biological structures. Neo-Boasianism adopts a type of agency, focusing on the actions of individuals within the cultural system as operations of structure. Social structures, according to this school of thought, only exist as long as there are relationships between agents. It is the analysis of the connection between external social structures and the structures of the brain by the means of a cultural neurohermeneutic system. This system allowed humans to connect antecedent reality with consequent reality. It is by this link between realities that social structure formation is made possible.

Methodologies:

Historical particularism is an approach to understanding the nature of culture and cultural changes of particular people. It is not a particular methodology. Boas argued that the history of a particular culture lay in the study of the individual traits of a particular culture in a limited geographical region. After many different cultures have been studied in the same way within a region, the history of individual cultures may be

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To this end, Boas and his students stressed the importance of gathering as much data as possible about individual cultures before any assumptions or interpretations are made regarding a culture or culture change within a culture. He and his students took great pains to record any and all manner of information. This included the recording of oral history and tradition (salvage ethnology) and basic ethnographic methods such as participant observation. The emphasis on intensive participant observation largely paralleled Malinowski's fieldwork methods being used by European anthropologists around the same time (see Functionalism for more). However, the people being studied and the overall theoretical aims of these two schools were quite different. Boas also stressed the importance of all sub-fields of anthropology in reconstructing history. Ethnographic evidence must be used with linguistic evidence, archaeological remains and physical and biological evidence. This approach became known as the four-field method of anthropology and was spread to anthropology departments all over the United States by Boas' students and their students.

Some Methodological Statements

Franz Boas:

"If we want to make progress on the desired line, we must insist upon critical methods, based not on generalities but on each individual case. In many cases the final decision will be on dependent origin in others in favor of dissemination" (Boas, as quoted by Harris 260). "Boas was aggressively atheoretical, rejecting as unsubstantiated assumptions the grand reconstructions of both evolutionists, such as Lewis Henry Morgan and Herbert Spencer, and diffusionists, such as G. E. Smith and Fritz Graebner" (Winthrop 83-84). Marvin Harris records Boas' "mission" as seeking "to rid anthropology of its amateurs and armchair specialists by making ethnographic research in the field the central experience and minimum attribute of professional status" (Harris 250)

Paul Radin:

Ethnography, he held, should only have "as much of the past and as much of the contacts with other cultures as is necessary for the elucidation of the particular period. No more" (Radin, as quoted by Hays 292).

Clark Wissler:

"The future status of anthropology depends upon the establishment of a chronology for man and his culture based upon objective verifiable data" (Wissler, as quoted by Hays 290).

Accomplishments:

Many of Boas' conclusions, as well as those of his most noted students, have fallen out of favor as more anthropological work has been carried out. However, Boas and his students are responsible for taking anthropology away from grand theories of evolution and diffusion and refocusing its attention on the many different cultures and varieties of cultural expression. Also, the interplay of countless factors that influence culture and culture change received more attention as a result of Boas and his students.

The emphasis on the importance of the collection of data has paid dividends for modern scholars. The vast amount of information generated by their investigations has provided raw information for countless subsequent studies and investigations, much of which would have been lost to time had 'oral cultures' not been recorded. Though current fieldwork methods have changed since Boas set forth his ideas on participant observation, those ideas have formed the foundation for fieldwork methods among anthropologists in the U.S.

Criticisms:

Most of the criticism of historical particularism has arisen over the issue of data collection and fear of making broad theories. Boas' insistence on the tireless collection of data fell under attack by some of his own students, particularly Wissler. Some saw the vast amounts being collected as a body of knowledge that would

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Eventually, salvage ethnography was also abandoned in favor of ethnography dealing with modern processes such as colonization and globalization. Instead of asking people about their past, some anthropologists have found it more important to study the cultural processes of the present.

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Relevant Web Links:

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- Franz Boas, the Encyclopedia Britannica entry
- Franz Boas, the Wikipedia entry
- Franz Boas' Historical Faculty page, Columbia University
- Franz Boas, a brief biography
- Franz Boas, a brief overview (with bibliography)
- Franz Boas and the African American Intelligentsia (by Vernon Williams)
- Franz Boas papers, The American Philosophical Society
- The Franz Boas Project (German language. Some browsers will translate into English)

A.L. Kroeber

- A. L. Kroeber, the Encyclopedia Britannica entry
- A. L. Kroeber, Audio Video Collection at Berkeley
- A. L. Kroeber Obituary, by Julian Steward

Robert H. Lowie

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G. Elliot Smith

G. Elliot Smith, Dictionary of Australian Biography

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The University of Alabama

Department of Anthropology

ANTHROPOLOGICAL THEORIES

A GUIDE PREPARED BY STUDENTS FOR STUDENTS

The guides to anthropological theories and approaches listed below have been prepared by graduate students of the University of Alabama under the direction of Dr. Michael D. Murphy. As always, *!Caveat Retis Viator!* (Let the Net Traveller Beware!)

Select a Theory: Go

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Marxist Anthropology

Sarah Morrow and Robert Lusteck

(Note: authorship is arranged stratigraphically with the most recent author listed first)

Basic Premises:

Marxism is essentially an economic interpretation of history based primarily on the works of Karl Marx and Frederich Engels. Marx was a revolutionary who focused his efforts on understanding capitalism to overthrow it. The rationale for the development of capitalism and the need to move towards communism is developed fully in *Capital* (1867), but introduced in *The Communist Manifesto* (1848). Marx, whose orientation was largely materialist and historicist, framed his analysis around four central points: the physical reality of people, the organization of social relations, the value of the historical context of development, and the human nature of continuous praxis.

As far as anthropology is concerned, the foundational work is Engels' *The Origin of the Family, Private Property, and the State: In Light of the Investigations of Lewis H. Morgan* (1884). Lewis Henry Morgan's materialist focus had lead Marx to making extensive notes on *Ancient Society* (1877), which Engels would later expand into *The Origin*…. Both of these men were influenced by Louis Henry Morgan and his model of social evolution based on material concerns. Morgan proposed that societies moved from more primitive to more civilized stages of development. The Marxist version of this resulted in transitions of stage from primitive communism, through feudalism and capitalism, to communism; stages are judged in terms of the modes of production which dominate each stage. Marx did not see these stages as progressive steps that every culture must progress through, but as being the development of historically contingent communities and their modes of production.

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realign themselves. However the ruling classes have a vested interest in maintaining their power and will seek to resist such change, though futilely in the long run, by whatever means they can. A key tool of the ruling classes is the elaboration of mystification in ideology, which results in the false consciousness of the lower class. Social evolution can be slowed, but not stopped.

Points of Reaction:

Marxist anthropology came about through the works of Marx and Engels and their followers. It developed as a critique and alternative to the domination of Euro-American capitalism and Eurocentric views in the social sciences. Marx was heavily influenced by extensive reading of Classical and Enlightenment era philosophers. Epicurean thought, which focused on the agency of the individual, the absence of a divine power, and the importance of contingency over teleology, was pervasive in Marx's writing, including his dissertation work. Rousseau's emphasis on history as being a self correcting tool to validate or contradict the statements of politicians clearly influences Marx's understanding of the connection between the structure and the mode of production. Hegel's work, which had the most significant impact on Marx, illustrated the community (while Kant illustrated the individual) and its role in the historically contingent realities in which it exists. Marx would spend much of his career drawing from and critiquing Hegel. The emphasis on the ability of humans to produce social change, the contradictory relationships of power, and the need for systematic investigation into the nature of social problems was very influential to Marx (see Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit* from 1807*)*. However, Hegel advocated a teleological approach to social change that Marx would reject through his later works. When Darwin posited his theory of Natural Selection in *The Origin of Species* (1859), Marx took the argument to be self evident and intuitive to his understanding of both the natural world and humanity's role within it.

Leading Figures:

Marx, Karl (1818-1883) Marx is often called the most successful social scientist of all time. Born in 1818, Marx lived during a period that allowed him to document the ways in which capitalism and the rise of industry influenced class structures. As a Jewish born Prussian, Marx experienced social divisions from an early age, despite his family being of notable wealth. His time at the University of Bonn and the University of Berlin would lead him to explore philosophical inquires relating to the emancipation of man from religious and political structures. Drawing from Hegel, Marx was an advocate of understanding economic and political changes as a historically contingent dialectic. His Hegelian idealism would diminish over the course of his writings and he would begin to approach his work with a more systematic, scientific approach. The emphasis on understanding these changes through material concerns would lead Marx to identify production as being at the heart of class differences. By looking at capitalism in a holistic fashion, Marx developed a theory of change based around the need for social classes to become equal as the modes and relations of production changed. Marx emphasized that the central component of the worker's revolution was not philosophical concerns, but action. Through analysis of failed revolutions, successful revolutions, and nations on the verge of revolution, Marx believed that the criteria for a successful communist nation could be discerned. In the process, he developed a set of economic structures and their progressive development. His life was marked by constant pressure from various governments across Europe, multiple expulsions from European countries, and a strong family connection to social movements. Without a doubt, he was one of the first true social scientists and, standing alongside Durkheim and Webber, one of the most influential social scientists in history.

Engels, Friedrich(1820-1895) Marx's colleague and friend who aided Marx in the establishment of his theories on society and continued to work on Marxist ideas after Marx's death. Engels experienced the plight of English workers through the eyes of a young industrialist. His unique perspective, published in his first major work *The Condition of the Working Class in England in 1844* (1844), allowed him to define the working-class as the origin of social action. Engels' orientation allowed him to connect heavily with Karl Marx. The two philosophers would go on to write together until Marx's death in 1883. Engels then went on to edit and reevaluate Marx's notes for futher publication. Engels is often seen as the scapegoat for the failure of

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Bloch, Maurice (1939-) Bloch is a British anthropologist and a well-known defender of French Marxism and Marxist anthropology. He is often noted as a key figure in the introduction of the revival of French Marxism to British Social Anthropology. Ideology, cognition, and language have been at the center of Bloch's work. These are seen as indicators of the differential distribution of power within a structured system.

Wolf, Eric (1923-1999) He was a Marxist who proposed three modes of production in his prominent work *Europe and the People Without History* (1982): capitalist, tributary, and kin-ordered. Wolf was a significant figure in the field of Anthropology. As a student of Julian Steward, Wolf was exposed to Marxism early in his academic career. Wolf would go on to critique Western history for over emphasizing the role of aristocratic figures and underplaying the history and dynamic nature of non Western and subordinate cultures. The academic divisions within the social sciences was evaluated as being a false division, as well, that denied the complexity of humanity. In this sense, Wolf saw Marx as being a true anthropologist by evaluating capitalism in a holistic sense.

Gramsci, Antonio(1891-1937) One of the leading figures in Marxism prior to World War II and an Italian communist who formulated the idea of hegemony. He is considered one of the greatest Marixst philosophers of the 20th Century. Gramsci saw human history as being key to the Marxist agenda of social change and that nature only mattered to the point that it interacted with mankind. Here, Gramsci divided the materialist concerns of traditional Marxism from his own socialist theories. The concept of cultural hegemony was articulated by Gramsci in order to explain why the revolution had not occurred. Gramsci was imprisoned for his ideas during Mussolini's reign and died in a prison hospital.

Althusser, Louis (1918-1990) The neo-Marxists major source of inspiration in the 1960's, who took a structuralist approach to Marxism. Althusser was known for taking a critical stance on the French Marxist School and the Structural Marxist School, but selectively utilizing key theory points from both schools in order to address Marxism in economics. Althusser's career was marked by mental illness and the murder of his wife.

Godelier, Maurice (1934-) A French Marxist and proponent of economic anthropology. Godelier is a strong advocate of anthropology incorporating Marxist theory with a Structuralist bent. His work focused on understanding what modes of production, superstructure, and infrastructure would look like for non Western cultures. Critics of this French Marxism claimed that Godelier tried to force a capital structure onto the history of non Western peoples who had not been capitalist societies before contact with the West.

Key Works:

The Communist Manifesto (1848) -- The best known of Marx and Engels' works and one of the most eloquent calls to action ever published. The Communist Manifesto lays out Marxism's basic economic theories, shows the basic struggle between classes, and recommends action against the 'specter' of capitalism.

Das Kapital or *Capital* (1867) --One of Marx's most complete and mature works, the aim of Capitol is to show how the capitalist system is exploitative in that it "transfers the fruit of the work of the majority...to a minority" and questions why this condition continues. Marx's solution to this problem is ideology, which blinds the workers to the truth of their plight.

Ancient Society (1877) -- In this anthropological classic, Lewis Henry Morgan takes a Social Evolution approach to understanding changes in material culture. This would become a deeply influential text to Marx and Engels as it verified the central role that material goods play in developing a centralized economy and the subsequent emphasis that emerges on private property. This work would become the basis for Engels' *The Origin...*

The Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State (1884) --Engels most influential work in anthropology, it presents the evolution of humankind from primitive communism, to slavery, feudalism, capitalism, and finally, industrial communism which would transcend the classes of the prior three stages.

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technological sphere with the understanding that demystification at the level of the ideological sphere can only occur with a clear understanding of the impact of the technology on individuals. The value of labor is articulated here as the physical energy of the individual.

Perspectives in Marxist Anthropology (1973) -- This collection of essays by Maurice Godelier investigates the potential applications of a Marxist analysis to precapitalist cultures. By looking at economic systems as historically contingent with the modes of production, Godelier saw the aspects of culture and society that related to economic change as multifunctional traits. These traits shifted in response to the needs of the developing economy and must be studied as scientific objects. This is then applied to what had been called "primitive" cultures.

The Modern World-System Vols I-IV (beginning in 1974) -- In this series, Wallerstein charts the origins of the world system. World Systems theory proposes interconnectivity between nations in the form of some locations being at the center of the line of production (core), while others are more peripheral (periphery or semi-periphery). Wallerstein relates this global movement to the capitalist emphasis on production and the historical contingency of where and when capitalism enters peripheral locations. This shift usually occurred in response to power differentials between classes and Western/non-Western cultures. Here, the system itself is the focus of analysis, not the components.

Europe and the People Without History (1982) -- Wolf's influential critique of Western scholarship focuses on the power roles that have become ingrained in social science discourse and the lack of focus on unwritten history. While focusing on the relevant modes of production, Wolf notes that the image of cultures without written records as being unchanging before contact with European powers is detrimental. This exoticization of the 'other' robs cultures of their history and active hand in their own development. Wolf also advocates for a more holistic, interdisciplinary approach to understanding the ever spreading reach of capitalism.

Sweetness and Power: The Place of Sugar in Modern History (1986) -- Sidney Mintz reviews the history of sugar as a commodity over the last 1000 years with an emphasis on the role of labor and production. Mintz argues that "sweetness" has had a strong influence on the historical development of power relations and exchange. By focusing on sugar and its holistic relationship with society, Mintz successfully argues the Marxist ideal of an integrated approach.

Critical Medical Anthropology (1995) -- Merrill Singer and Hans Baer investigate the ways in which medical systems mirror power differentials in social classes. By looking at the intersection of the individual, economic forces, and political systems, Singer and Baer argue that current medical practices are indicative of an exchange of goods. Critical medical anthropology focuses on these violations of human rights through a careful analysis of the political economy of health disparities.

Principal Concepts:

Dialectical Materialism– This is the philosophical school of Marxism. A focus on the dialectical relationship between the historical contingency of the structure, the material production, and the community is at the center of this theoretical model.

Base and Superstructure—The base consists of the forces and relations of power that are influential to the community. The superstructure is the political, economic, and legal organization of the structure. Standing beside this superstructure is the ideological structure. This system is often cited as a flaw in Marxism and seen as a kind of political economy determinism.

Labor—This is productive labor, that work which is needed to sustain production and go beyond the level of the immediate producer. Labor is the sum of the work of the individual through the means of labor and the subject of labor. Labor disappears in the product, as the result is the value.

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Forces of Production— The things we use to produce what we need, including the **means of production** and **labor** (including both physical and mental capacities). Meaning this is the combination of the power of labor, the technology of tools used, and the raw materials being converted.

Relations of Production— The relationships that individuals are forced to develop to survive within a capitalist driven system and to produce and reproduce their means. These relationships vary between the individuals of the bourgeoisie and the proletariat. Control of the **relations of production** comes from ownership of the **means of production**. They also exist between the individual and the forces of their economic connections (i.e., the connection of the bourgeoisie to capital).

Mode of Production— The way in which all required aspects of everyday life are produced. The mode of production is dictated by the **relations of production** and the **forces of production**. The forces of production determine the general mode of production, but only within the confines of the relations of production. When the relations of production conflict with the forces of production, change must occur to the mode of production. This forced change usually happens when the forces of production advance beyond the locus of control for the current version of the relations of production, i.e., a class struggle will occur in response to a disconnection between relation and force. This will continue until the mode of production meets the needs of both.

Immediate Producer— The immediate producers are those who produce what they themselves consume and more/surplus. The surplus production is that which is in excess of the immediate producer's consumption. The product is never the property of the producer, however. The product is the property of the capitalist.

Class—Classes are groups consisting of those individuals who share means of production to the forces of production. Class divides societies because some possess the relations of production through ownership of the means of production and some do not. The rise of private property and the state is the source of these class distinctions. Dialectical materialism states that these class distinctions lead to social solidarity through a collective consciousness.

Communism—Communism is a classless society in which individuals control their own labor through a shared structure of general production, there is no private property (beyond personal affects), and all hold in common the means of production.

Methodologies:

Marx did not leave a clear methodological framework for his philosophy. One of the basic methods of Marxist anthropology is to try to find classes in societies around the world, and examine the ways in which they interact. Marx, himself, focused on this kind of ethnographic research by developing individual case studies. When a political order based on class is found which seems to lack class conflict, special attention is paid. Attention has also been paid to the ways in which cultures resist the spread of capitalism. It has often been felt that Marxism is particularly suited to ferreting out the hidden resistance present in religion and ideology. Marxism is of course dedicated to examining the modes of production present in any society, and there may be more than one present. The dialectical method is also an important concept in Marxism, which is built on the examination of contradictions between classes, ideas, etc.. When well-applied, the Marxist framework can be used to examine the developments of some societies at various scales. However, there is no one unifying method or vision in Marxism. This is complicated by discussions of "Marxist", "Marxian", and "Marxism" as differing concepts (Maquet, 1984).

Accomplishments:

Marxism formed the basis for the anthropologies, and indeed, the governments, of both China and the Soviet Union/Russia. The idea that the most successful groups seeking a communist life would be societies with a peasant class capable of understanding the benefits of sharing resources fit well here. The peasant class of Russia was seen by Marx as the ideal breeding ground for communism. However, the resulting Soviet Union

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Communism (in the USSR sense). The impact of being labeled “red” kept many Western Marxist anthropologists in the closet until after the end of McCarthyism.

Marxism in anthropology has served to raise a number of questions in anthropological reasoning. It has resulted in several other approaches in anthropology, including cultural materialism and cultural ecology. The flag of Marxism was carried by **Leslie White** (1900-1975) when he focused **American Cultural Materialism** on the technological sphere of cultures and its influence on the creation of the structure and the ideology of cultures. In other words, White identified the mode of production, its relation of production, and the ways in which the dominant powers utilize mystification to control production and labor (Peace, 2004). **Cultural Ecology** was championed by **Julian Steward** (1902-1972). Steward looked at the material concerns of mankind in relation to the environment. Marx had always made a point of noting that humans are a part of the natural world. With this in mind, Steward looked at the connections between environment and possible modes of production.

It has also added to the efforts of feminist anthropology and has had a number of influences on archaeology, an essentially materialist endeavor. **Feminist Post-Marxism** is drawn on heavily by **Judith Butler** (1956-). Here, **Feminist and Queer Anthropology** see the linguistic differentiation between genders as an example of a power struggle imposed by structure. Butler extrapolates further to indicate that utilizing this kind of language is a performance act, per Marx’s ideas of recreation of social structure in everyday encounters and Michel Foucault’s subjugation theory. The link between gender, sexuality, language, and class power has also been explored by **Sally McConnell-Ginet**. Her analysis of the impact of diagnostic terminology and terminology of social solidarity in gender and sexuality indicates that dominate class views are deeply pervasive in language (McConnell-Ginet, 2002).

The **French Marxist** school of thought brought together Marxist philosophy, Levi-Strauss’ Structuralism, and what would become known as Post Modernism. The post WWII developments included the Existentialist Marxism of **Jean Paul Sartre** (1905-1980), the rejection of total history by **Michel Foucault** (1926-1984), and the Structural Marxism of Althusser. French Marxism collapsed after the protests of 1968 and the failure of the revolution.

In recent years, Marxism has been evaluated as being something of a passé model for theory and has been overlooked in many areas. Anthropology, however, has maintained an air of Marxism due to the tendency for anthropologists to maintain a social justice orientation. NeoMarxism has become more pervasive under the name of **Political Economy**. Contemporary Political Economy focuses on the tangible disparities between differing socioeconomic groups due to political influences. The works of Wolf, **Andre Gunder Frank** (1929-2005), **Immanuel Wallerstein** (1930 -), and the more recent work of **Noam Chomsky** (1928 -) all relate to Political Economy and Hegemony, while selectively pulling from Marx and Gramsci. Since the publication of *Building a New Biocultural Synthesis: Political-Economic Perspectives on Human Biology* (Goodman & Leatherman, 1998), the connections between class disparities, health statuses, and access to resources have been clear to applied biocultural anthropologists. The political economy of language has become a notable area of inquiry, including the ways in which language is a tool for economic exchange (Irvine, 1989). The lasting legacy of Marx is this increased awareness of the broader impact of class structures.

Criticisms:

One of the main criticisms of Marxism is that it is not particularly anthropological in nature, not being interested in culture and ethnography. Marx, however, completed many case studies on the successes and failures of specific cultures and social groups in creating his philosophy When anthropologists did apply it in a more anthropological framework, it looked less and less like Marxism. Marxism has been restricted by its inability "to deal with culture as a distinct and irreducible order of signs and meanings". One criticism of Marxists themselves is that they have often "built their work on unacknowledged Marxist assumptions about the importance of class and inequality in social life without properly confronting either the strengths or the weaknesses of Marxist theory". A major criticism is that Marxism has no particular unified aim or method; many Marxists argue more among themselves than with other theorists. Marxism has also been criticized on

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stronger connections than has class. When viewed independently, this critique makes sense. No aspect of culture operates in isolation, however, meaning that aspects such as kinship, religion, and ethnicity can be aspects of class within a culture. Other terms in Marxism have also been criticized, such as the labor theory of value, which states that the value of work is the cost of materials and labor involved, a definition which assumes voluntary cooperation of laborers and does not include management costs and responsibilities. Today, Marxism is criticized for overemphasizing the reach of capitalism. It is still debated as to whether or not capitalism has truly had a pervasive impact on society.

Comments:

Marxism has taken many forms other than those originally outlined by Marx and Engels; communism has as well. Within Marx's lifetime, he was presented with his own name being used as a popular catchall for radical view points. It is said that Marx declared "if this is Marxism, then I am not a Marxist" in a personal communication concerning the French political party divisions. Much of the criticism of Marxism today is related to the vastly different versions of Marxism that have proliferated and assumptions about what he did and did not intend.

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Relevant Web Links:

- The basics of Marxism
- Marxists Internet Archives
- The Communist Manifesto on Project Gutenberg
- The Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State on Project Gutenberg
- Ancient Society on Google Books
- The Evolution of Culture on Google Books
- Open Anthropology Cooperative thread on NeoMarxism; started by Phillip Carl Salzman

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